VisionGuard: AI vs Real Image Classification and Deployment

MLOps Assignment 2 · L230518_A2_Ops

Front matter

Name	Muhammad Rahim
Roll number	L230518
Project name	L230518_A2_Ops (GitHub, DagsHub, model registry, Vercel project l230518-a2-ops-api)
GitHub	https://github.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops
DagsHub	https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops (data, experiments, model registry)
MLflow tracking	https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops.mlflow
Model API (Vercel)	https://l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app (`GET /health`, `POST /predict` with `X-API-Key`)
Web app	Runs on localhost (`docker compose up`) and calls the cloud API, as Task 7 requires
Graded commit	`eb73a05924cd0c721e5345ffe7d85f2ded98bca6` (all code, model pipeline and evidence; the only later commit records this hash in the report)

Disclosure of AI assistance. - **Claude Code (Anthropic), used as a coding assistant in VS Code.** It helped me: - write and debug the Flask app, model API, Dockerfiles, Compose file, CI workflow, tests and Grad-CAM script; - plan the cloud deployment; - draft and structure this report from my terminal output and screenshots. - **My own work:** I ran every command, training run, experiment and deployment myself. I took the screenshots and checked every number in the report against my own outputs. - **Other sources:** - the official TensorFlow/Keras, MLflow, DagsHub, DVC, Docker, Vercel and LiteRT documentation; - the Kaggle dataset page.

Chapter 1: Data understanding and versioning

1.1 Environment

What I did. - I created an isolated virtual environment (`python -m venv venv`) with Python 3.12.10 and installed TensorFlow 2.21.0, Keras 3.15.1, MLflow 3.17.2, DVC 3.67.1, DagsHub, Keras Tuner 1.4.8, pandas, scikit-learn, Pillow and Flask. - I froze the exact versions into `requirements.txt` (`pip freeze`).

Why. A venv keeps the project's dependency versions separate from other projects. Freezing the list makes the training environment reproducible.

Result. `tf.config.list_physical_devices('GPU')` returns `[]`. TensorFlow ≥ 2.11 has no GPU support on native Windows (it needs WSL2), so all training ran on the CPU (Figure 1.1).

What went wrong. `pip freeze > requirements.txt` in PowerShell 5.1 writes UTF-16. Linux `pip` inside Docker can't read that, so I later re-saved the file as UTF-8.

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
>> python -c "import tensorflow as tf; print(tf.__version__); print(tf.config.list_physical_devices('GPU'))"
>> python --version
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792924237.227969   16364 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792924246.434173   16364 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
2.21.0
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11. Even if CUDA/c
uDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
[]
Python 3.12.10
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 1.1 – Python, TensorFlow version and GPU check

1.2 Dataset audit

What I did. `scripts/audit.py` walks `data/`. For every file it records: - class (taken from the folder name); - file size, width, height, colour mode and format (read with Pillow); - SHA-256 of the file's bytes.

The full table is `reports/audit.csv`. A file that fails `Image.open().verify()` counts as corrupt. Rows that share a hash are exact duplicates.

Results (Figures 1.2a–b):

	AI	Real
Images	**539**	**435**
Width min / median / max (px)	225 / 1024 / 6000	183 / 940 / 8495
Height min / median / max (px)	135 / 800 / 4001	158 / 720 / 7091
File size min / median / max	11.7 KB / 199.8 KB / 5.6 MB	11.3 KB / 145.0 KB / 10.2 MB

- **Corrupt files:** 0.
- **Exact duplicates:** 1. I kept one copy, so the same image can't land in both train and test.
- **Colour modes:** RGB 895, RGBA 49, P (palette) 23, L (greyscale) 7.
- **Formats:** JPEG 831, PNG 143.
- **Split:** stratified 70/15/15 with seed 42:

Split	Images	AI	Real
Train	681	377	304
Validation	146	81	65
Test	146	80	66

The split lists are in `splits/*.csv`, with path, label and hash.

Interpretation. - The classes are mildly imbalanced (55% AI), so accuracy alone is misleading. I also report precision, recall, F1 and ROC-AUC. - The colour modes are mixed. The input pipeline therefore forces 3 channels, which drops alpha and expands greyscale.

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python scripts/audit.py
files found: 974
0 / 974

=== counts per class ===
class
ai      539
real    435
dtype: int64

=== min / median / max ===
class                    ai        real
width      min         225.0       183.0
           median     1024.0       940.0
           max        6000.0      8495.0
height     min         135.0       158.0
           median      800.0       720.0
           max        4001.0      7091.0
file_size  min       11738.0     11311.0
           median   199760.0    144982.0
           max     5626183.0  10195352.0

corrupt files: 0
exact duplicates: 1

modes:
 mode
RGB     895
RGBA     49
P        23
L         7
```

Figure 1.2a – audit output: counts and size statistics

```
modes:
 mode
RGB     895
RGBA     49
P        23
L         7
Name: count, dtype: int64

formats:
 format
JPEG    831
PNG     143
Name: count, dtype: int64

unknown-class files: 0
train 681 {1: 377, 0: 304}
val 146 {1: 81, 0: 65}
test 146 {1: 80, 0: 66}
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python scripts/eda.py
done
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 1.2b – colour modes, formats and split sizes

1.3 Visual EDA

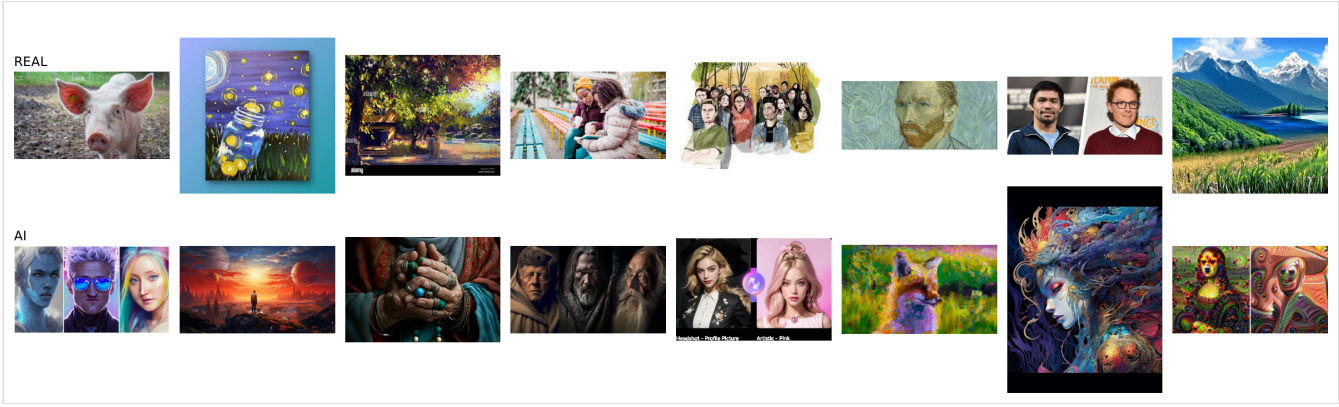


Figure 1.3a – random samples per class (top real, bottom AI)

Figure 1.3a shows random samples from each class. - The "real" class is not only photographs. It also contains paintings, drawings, collages and stock-photo grids. - The AI class leans toward saturated, smooth, "digital-art" portraits and fantasy scenes.

So the model can partly learn *style* instead of *generation artefacts*, and real paintings are likely to be confused with AI art.

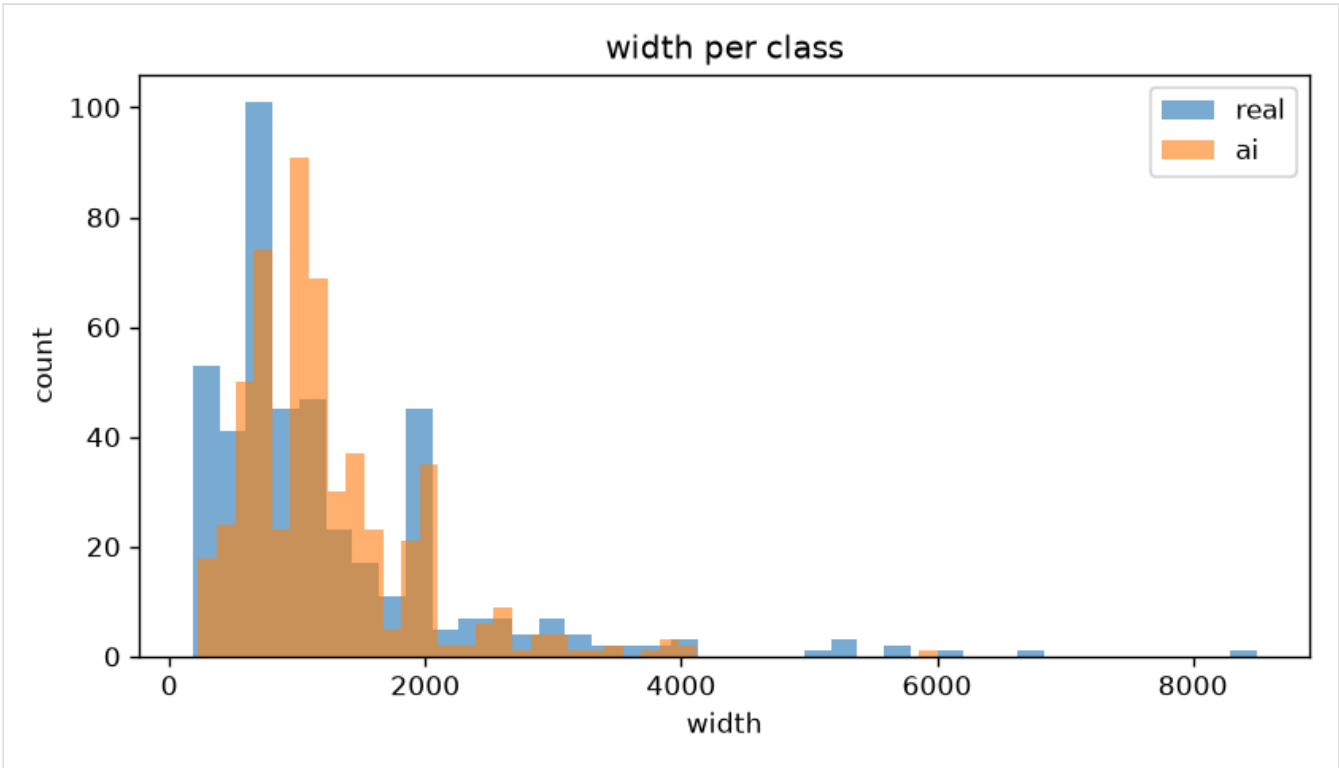


Figure 1.3b – width per class

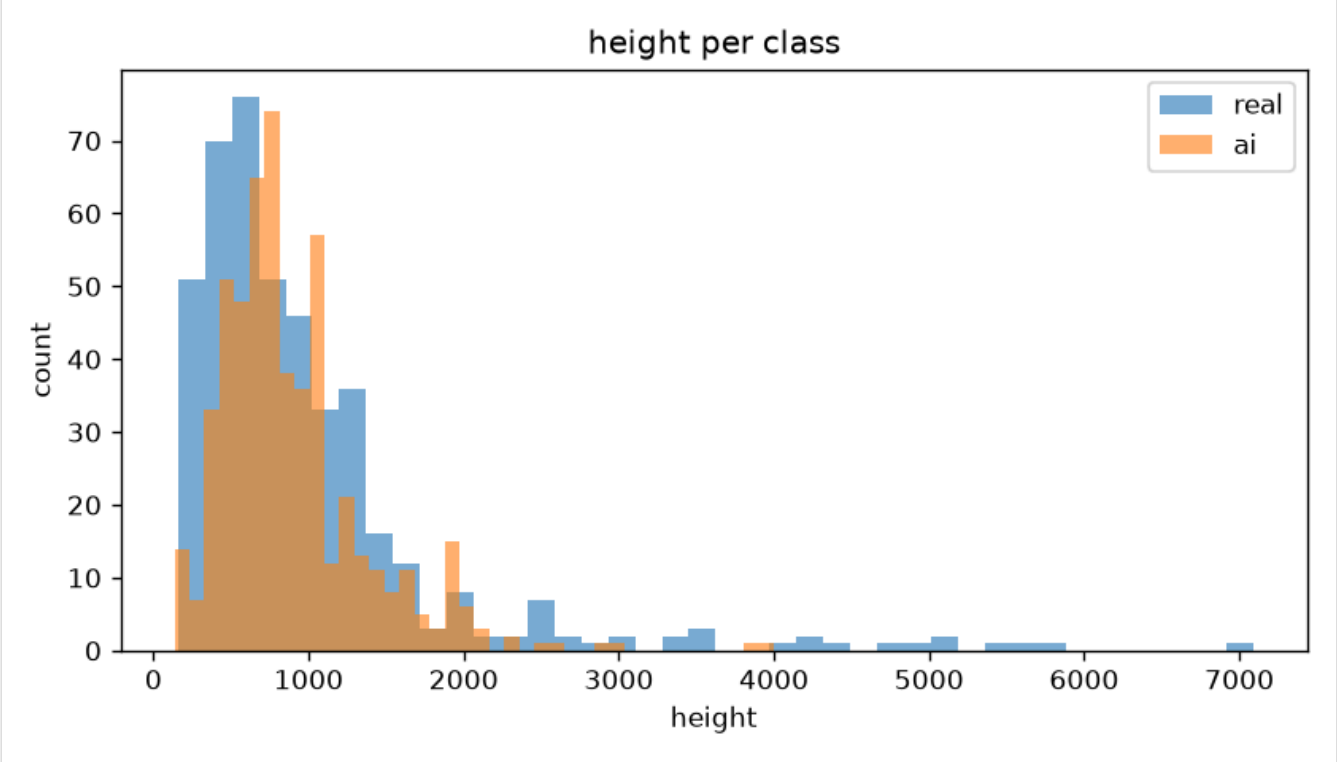


Figure 1.3c – height per class

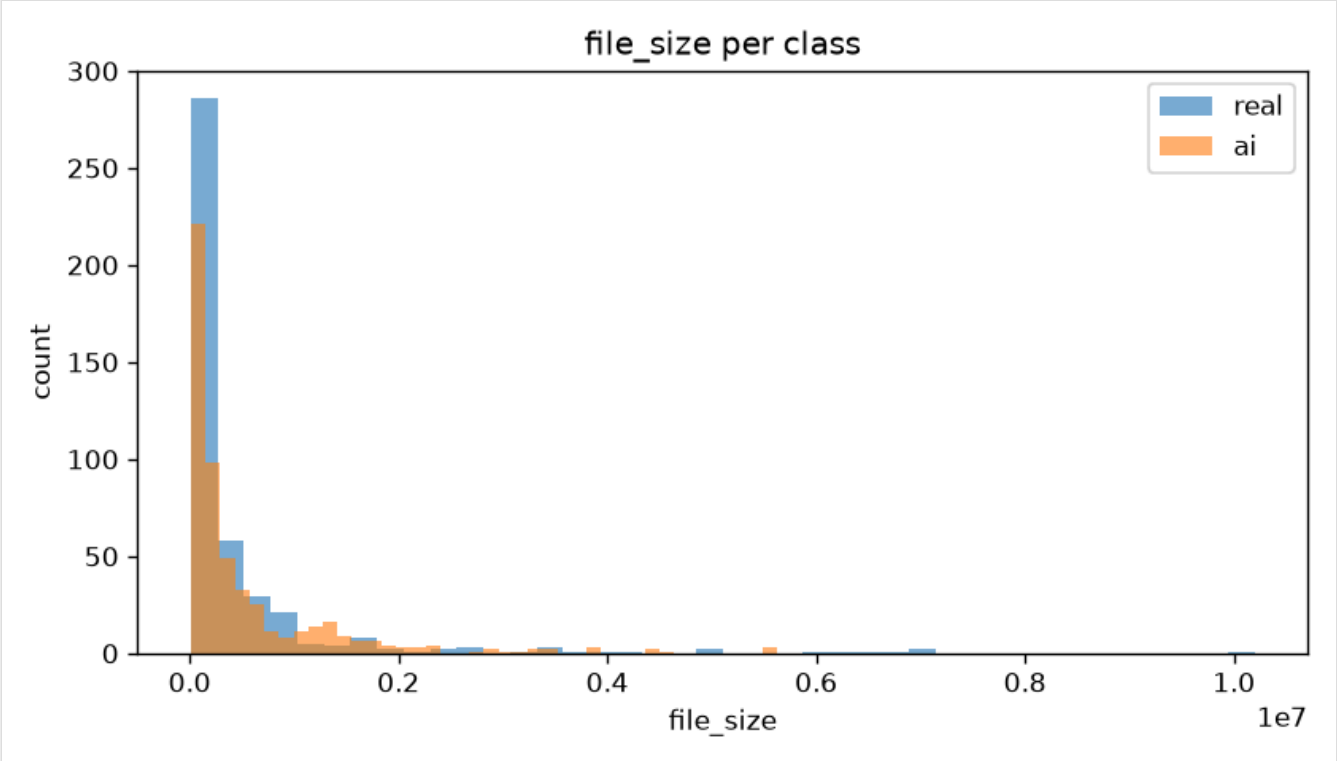


Figure 1.3d – file size per class

Figures 1.3b–c (width and height). - Both classes peak below 2000 px. - AI images cluster at generator-native sizes around 1024 px (and 512/2048). - Real images spread wider, with a long tail up to 8495 px.

Size alone carries a weak class signal. Resizing everything to 224×224 removes it, which is good, because a classifier should not depend on resolution.

Figure 1.3d (file size). Real files have the heavier tail (camera JPEGs up to 10 MB), while AI files are more uniform. This decided the upload limit for the web app: 5 MB, which covers about 99% of the data.

1.4 DVC (data version control)

Toy part (folder `dvc_toy`, Figures 1.4a–h). These are the steps, in order: 1. `git init` and `dvc init`. 2. Create a 3-row `data.csv`, then `dvc add data.csv`. This creates the pointer `data.csv.dvc` and adds `data.csv` to `.gitignore`. Then commit (v1). 3. Append a row, run `dvc add` again and commit (v2). 4. `git checkout HEAD~1 -- data.csv.dvc` followed by `dvc checkout` brought back the **3-row** version. `git checkout HEAD -- data.csv.dvc` and `dvc checkout` returned the 4-row version. 5. Add a local folder remote (`dvc remote add -d localremote …`) and `dvc push`. 6. Delete `data.csv` **and** `.dvc/cache`, then `dvc pull`. The pull printed "1 file fetched and 1 file added", so the file was restored from the remote. 7. Push the Git history to DagsHub (`Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops_toy`). DagsHub shows `data.csv` as a DVC-tracked file next to its pointer.

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github> mkdir dvc_toy
>> cd dvc_toy
>> git init
>> dvc init
>> git commit -m "init git and dvc"
>>
>> @"
>> id,name,score
>> 1,ali,50
>> 2,sara,60
>> 3,omar,70
>> "@ | Out-File -Encoding ascii data.csv
>>
>> dvc add data.csv
>> type data.csv.dvc
>> git add data.csv.dvc .gitignore
>> git commit -m "track data.csv v1"
>>
>> Add-Content data.csv "4,hina,80"
>> dvc add data.csv
>> git add data.csv.dvc
>> git commit -m "data.csv v2 (added a row)"
>> git log --oneline
>>
>> # go back to the old version
>> git checkout HEAD~1 -- data.csv.dvc
>> dvc checkout
>> type data.csv        # should show only 3 rows
>>
>> # come back to the newest version
>> git checkout HEAD -- data.csv.dvc
```

Figure 1.4a – toy commands

```
>> dvc checkout
>> type data.csv        # 4 rows again
>>
>> # remote storage (local folder), push, delete, pull
>> dvc remote add -d localremote "C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\dvc_toy_remote"
>> git add .dvc/config
>> git commit -m "add local remote"
>> dvc push
>> Remove-Item data.csv
>> Remove-Item -Recurse -Force .dvc\cache
>> dvc pull
>> dir


    Directory: C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github


Mode                 LastWriteTime         Length Name
----                 -------------         ------ ----
d-----        10/25/2026   3:54 PM                dvc_toy
Initialized empty Git repository in C:/Users/It Zone/Desktop/Github/dvc_toy/.git/
Initialized DVC repository.

You can now commit the changes to git.

+---------------------------------------------------------------------+
```

Figure 1.4b – toy commands (remote, push, delete, pull)

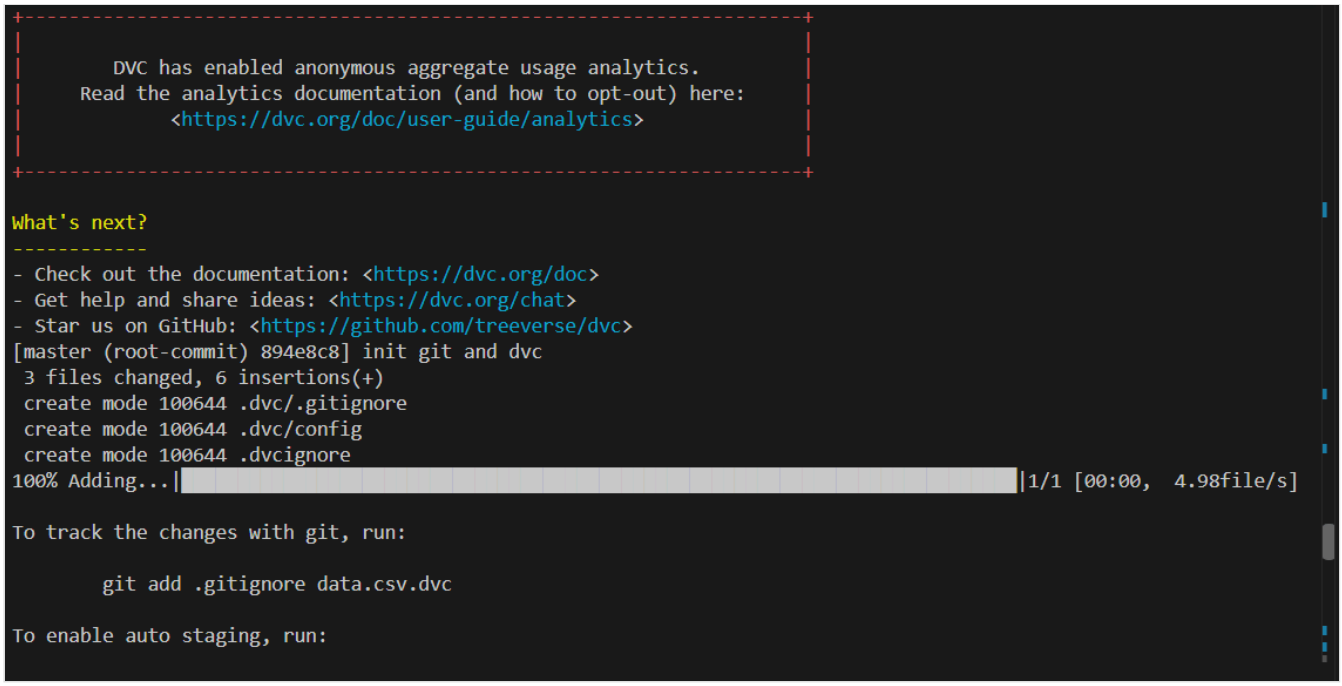


Figure 1.4c – init output

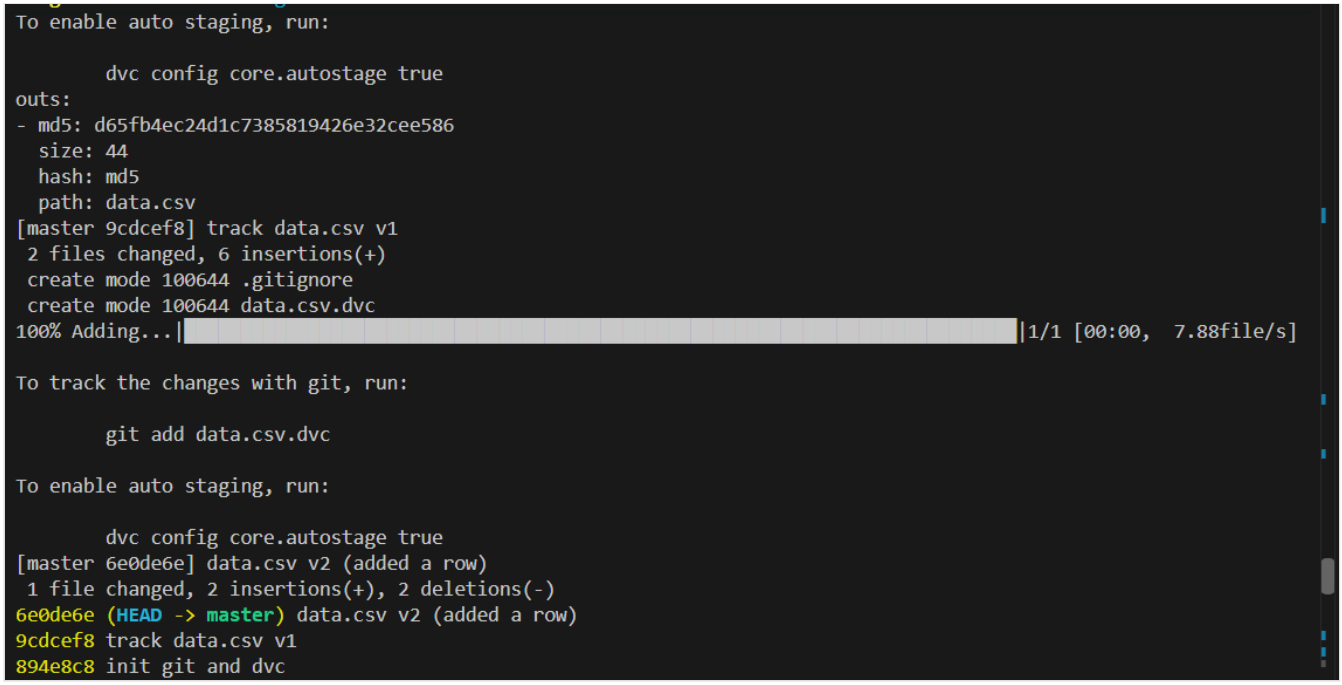


Figure 1.4d – pointer file content and v1/v2 commits

```
1 file changed, 2 insertions(+), 2 deletions(-)
6e0de6e (HEAD -> master) data.csv v2 (added a row)
9cdcef8 track data.csv v1
894e8c8 init git and dvc
Building workspace index                                                |1.00 [00:00, 23.9entry/s]
Comparing indexes                                                       |2.00 [00:00, 2.00kentry/s]
Applying changes                                                        |1.00 [00:00,   125file/s]
M       data.csv
id,name,score
1,ali,50
2,sara,60
3,omar,70
Building workspace index                                                |1.00 [00:00, 30.9entry/s]
Comparing indexes                                                       |2.00 [00:00,  983entry/s]
Applying changes                                                        |1.00 [00:00,   131file/s]
M       data.csv
id,name,score
1,ali,50
2,sara,60
3,omar,70
4,hina,80
Setting 'localremote' as a default remote.
[master ed46506] add local remote
 1 file changed, 4 insertions(+)
Collecting                                                              |1.00 [00:00, 57.4entry/s]
Pushing
```

Figure 1.4e – checkout of the old version (3 rows) and back (4 rows)

```
Pushing
1 file pushed
Collecting                                                              |1.00 [00:00,  178entry/s]
Fetching
Building workspace index                                                |0.00 [00:00,    ?entry/s]
Comparing indexes                                                       |2.00 [00:00, 1.98kentry/s]
Applying changes                                                        |1.00 [00:00,  70.7file/s]
A       data.csv
1 file fetched and 1 file added


    Directory: C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\dvc_toy


Mode                 LastWriteTime         Length Name
----                 -------------         ------ ----
d-----        10/25/2026   3:55 PM                .dvc
-a----        10/25/2026   3:54 PM            142 .dvcignore
-a----        10/25/2026   3:54 PM             11 .gitignore
-a----        10/25/2026   3:55 PM             55 data.csv
-a----        10/25/2026   3:55 PM             91 data.csv.dvc
```

Figure 1.4f – push, deletion and pull restore the file

```
fatal: Authentication failed for 'https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops_toy.git/'
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\dvc_toy> git remote add origin https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_O
ps_toy.git
>> git push -u origin master
error: remote origin already exists.
Enumerating objects: 17, done.
Counting objects: 100% (17/17), done.
Delta compression using up to 8 threads
Compressing objects: 100% (14/14), done.
Writing objects: 100% (17/17), 1.47 KiB | 137.00 KiB/s, done.
Total 17 (delta 3), reused 0 (delta 0), pack-reused 0 (from 0)
To https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops_toy.git
 * [new branch]      master -> master
branch 'master' set up to track 'origin/master'.
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\dvc_toy>
```

Figure 1.4g – pushing the toy repo to DagsHub

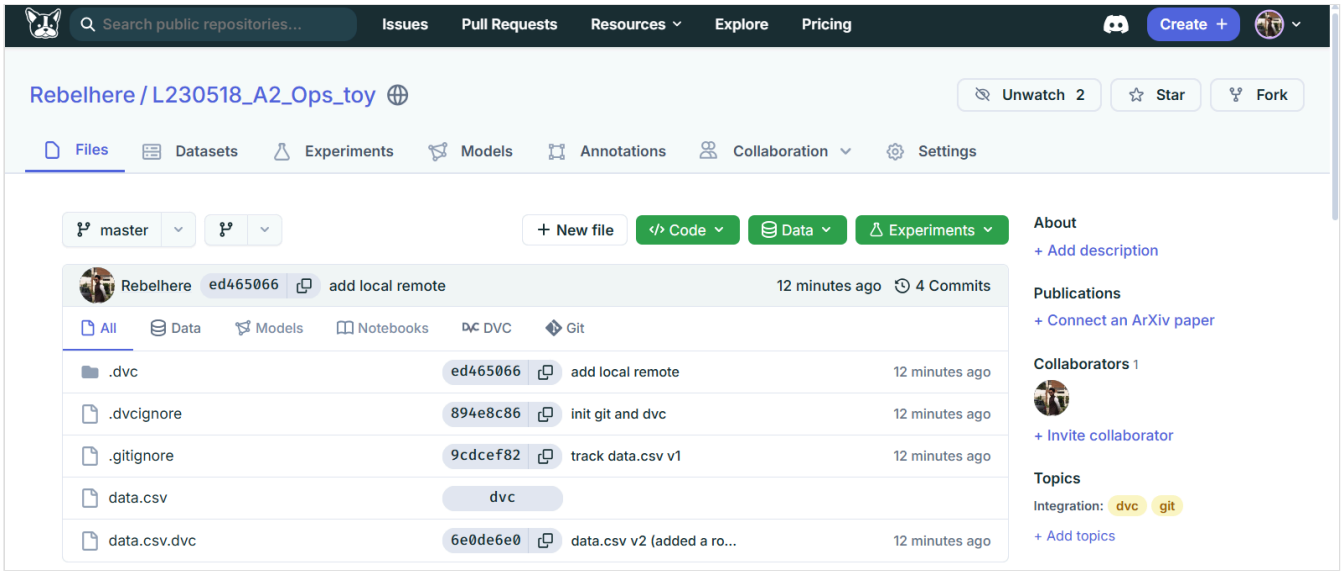


Figure 1.4h – toy repo on DagsHub

Apply. - I tracked the whole `data/` folder with `dvc add data`, using DagsHub storage as the `origin` remote. - `data.dvc` (Figure 1.4i) holds the directory hash `b2cec678….dir`, the size (503,783,378 bytes) and the file count (975). - `dvc status -c` reports "Cache and remote 'origin' are in sync" (Figure 1.4j). - DagsHub and GitHub both show `data` as DVC-managed. Only the pointer is in Git (Figures 1.4k–l).

What the pointer file holds and why large data stays out of Git. - The `.dvc` file is a few lines of YAML: a content hash (md5), a size, a file count and a path. The hash is the address of the real content in the DVC cache and remote, so the Git commit pins *exactly* which data version the code used. - Git stores every version of every file forever and diffs them as text. A 500 MB image folder would bloat every clone, slow every operation, and exceed GitHub's size limits. - DVC stores the data once per content hash in cheap object storage and keeps Git small. - Every MLflow run is tagged with this hash (`dvc_data_md5`; see Chapter 3).

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> git ls-files data.dvc
>> type data.dvc
>> git log --oneline -3
data.dvc
outs:
- md5: b2cec67839f742df4653f66d4bcbbafb.dir
  size: 503783378
  nfiles: 975
  hash: md5
  path: data
02ff0e0 (HEAD -> main, origin/main, origin/HEAD) Task 1: audit, EDA, splits, DVC-tracked dataset
0483a13 Task 1: audit, EDA, splits, DVC-tracked dataset
355e71c Initial commit
```

Figure 1.4i – data.dvc pointer for the dataset

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> dvc status -c
Cache and remote 'origin' are in sync.
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 1.4j – cache and DagsHub remote in sync

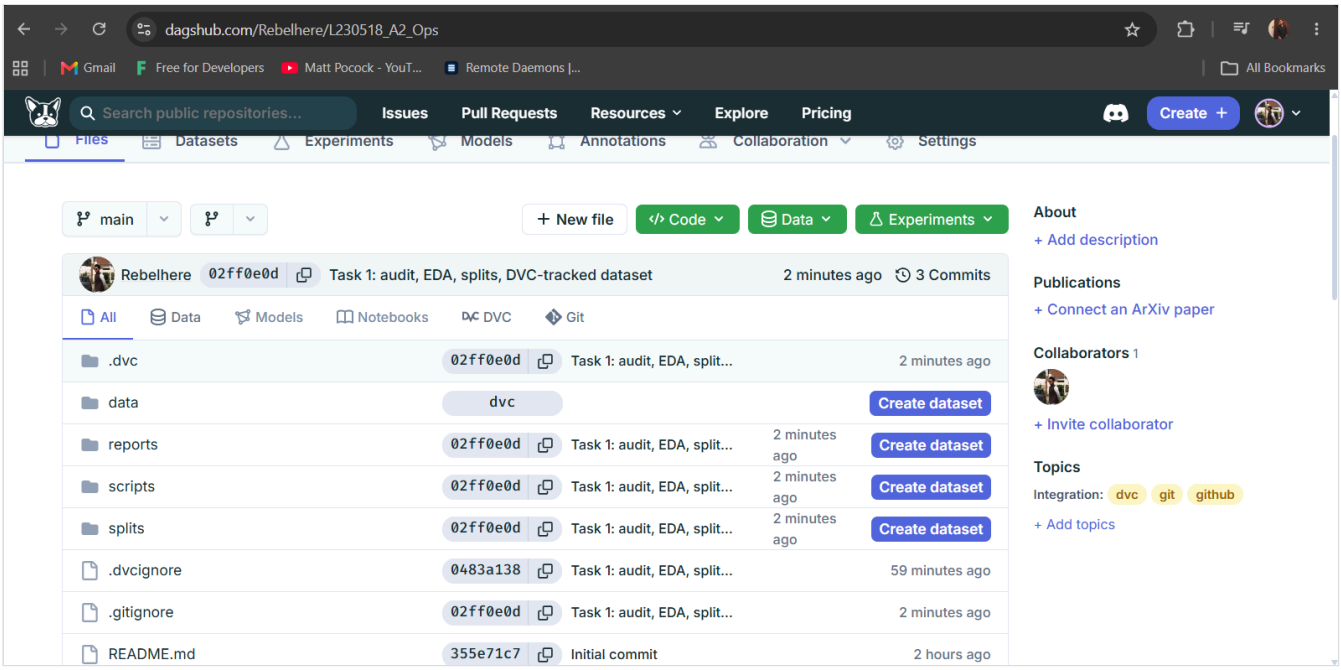


Figure 1.4k – DagsHub repository (data tracked by DVC)

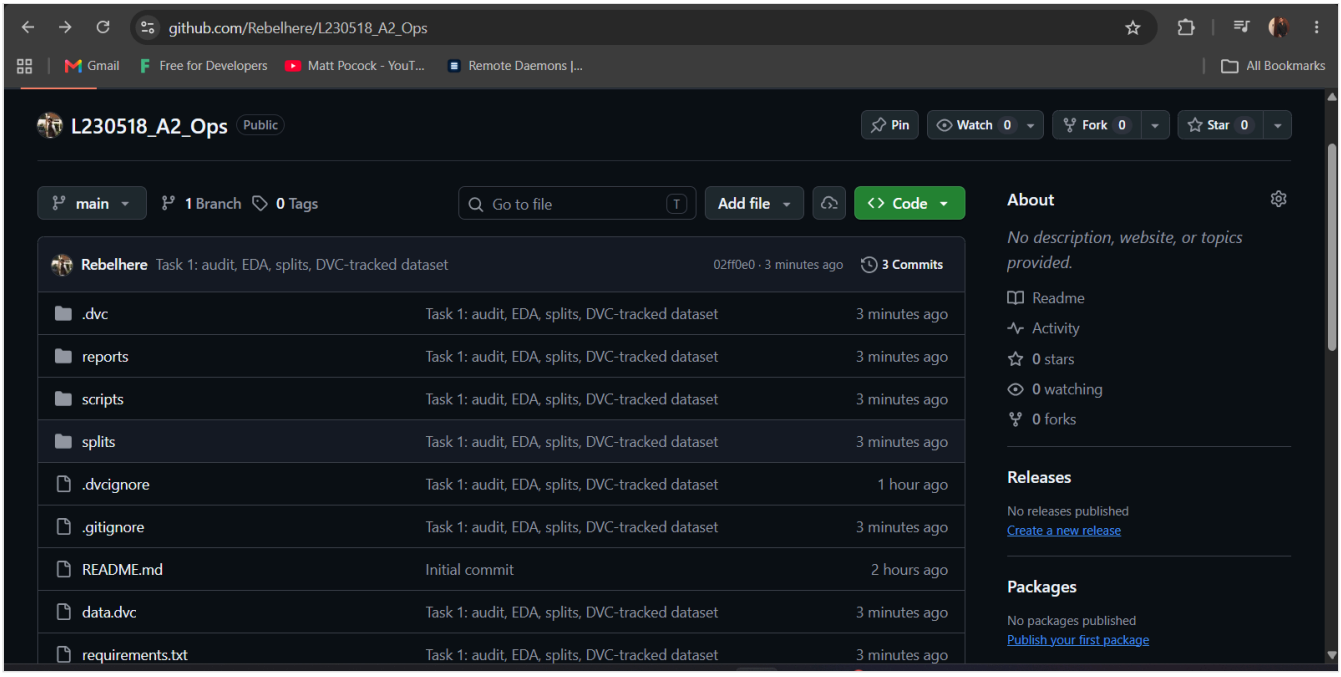


Figure 1.4l – GitHub repository

Chapter 2: Model development with TensorFlow/Keras

2.1 Input pipeline

`src/data.py::make_ds` builds a `tf.data` pipeline. The stages, in order: 1. **Read split list.** `from_tensor_slices((paths, labels))` reads the paths and labels from `splits/<split>.csv`. Only these three lists are used, so no image can leak between splits. 2. **Decode and resize.** `map(_load, AUTOTUNE)` calls `src/preprocess.py::decode_resize`: - `tf.io.decode_image(channels=3, expand_animations=False)` handles both JPEG and PNG, forces 3 channels (drops alpha, expands greyscale and palette), and takes the first frame of a GIF-like file. - `tf.image.resize` makes the image 224×224 with bilinear interpolation, as float32 values in [0, 255]. 3. **Cache.** `cache()` keeps the decoded images in memory after the first epoch. Decoding 5–10 MB JPEGs is the most expensive step. 4. **Shuffle.** `shuffle(len, seed=42, reshuffle_each_iteration=True)` runs on training data only. 5. **Augment** (training data only): `RandomFlip("horizontal")`, `RandomRotation(0.08)`, `RandomZoom(0.15)` and `RandomContrast(0.15)`. These perturbations are mild, so they don't destroy the high-frequency artefacts that separate AI images from real ones. 6. **Batch and prefetch.** `batch(32)` then `prefetch(AUTOTUNE)` lets the CPU prepare the next batch while the model trains on the current one.

Image size. - **224×224** is the native ImageNet input of MobileNetV2, so the pretrained filters see objects at the scale they were trained on. - It is also small enough for CPU training.

Aspect ratio. - `tf.image.resize` **stretches** the image; it does not keep the aspect ratio. A 1024×576 image is squeezed horizontally. - I chose stretching over crop or pad because cropping can cut off the part of the image that shows the artefact, and padding adds black borders the model could learn to use. - The same stretch is applied in serving (Chapter 4), so training and serving still agree.



Figure 2.1 – one augmented training batch

2.2 Baseline CNN

`src/models.py::build_cnn` (Figures 2.2a–c, table in `reports/cnn_layers.csv`):

Layer	Output shape	Params	Why it is there
Input	(224, 224, 3)	0	raw RGB in [0, 255]
Rescaling(1/255)	(224, 224, 3)	0	puts inputs in [0, 1] so gradients are well-scaled
Conv2D 32, 3×3 (no bias)	(224, 224, 32)	864	learns local edges and texture; no bias because BN follows
BatchNormalization	(224, 224, 32)	128	stabilises and speeds up training
ReLU	(224, 224, 32)	0	non-linearity
MaxPooling2D	(112, 112, 32)	0	halves resolution, grows the receptive field
Conv 64 + BN + ReLU + Pool	(56, 56, 64)	18,432 + 256	mid-level patterns
Conv 128 + BN + ReLU + Pool	(28, 28, 128)	73,728 + 512	higher-level patterns
Conv 128 + BN + ReLU + Pool	(14, 14, 128)	147,456 + 512	
GlobalAveragePooling2D	(128)	0	one value per channel; far fewer weights than Flatten, so less overfitting
Dropout(0.4)	(128)	0	regularisation for a small dataset (681 training images)
Dense(1, sigmoid)	(1)	129	outputs p(AI)
Total		**242,017** (241,313 trainable)	

Loss. Binary cross-entropy is the correct likelihood for a single sigmoid output with 0/1 labels.

Optimizer. Adam at lr = 1e-3 gives robust default step sizes, so it needs no hand-tuned schedule (ReduceLROnPlateau handles the rest).

Metrics. Accuracy, precision, recall and AUC. Because the classes are imbalanced and the two errors cost differently (see 2.5), accuracy alone isn't enough. AUC measures ranking quality independently of the threshold.

Problems 5 Output Debug Console Terminal Ports powershell

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.task2_demo
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792931104.040349   19420 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792931116.989117   19420 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
I0000 00:00:1792931128.247451   19420 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized to use availabl
e CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild TensorFlow with
 the appropriate compiler flags.
batch: (32, 224, 224, 3) <dtype: 'float32'> labels: (32,)
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11. Even if CUDA/c
uDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
Model: "baseline_cnn"
```

Layer (type)	Output Shape	Param #
input_layer_1 (InputLayer)	(None, 224, 224, 3)	0
rescaling (Rescaling)	(None, 224, 224, 3)	0
conv2d (Conv2D)	(None, 224, 224, 32)	864
batch_normalization (BatchNormalization)	(None, 224, 224, 32)	128
re_lu (ReLU)	(None, 224, 224, 32)	0

Figure 2.2a – CNN model summary (1)

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.task2_demo
```

re_lu (ReLU)	(None, 224, 224, 32)	0
max_pooling2d (MaxPooling2D)	(None, 112, 112, 32)	0
conv2d_1 (Conv2D)	(None, 112, 112, 64)	18,432
batch_normalization_1 (BatchNormalization)	(None, 112, 112, 64)	256
re_lu_1 (ReLU)	(None, 112, 112, 64)	0
max_pooling2d_1 (MaxPooling2D)	(None, 56, 56, 64)	0
conv2d_2 (Conv2D)	(None, 56, 56, 128)	73,728
batch_normalization_2 (BatchNormalization)	(None, 56, 56, 128)	512
re_lu_2 (ReLU)	(None, 56, 56, 128)	0
max_pooling2d_2 (MaxPooling2D)	(None, 28, 28, 128)	0
conv2d_3 (Conv2D)	(None, 28, 28, 128)	147,456
batch_normalization_3 (BatchNormalization)	(None, 28, 28, 128)	512
re_lu_3 (ReLU)	(None, 28, 28, 128)	0

Figure 2.2b – CNN model summary (2)

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.task2_demo
```

max_pooling2d_3 (MaxPooling2D)	(None, 14, 14, 128)	0
global_average_pooling2d (GlobalAveragePooling2D)	(None, 128)	0
dropout (Dropout)	(None, 128)	0
dense (Dense)	(None, 1)	129

Total params: 242,017 (945.38 KB)
Trainable params: 241,313 (942.63 KB)
Non-trainable params: 704 (2.75 KB)

	layer	type	output_shape	params
0	input_layer_1	InputLayer	(None, 224, 224, 3)	0
1	rescaling	Rescaling	(None, 224, 224, 3)	0
2	conv2d	Conv2D	(None, 224, 224, 32)	864
3	batch_normalization	BatchNormalization	(None, 224, 224, 32)	128
4	re_lu	ReLU	(None, 224, 224, 32)	0
5	max_pooling2d	MaxPooling2D	(None, 112, 112, 32)	0
6	conv2d_1	Conv2D	(None, 112, 112, 64)	18432
7	batch_normalization_1	BatchNormalization	(None, 112, 112, 64)	256
8	re_lu_1	ReLU	(None, 112, 112, 64)	0
9	max_pooling2d_1	MaxPooling2D	(None, 56, 56, 64)	0
10	conv2d_2	Conv2D	(None, 56, 56, 128)	73728
11	batch_normalization_2	BatchNormalization	(None, 56, 56, 128)	512
12	re_lu_2	ReLU	(None, 56, 56, 128)	0
13	max_pooling2d_2	MaxPooling2D	(None, 28, 28, 128)	0
14	conv2d_3	Conv2D	(None, 28, 28, 128)	147456
15	batch_normalization_3	BatchNormalization	(None, 28, 28, 128)	512

Figure 2.2c – summary end and per-layer table

2.3 Transfer learning (MobileNetV2)

`src/models.py::build_mobilenet` loads `keras.applications.MobileNetV2(include_top=False, weights="imagenet")`, which leaves out the 1000-class classifier.

Head. GAP, then Dropout(0.3), then Dense(1, sigmoid).

Preprocessing. - `mobilenet_v2.preprocess_input` maps [0, 255] to **[-1, 1]**, which is the scaling MobileNetV2 was pretrained with. Feeding [0, 1] or [0, 255] would shift every activation, and the pretrained filters would then see "wrong" inputs. - I put this step **inside the model graph**. The saved `.keras` file therefore contains it, and the serving code cannot forget it.

Stage 1 (frozen base). - `base.trainable = False`, and the base is called with `training=False` so BatchNorm stays in inference mode. - The only trainable weights are `dense_1/kernel` and `dense_1/bias`: 1,281 parameters. - Adam lr = 1e-3, up to 15 epochs.

Stage 2 (fine-tune the last block). `unfreeze_last_block` sets `trainable=True` only for the `block_16_*` layers and `Conv_1`: - `block_16_expand`, `block_16_expand_relu`, `block_16_depthwise`, `block_16_depthwise_relu`, `block_16_project` and `Conv_1`; - 880,321 trainable parameters; - BatchNorm layers stay frozen, so the small batches don't corrupt their running statistics; - recompiled with a **much smaller learning rate** (1e-5 for the first runs, 1e-4 for the best one) for up to 10 epochs.

The small learning rate lets the pretrained features shift slightly toward "AI vs real" cues without erasing what they learned from ImageNet.

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.task2_demo
14                conv2d_3                Conv2D   (None, 28, 28, 128)  147456
15    batch_normalization_3    BatchNormalization   (None, 28, 28, 128)     512
16                  re_lu_3                  ReLU   (None, 28, 28, 128)       0
17           max_pooling2d_3          MaxPooling2D   (None, 14, 14, 128)       0
18  global_average_pooling2d  GlobalAveragePooling2D          (None, 128)       0
19                   dropout               Dropout          (None, 128)       0
20                     dense                 Dense            (None, 1)     129
Downloading data from https://storage.googleapis.com/tensorflow/keras-applications/mobilenet_v2/mobilenet_v2_weight
s_tf_dim_ordering_tf_kernels_1.0_224_no_top.h5
9406464/9406464 ━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━━ 8s 1us/step

STAGE 1: base frozen. trainable weights: ['dense_1/kernel', 'dense_1/bias']
STAGE 2 trainable base layers (6): ['block_16_expand', 'block_16_expand_relu', 'block_16_depthwise', 'block_16_dept
hwise_relu', 'block_16_project', 'Conv_1']
trainable params: 880321
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 2.3a – trainable weights in stage 1 and trainable layers in stage 2

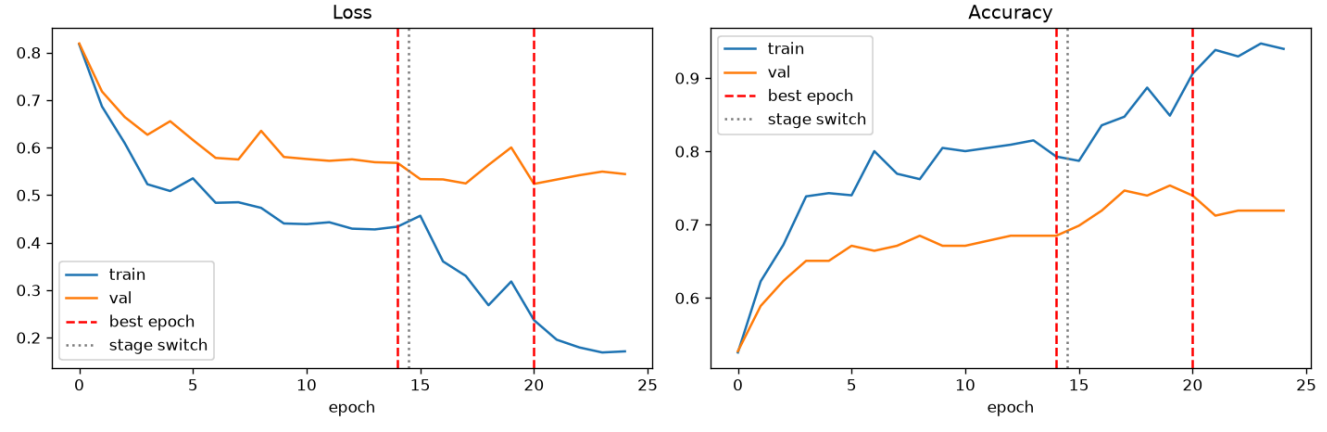


Figure 2.3b – training curves, both stages (champion run mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4); dotted line = stage switch

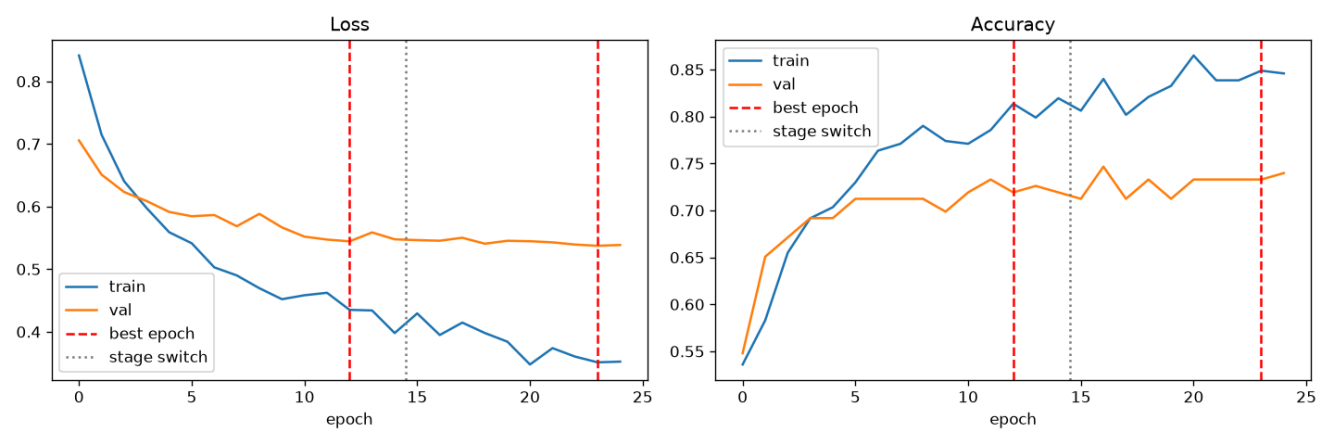


Figure 2.3c – training curves, first fine-tuned run mobilenet_manual

2.4 Training discipline

Seeds. `keras.utils.set_random_seed(42)` seeds Python, NumPy and TF, and the split and the shuffle also use seed 42.

Callbacks (`src/train.py::fit_stage`), on every stage: - `EarlyStopping(val_loss, patience=5, restore_best_weights=True)`; - `ModelCheckpoint(models/<run>_<stage>.keras, monitor=val_loss, save_best_only=True)`; - `ReduceLROnPlateau(val_loss, factor=0.3, patience=2, min_lr=1e-7)`.

Best epoch. The best epoch (lowest val_loss) of each stage is logged as `best_epoch_stage1/2` and marked with a red dashed line in the curves.

Run	Best epoch, stage 1	Best epoch, stage 2
mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 (champion)	**15** (val_loss 0.568)	**6** (val_loss 0.524)
mobilenet_manual	13 (0.544)	9 (0.537)
cnn_baseline	9 (0.655)	–

Stage 1 of the champion was still improving at the 15-epoch cap; stage 2 then lowered val_loss further. The CNN overfit after epoch 9, and early stopping restored those weights.

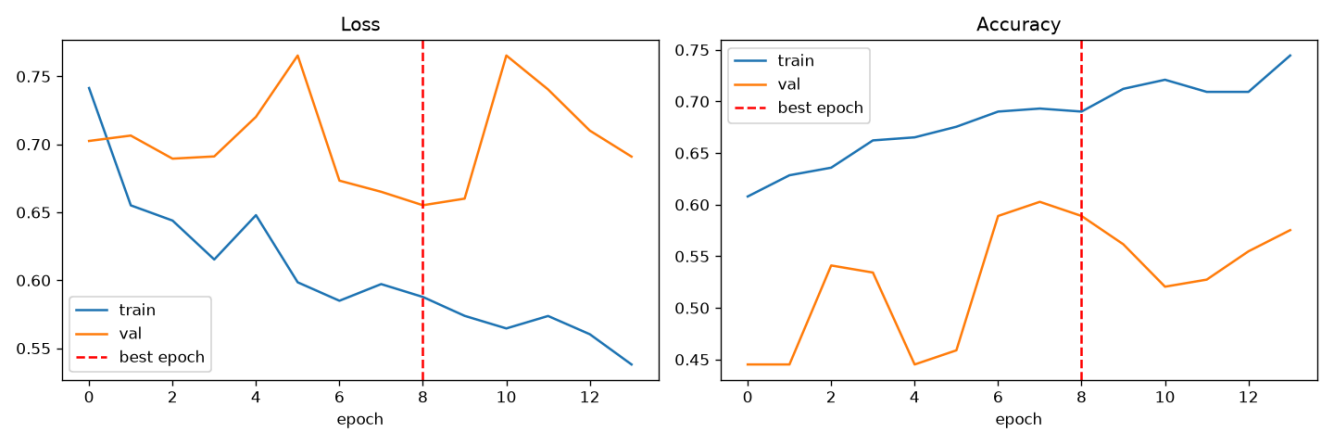


Figure 2.4 – loss and accuracy with best epoch marked (CNN baseline)

2.5 Evaluation (test set, once)

I chose the model and the threshold on **validation** data only. The test set was then used once for each of the two final models (`scripts/final_eval.py`, Figures 2.5a–c, `reports/test_results.csv`). The threshold in that run was the validation-F1-optimal one.

Model (test, n = 146)	Threshold	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1	ROC-AUC	TN	FP	FN	TP
Baseline CNN	0.364	0.582	0.571	0.950	0.714	0.669	9	57	4	76
MobileNetV2 fine-tuned	0.366	**0.788**	**0.725**	**0.988**	**0.836**	**0.870**	36	30	1	79

Transfer learning wins on every metric. The CNN's AUC of 0.67 shows that 681 images aren't enough to learn good features from scratch.

Which error is worse. - For VisionGuard, **calling a real photo fake (a false positive)** is worse. It can wrongly accuse a photographer or journalist of fabrication, damage their reputation, and get real evidence dismissed. - Missing an AI image leaves the user where they were without the tool.

Threshold choice. - The F1-optimal threshold (0.366) flags 30 of 66 real test photos as AI (FPR 45%), which is unacceptable for this product. - `scripts/threshold_table.py` and `scripts/pick_threshold.py` scan the **validation** ROC curve (Figure 2.5d). They pick the threshold with the highest AI recall subject to **FPR ≤ 20%**, which gives **t = 0.771**. - Youden's J would pick 0.836, which is even stricter.

Threshold 0.771	False-alarm rate (real → AI)	AI recall	Precision	Accuracy
Validation	0.200	0.667	0.806	0.726
Test	**0.182**	0.688	**0.821**	0.747

The test false-alarm rate (18%) matches the validation target (20%), so the threshold generalised. The deployed app uses t = 0.771, read from the `THRESHOLD` environment variable.

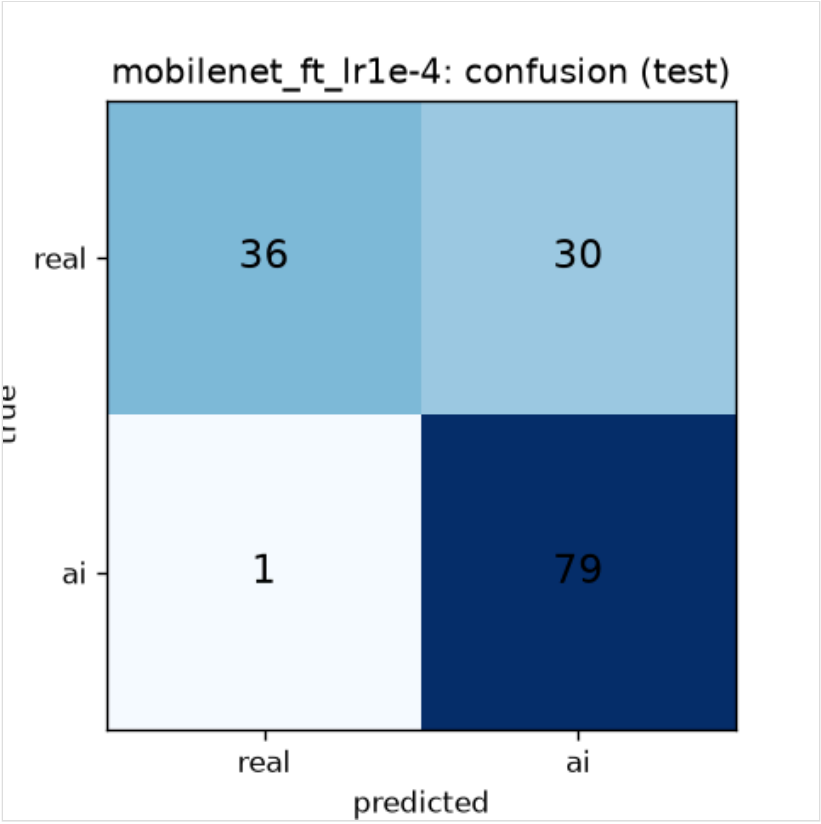


Figure 2.5a – test confusion matrix, MobileNetV2

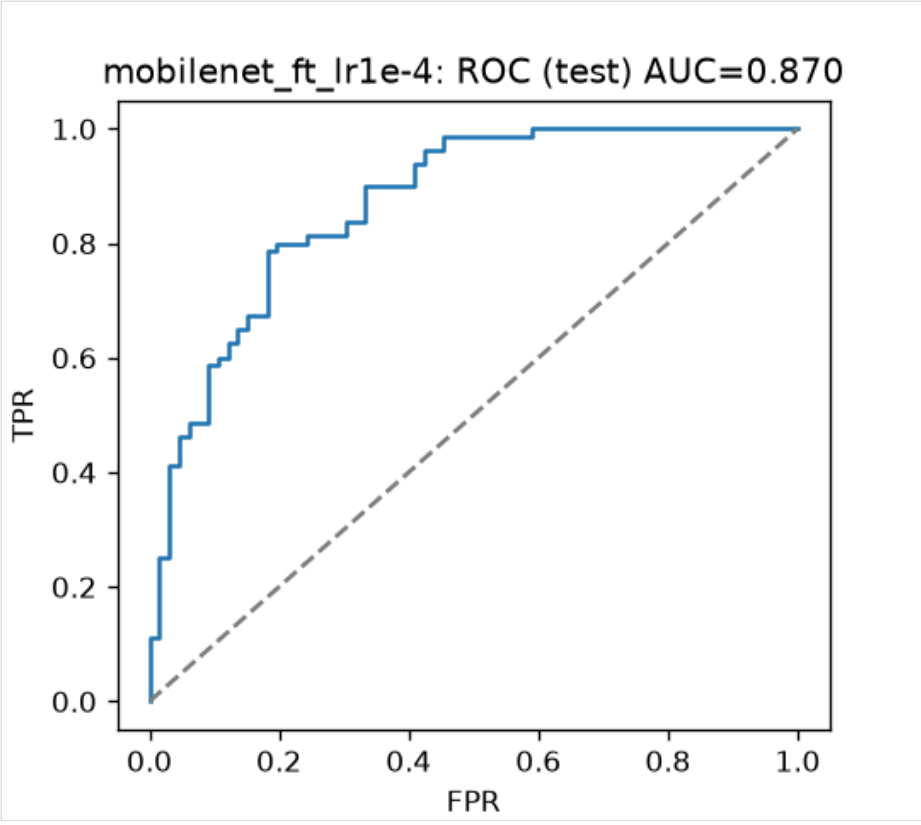


Figure 2.5b – test ROC, MobileNetV2

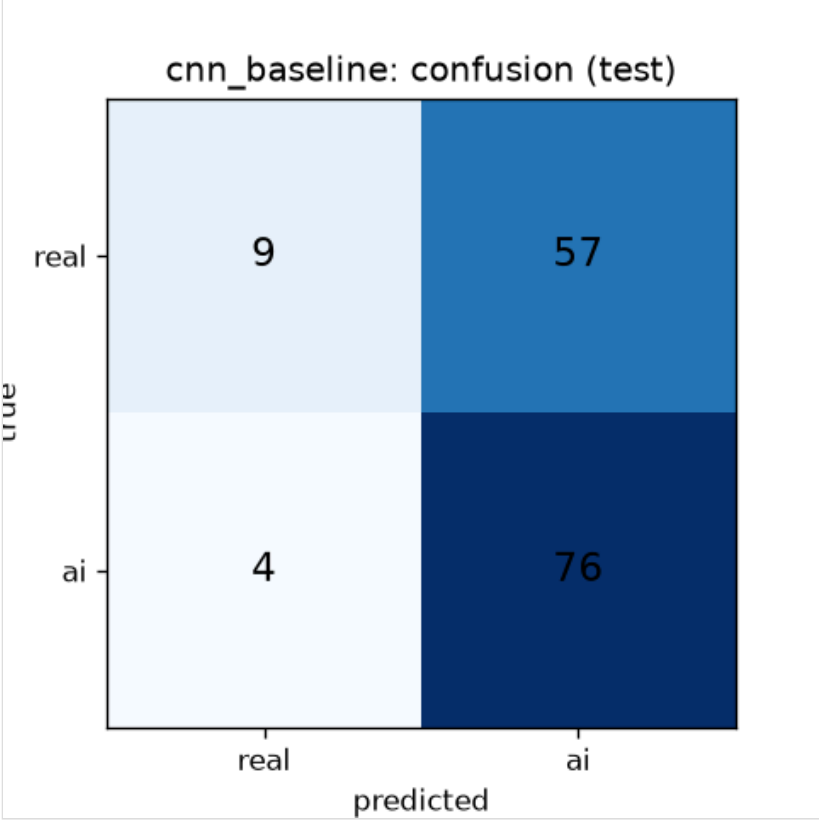


Figure 2.5c – test confusion matrix and ROC, CNN

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.threshold_table
 the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11. Even if CUDA/c
uDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
 threshold  real_called_fake_%  ai_caught_%  precision_%
     0.200               64.6         96.3         65.0
     0.300               47.7         91.4         70.5
     0.366               44.6         90.1         71.6
     0.400               43.1         88.9         72.0
     0.500               40.0         85.2         72.6
     0.600               35.4         77.8         73.3
     0.700               27.7         72.8         76.6
Youden J threshold: 0.836
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 2.5d – threshold trade-off on validation data

2.6 Error analysis

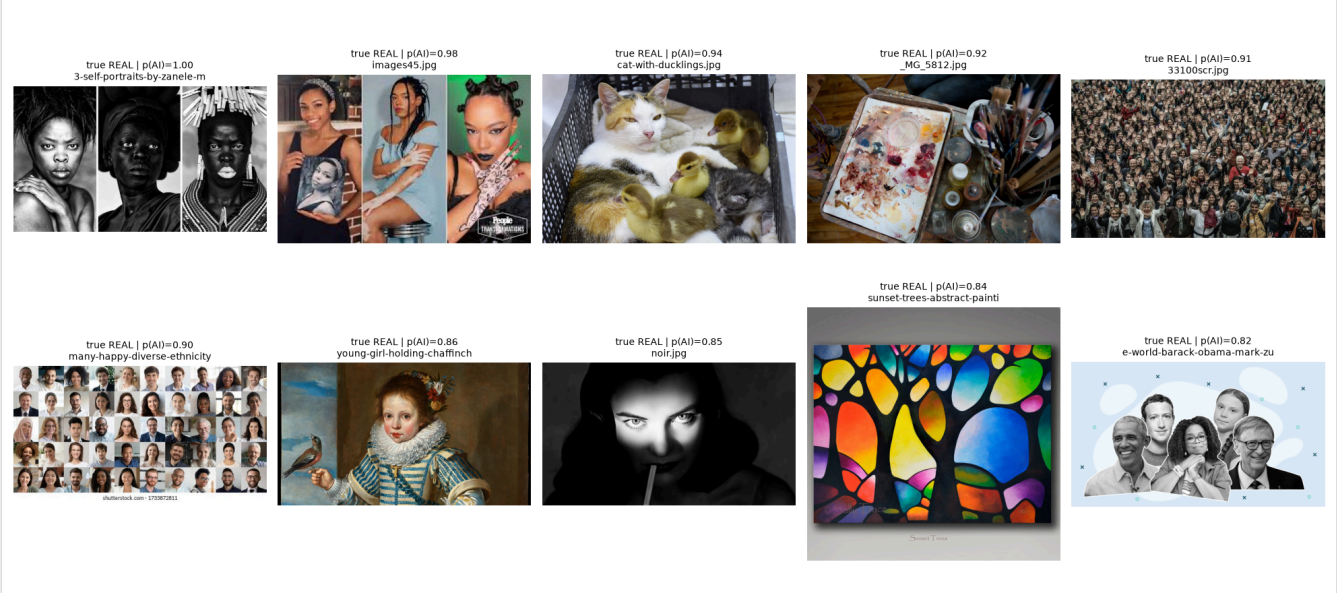


Figure 2.6 – 10 misclassified test images (all are real images flagged as AI at the F1 threshold)

All 10 errors with the highest confidence are **real images predicted as AI**:

#	Image	p(AI)	Hypothesis
1	3 B&W self-portraits (collage)	1.00	high-contrast studio B&W with smooth skin and a stylised pose looks like AI portraits; collage seams
2	3-photo collage with a "People" watermark	0.98	collage layout + heavy retouching; magazine-style beauty edits resemble AI faces
3	cat with ducklings	0.94	soft, shallow depth of field and "too cute" composition; downscaling hides sensor noise
4	painter's palette and brushes	0.92	saturated paint textures; painting-like content is common in the AI class
5	huge crowd	0.91	repeated faces / texture tiling, similar to the repetition artefacts of generators
6	stock grid of faces (shutterstock watermark)	0.90	grid of uniformly lit, retouched faces; the AI class has many portrait grids
7	painting of a girl with a chaffinch	0.86	**a painting labelled real**: style, not generation, drives the prediction
8	film-noir portrait	0.85	dramatic lighting and smooth gradients, typical of AI "cinematic" prompts
9	abstract tree painting	0.84	flat saturated colours, an artwork, not a photo
10	cut-out celebrity collage on a pastel background	0.82	graphic-design composite with clean edges and no camera noise

Conclusion. The model partly learned "artistic / retouched / composite → AI". This is a dataset bias: the real class contains paintings and edited stock images. It is why the deployed threshold was raised to 0.771, and why the result page carries a caveat about paintings and edited photos.

2.7 Tool lab: Keras Tuner

Toy part (`scripts/toy_tuner.py`). - RandomSearch with 8 trials on Fashion-MNIST (10k training images, 2k validation, 5 epochs). - Search space: `units` ∈ {32, ..., 256} and `lr` ∈ [1e-4, 1e-2] on a log scale.

units	lr	val_accuracy
256	**1.7e-3**	**0.855**
128	3.1e-4	0.845
128	3.5e-4	0.841
256	1.2e-4	0.839
160	1.4e-4	0.837
256	1.5e-4	0.837
192	1.2e-4	0.833
256	5.1e-4	0.827

The best settings (read with `get_best_hyperparameters`) are 256 units and lr ≈ 1.7e-3. For a 5-epoch budget, the learning rate matters more than width: the four slowest learning rates are near the bottom of the table.

Apply (`scripts/tune_visionguard.py`). - A `kt.HyperModel` wraps `build_mobilenet` and searches three things: - `dropout` ∈ {0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5}; - `lr` ∈ [1e-4, 1e-3] on a log scale; - `unfrozen_layers` ∈ {0, 10, 30, 60}, the number of last base layers fine-tuned at lr/10. - RandomSearch ran **8 trials** with the objective of maximising `val_auc` (6 head epochs + 4 fine-tune epochs, early stopping).

dropout	lr	unfrozen layers	val AUC
0.3	**1.75e-4**	**60**	**0.773**
0.3	3.53e-4	0	0.751
0.3	1.87e-4	60	0.748
0.4	1.10e-4	30	0.745
0.3	8.20e-4	0	0.741
0.2	2.03e-4	10	0.725
0.4	2.79e-4	10	0.709
0.3	1.09e-4	0	0.582

Which setting mattered most. - **The number of unfrozen layers, together with the learning rate.** With 0 unfrozen layers, the results range from 0.58 to 0.75 depending only on lr. The worst trial (lr 1.1e-4, frozen) simply had not converged in 6 epochs. - Unfreezing 60 layers gave the two best AUCs (0.773 and 0.748). - Dropout between 0.2 and 0.4 had no consistent effect.

This agrees with my manual runs (3.5): fine-tuning more of the network with a moderate learning rate helped most.

Why choosing the best validation score can overfit the validation set. - The validation set has only 146 images, and one image is worth about 0.7 percentage points of accuracy. - Over many trials, some configurations win partly by luck on those particular images. Taking the maximum selects that luck, which is a **winner's curse**: the best trial's validation score is optimistically biased. - Trials 1 and 3 had almost the same settings (60 layers, lr 1.8e-4 vs 1.9e-4) but AUCs of 0.773 and 0.748, so the noise is about the size of the gaps between trials. - This is why the **test set is used only once**, after all choices are made, and why the reported performance comes from the test set, not from the best validation score.

```
>> python -m scripts.tune_visionguard
>> git add .gitignore scripts reports
>> git commit -m "Keras Tuner toy and VisionGuard search"
>> git push origin main
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792949671.696185    4388 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see sli
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792949684.911101    4388 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see sli
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
I0000 00:00:1792949696.025347    4388 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized
 to use available CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild
 TensorFlow with the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11
. Even if CUDA/cuDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectM
L plugin.

Search: Running Trial #1
```

Figure 2.7a – toy search starting (trial 1)

```
Value             |Best Value So Far |Hyperparameter
192               |192               |units
0.00011943        |0.00011943        |lr

WARNING:tensorflow:From C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops\venv\Lib\site-packages\keras
\src\backend\common\global_state.py:82: The name tf.reset_default_graph is deprecated. Please use t
f.compat.v1.reset_default_graph instead.

Epoch 1/5
313/313 - 3s - 10ms/step - accuracy: 0.6663 - loss: 1.0550 - val_accuracy: 0.7585 - val_loss: 0.720
4
Epoch 2/5
313/313 - 2s - 7ms/step - accuracy: 0.7871 - loss: 0.6464 - val_accuracy: 0.8000 - val_loss: 0.5985
Epoch 3/5
313/313 - 1s - 5ms/step - accuracy: 0.8116 - loss: 0.5606 - val_accuracy: 0.8180 - val_loss: 0.5457
Epoch 4/5
313/313 - 1s - 5ms/step - accuracy: 0.8280 - loss: 0.5139 - val_accuracy: 0.8285 - val_loss: 0.5164
Epoch 5/5
313/313 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8376 - loss: 0.4827 - val_accuracy: 0.8330 - val_loss: 0.4967

Trial 1 Complete [00h 00m 14s]
val_accuracy: 0.8330000042915344
```

Figure 2.7b – toy trial 1: units 192, lr 1.2e-4 → val_accuracy 0.833

```
val_accuracy: 0.8330000042915344

Best val_accuracy So Far: 0.8330000042915344
Total elapsed time: 00h 00m 14s

Search: Running Trial #2

Value             |Best Value So Far |Hyperparameter
128               |192               |units
0.00034974        |0.00011943        |lr

Epoch 1/5
313/313 - 3s - 9ms/step - accuracy: 0.7145 - loss: 0.8528 - val_accuracy: 0.8025 - val_loss: 0.6036
Epoch 2/5
313/313 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8111 - loss: 0.5467 - val_accuracy: 0.8240 - val_loss: 0.5238
Epoch 3/5
313/313 - 2s - 6ms/step - accuracy: 0.8344 - loss: 0.4830 - val_accuracy: 0.8350 - val_loss: 0.4889
Epoch 4/5
313/313 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8485 - loss: 0.4457 - val_accuracy: 0.8395 - val_loss: 0.4693
Epoch 5/5
313/313 - 1s - 5ms/step - accuracy: 0.8550 - loss: 0.4189 - val_accuracy: 0.8410 - val_loss: 0.4560
```

Figure 2.7c – toy trial 2 and the running best

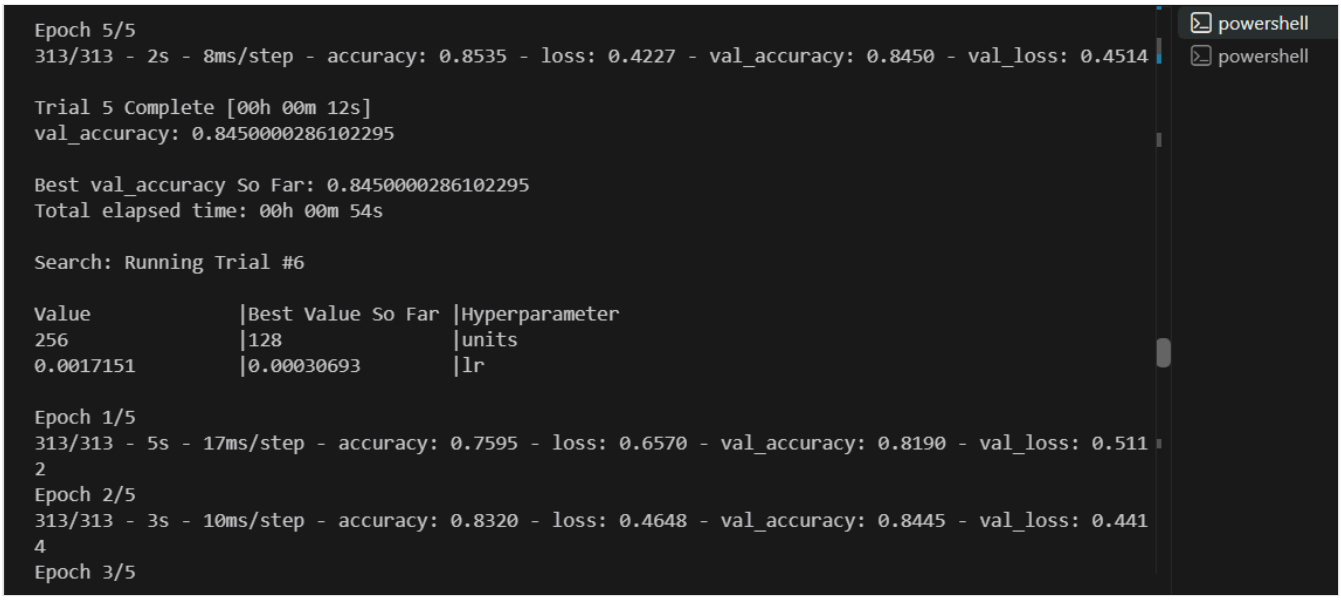


Figure 2.7d – toy trial 6: units 256, lr 1.7e-3 (the eventual best)

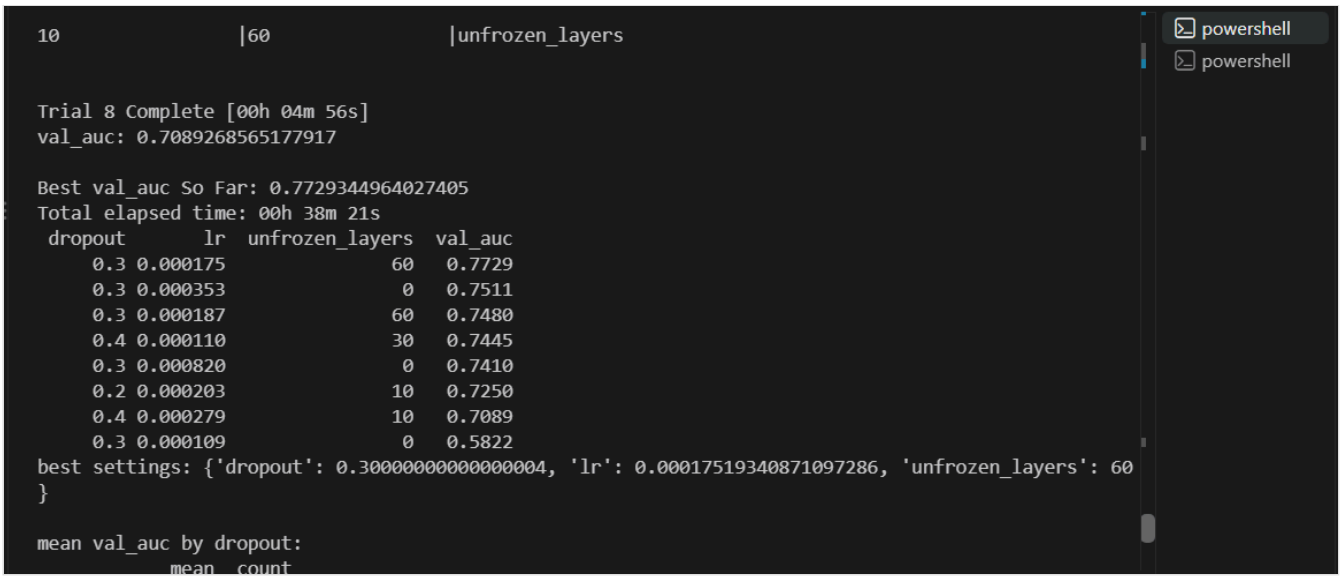


Figure 2.7e – VisionGuard search: 8 trials ranked, best settings

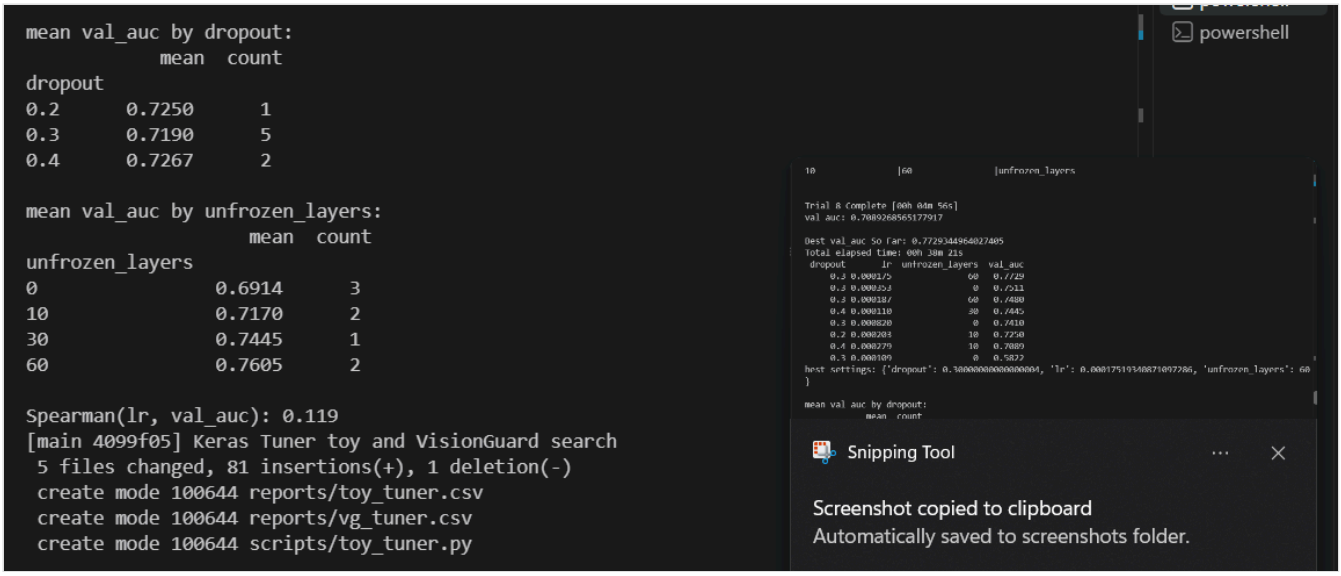


Figure 2.7f – mean val AUC by dropout and by unfrozen layers; Spearman(lr, AUC) = 0.12

The grouped means in Figure 2.7f back up the conclusion above: - **AUC rises steadily with the number of unfrozen layers:** 0.691 (0) → 0.717 (10) → 0.745 (30) → 0.761 (60). - **Dropout barely matters:** 0.719–0.727. - **Learning rate on its**

own correlates only weakly with AUC (Spearman 0.12) inside the searched range.

So the **number of unfrozen layers mattered most**.

Bonus: Grad-CAM

`scripts/gradcam.py` computes Grad-CAM from the last convolutional block of MobileNetV2 (7×7×1280) for 4 correct and 4 wrong test predictions at t = 0.771.

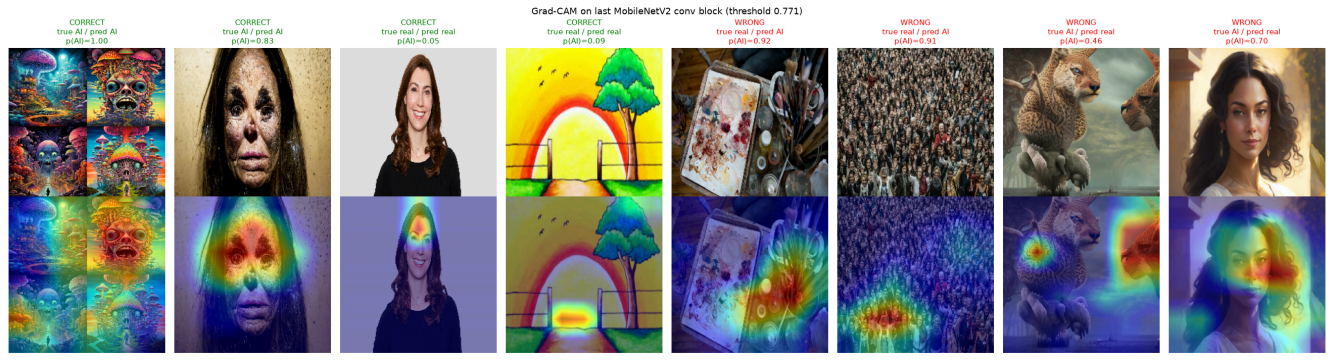


Figure 2.8 – Grad-CAM: top = image, bottom = heat map (red = most influence on p(AI))

What the model looks at. - **Correct AI cases.** On the psychedelic collage, the heat sits on the over-detailed face with its saturated, repeated textures. On the weathered-face portrait, it covers the eyes and the unnaturally uniform skin "cracks". These are plausible generator artefacts. - **Correct real cases.** For the studio headshot, the evidence for AI is weak and centred on the face, so p = 0.05. For the child-style drawing, it sits on a small region at the bottom. - **Real images flagged as AI.** - On the paint palette (p = 0.92), the model focuses on the dense, colourful *paint texture* in the corner, not on any photographic flaw. - On the crowd photo (0.91), it focuses on the repeated pattern of tiny faces at the bottom.

Both confirm the hypothesis from 2.6: busy, saturated, repetitive *texture* is read as "AI". - **AI images missed.** - On the leopard (0.46), the attention spreads over the fur and the background, and nothing stands out. - On the photorealistic portrait (0.70, just under the 0.771 threshold), the attention is on the face, but the face is clean enough to pass as real.

Conclusion. - The model mostly uses **texture and colour statistics in salient regions** (faces, dense patterns). It is not keying on watermarks or borders, which is good. - Texture is also its weakness: real artworks and crowded scenes trigger it, and clean photorealistic AI faces escape it.

What went wrong. - My first Grad-CAM version rebuilt the forward pass layer by layer. In Keras 3, `preprocess_input` is stored as a graph op inside the saved model, **not** as a layer in `model.layers`, so the rebuild skipped the [-1, 1] scaling. The heat maps looked plausible, but the probabilities were wrong (0.24 instead of 0.999 for the same image). - I found it by comparing against the inference module's output. I now re-apply `preprocess_input` and `assert` that Grad-CAM's p(AI) equals `model(x)` for every image. This was a small, real example of the training/serving-skew problem discussed in 4.1.

Chapter 3: Experiment tracking with MLflow and DagsHub

3.1 Tool lab: MLflow locally

What I did. - `scripts/toy_mlflow.py local` trains a small dense network on Fashion-MNIST twice, with lr = 0.01 and lr = 1e-4. It logs to a local SQLite store (`sqlite:///toy.db`). - Each run logs three parameters (`lr`, `units`, `epochs`), per-epoch metrics, one plot (`loss_curve.png`), the Keras model, and the tags `stage=toy` and `target=local`. - `mlflow ui --backend-store-uri sqlite:///toy.db` opened the UI. I compared the two runs in the parallel-coordinates view (Figures 3.1a–h).

Result. lr = 0.01 reached accuracy 0.854 / val 0.824 in 5 epochs; lr = 1e-4 reached 0.791 / val 0.798. The small learning rate is still under-trained after 5 epochs.

Definitions (my own words): - **Experiment**: a named folder that groups runs trying to solve the same problem (`toy-fashion-mnist`, `VisionGuard`). - **Run**: one execution of the training code, with a unique id, start time, status and source commit. - **Parameter**: an input I chose before the run that does not change during it (learning rate, dropout). It is logged once. - **Metric**: a number measured *by* the run, possibly many times with a step (val_loss per epoch, final test F1). - **Artifact**: any output file stored with the run (plots, split lists, `pip_freeze.txt`, the model). - **Tag**: free-form key/value metadata about the run (git commit, data hash, seed, "manual" vs "autolog"). It is used to search and filter runs.

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.toy_mlflow local
>> mlflow ui --backend-store-uri sqlite:///toy.db
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792931661.618052   16668 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792931671.375143   16668 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different
numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set t
he environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
2026/10/25 17:34:38 INFO mlflow.store.db.utils: Creating initial MLflow database tables...
2026/10/25 17:34:38 INFO mlflow.store.db.utils: Updating database tables
2026/10/25 17:34:45 INFO mlflow.tracking.fluent: Experiment with name 'toy-fashion-mnist' does not exist. Creating
a new experiment.
I0000 00:00:1792931686.858393   16668 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized to use availabl
e CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild TensorFlow with
 the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11. Even if CUDA/c
uDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
Epoch 1/5
157/157 - 2s - 14ms/step - accuracy: 0.7482 - loss: 0.7207 - val_accuracy: 0.8075 - val_loss: 0.5148
Epoch 2/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8209 - loss: 0.4926 - val_accuracy: 0.8305 - val_loss: 0.4679
Epoch 3/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8359 - loss: 0.4439 - val_accuracy: 0.7975 - val_loss: 0.5627
Epoch 4/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8479 - loss: 0.4098 - val_accuracy: 0.8260 - val_loss: 0.4710
Epoch 5/5
157/157 - 1s - 5ms/step - accuracy: 0.8541 - loss: 0.3926 - val_accuracy: 0.8240 - val_loss: 0.4864
```

Figure 3.1a – both toy runs trained locally

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\IT Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.toy_mlflow local
>> mlflow ui --backend-store-uri sqlite:///toy.db
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8209 - loss: 0.4926 - val_accuracy: 0.8305 - val_loss: 0.4679
Epoch 3/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8359 - loss: 0.4439 - val_accuracy: 0.7975 - val_loss: 0.5627
Epoch 4/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.8479 - loss: 0.4098 - val_accuracy: 0.8260 - val_loss: 0.4710
Epoch 5/5
157/157 - 1s - 5ms/step - accuracy: 0.8541 - loss: 0.3926 - val_accuracy: 0.8240 - val_loss: 0.4864
2026/10/25 17:34:52 WARNING mlflow.models.model: `artifact_path` is deprecated. Please use `name` instead.
2026/10/25 17:34:52 WARNING mlflow.keras.save: You are saving a Keras model without specifying model signature.
Epoch 1/5
157/157 - 2s - 12ms/step - accuracy: 0.5330 - loss: 1.6050 - val_accuracy: 0.6500 - val_loss: 1.1333
Epoch 2/5
157/157 - 1s - 4ms/step - accuracy: 0.7032 - loss: 0.9602 - val_accuracy: 0.7250 - val_loss: 0.8554
Epoch 3/5
157/157 - 1s - 3ms/step - accuracy: 0.7507 - loss: 0.7874 - val_accuracy: 0.7560 - val_loss: 0.7417
Epoch 4/5
157/157 - 0s - 3ms/step - accuracy: 0.7741 - loss: 0.7022 - val_accuracy: 0.7815 - val_loss: 0.6760
Epoch 5/5
157/157 - 1s - 3ms/step - accuracy: 0.7909 - loss: 0.6489 - val_accuracy: 0.7975 - val_loss: 0.6326
2026/10/25 17:35:27 WARNING mlflow.models.model: `artifact_path` is deprecated. Please use `name` instead.
2026/10/25 17:35:27 WARNING mlflow.keras.save: You are saving a Keras model without specifying model signature.
done -> local
Registry store URI not provided. Using backend store URI.
[MLflow] Security middleware enabled with default settings (localhost-only). To allow connections from other hosts,
 use --host 0.0.0.0 and configure --allowed-hosts and --cors-allowed-origins.
2026/10/25 17:35:56 WARNING mlflow.server: MLflow job execution requirements not met (MLflow job backend does not s
upport Windows system.). Server will start without job execution support. Errors will be surfaced at job invocation
 time.
2026/10/25 17:35:57 INFO:     Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:5000 (Press CTRL+C to quit)
```

Figure 3.1b – second run and the MLflow UI starting

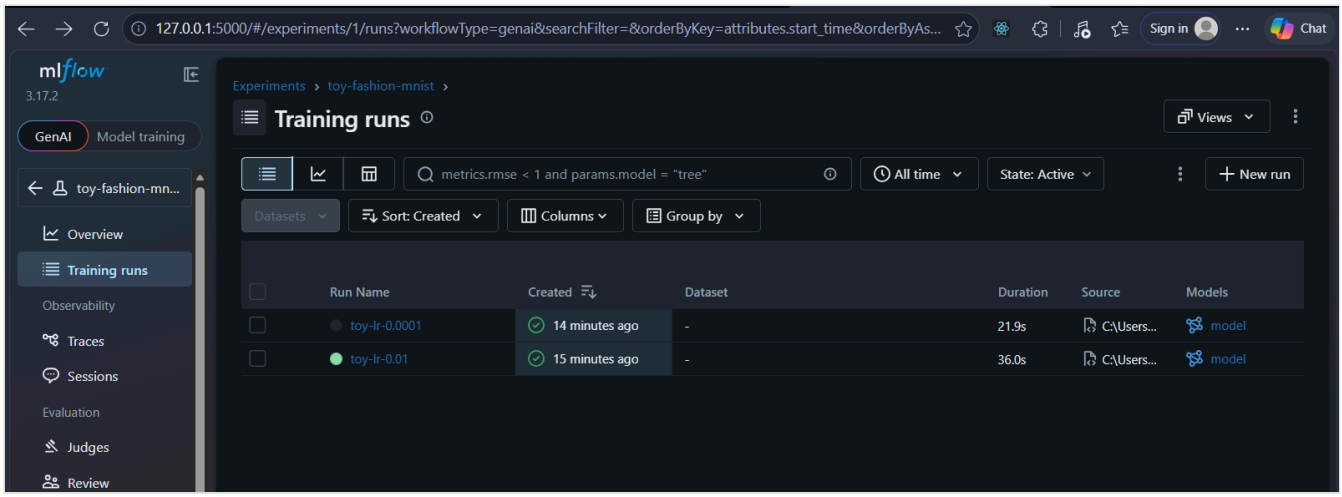


Figure 3.1c – the two runs in the local UI

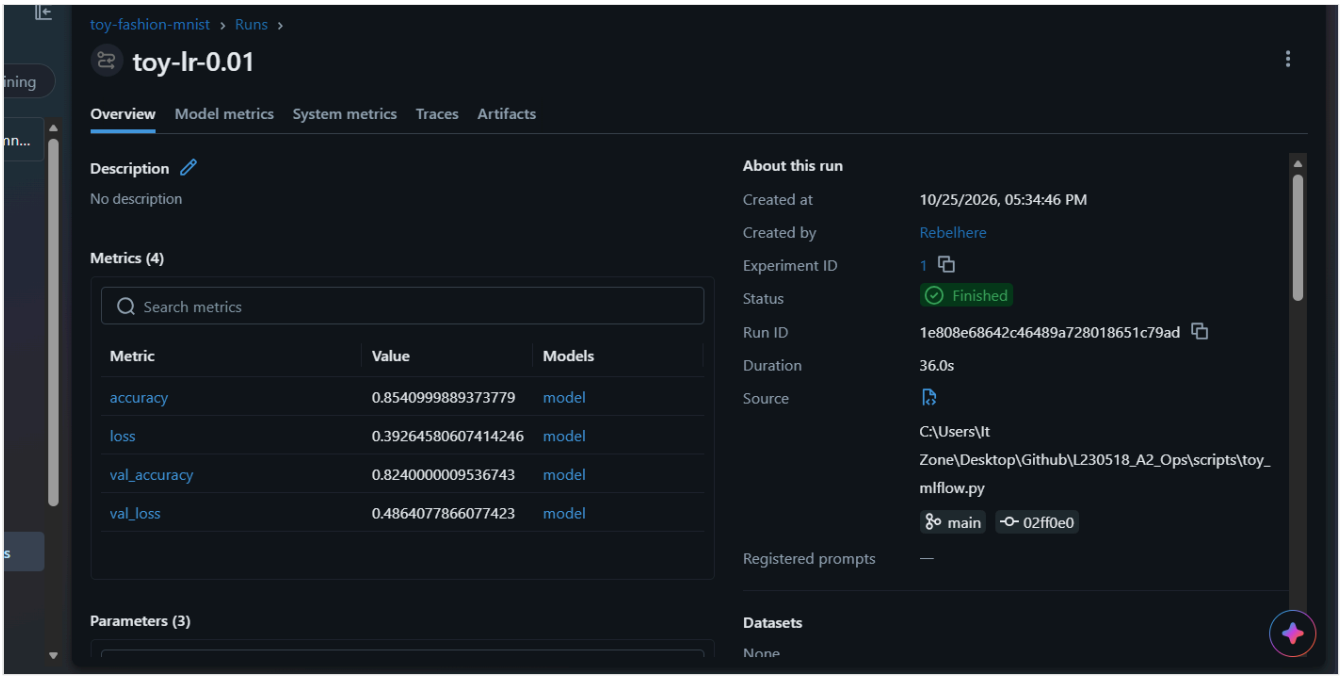


Figure 3.1d – run overview with metrics

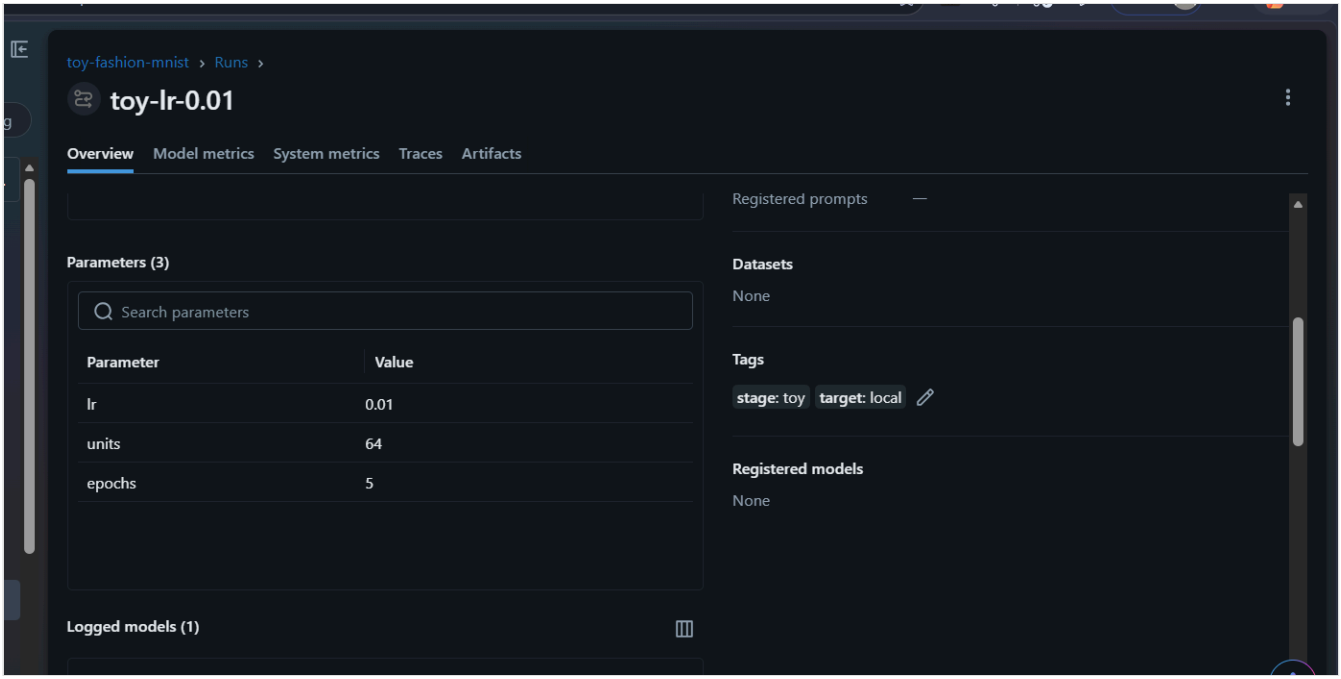


Figure 3.1e – parameters and tags



Figure 3.1f – per-epoch metric charts

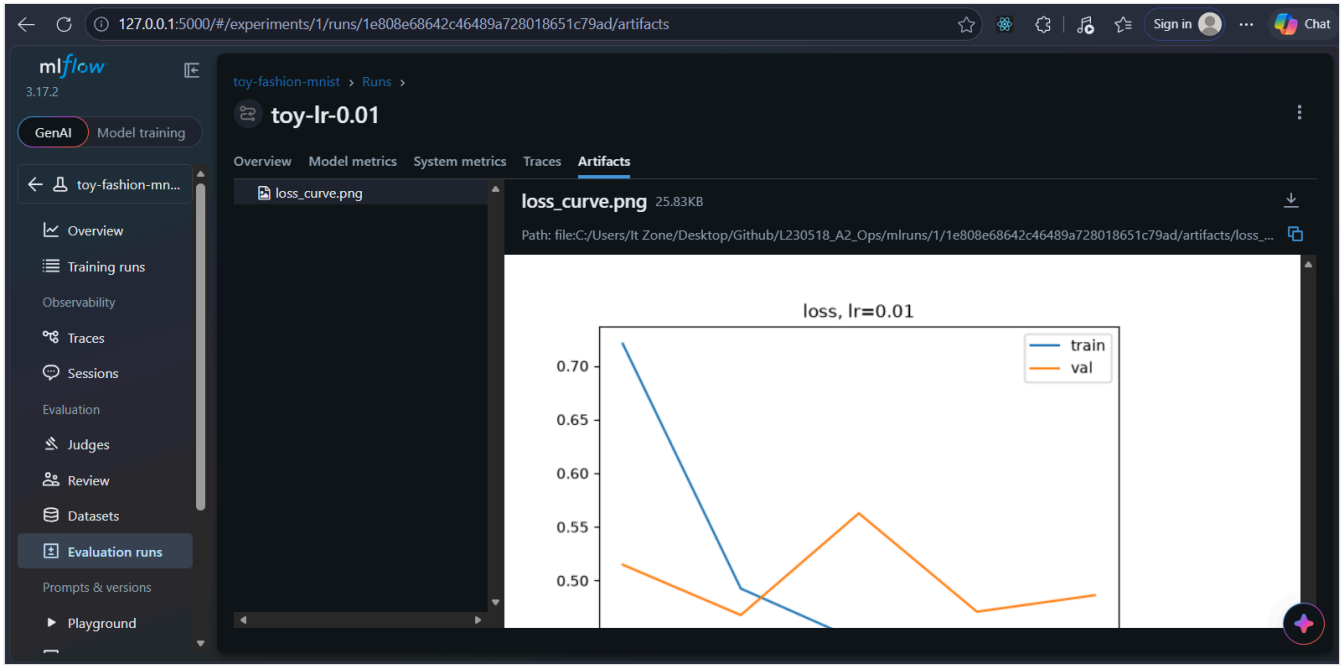


Figure 3.1g – logged plot artifact



Figure 3.1h – comparison view of the two learning rates

3.2 DagsHub setup

What I did. - The DagsHub repository `Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops` is connected to the GitHub repository (Figure 1.4k). Its MLflow tracking address is `https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops.mlflow`. - I created a DagsHub access token and stored three values only in `.env`: - `MLFLOW_TRACKING_URI`, - `MLFLOW_TRACKING_USERNAME`, - `MLFLOW_TRACKING_PASSWORD` (the token). - The code calls `load_dotenv()`, and MLflow reads these variables automatically, so no credential appears in source code. - `.env` is git-ignored: `git check-ignore -v .env` → `.gitignore:2:.env`, and `git status` doesn't list it (Figure 3.2a). `.env.example` documents the variable names without values. - I repeated the toy run against DagsHub (Figure 3.2b).

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.task2_demo
>> git statusUsers\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
.gitignore:2:.env       .env
On branch main
Your branch is up to date with 'origin/main'.

Changes not staged for commit:
  (use "git add <file>..." to update what will be committed)
  (use "git restore <file>..." to discard changes in working directory)
        modified:   .gitignore

Untracked files:
  (use "git add <file>..." to include in what will be committed)
        .env.example
        reports/cnn_layers.csv
        reports/figs/augmented_batch.png
        scripts/__pycache__/
        scripts/task2_demo.py
        src/

no changes added to commit (use "git add" and/or "git commit -a")
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 3.2a – .env is ignored by Git

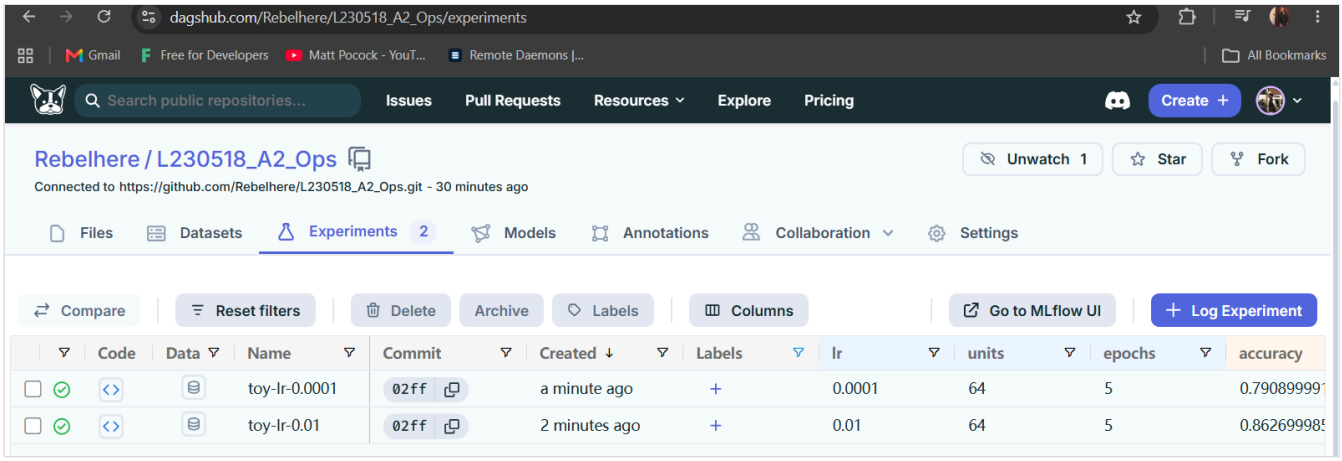


Figure 3.2b – toy runs on DagsHub

3.3 Instrumenting VisionGuard training

`src/train.py` logs every run to the `VisionGuard` experiment: - **Tags:** - `git_commit` (from `git rev-parse HEAD`); - `dvc_data_md5` (the hash read from `data.dvc`, which ties the run to the exact data version); - `seed=42`; - `model`; - `logging`. - **Parameters:** every CLI argument (lr, ft_lr, dropout, epochs, ft_epochs, augmentation), plus img_size and batch. - **Per-epoch metrics:** loss, accuracy, precision, recall and AUC for training and validation. - **Final metrics:** `best_epoch_stage*`, `threshold`, `final_val_*` and, with `--test`, `test_*`.

Manual approach (`--logging manual`, run `mobilenet_manual`, Figures 3.3a–e). - A custom Keras callback `EpochLogger` calls `mlflow.log_metrics(logs, step=offset+epoch)` at the end of each epoch. - The step offset makes stage 2 continue on the same x-axis as stage 1. - I decide exactly what is logged and how it is named.

Autolog approach (`--logging autolog`, run `mobilenet_autolog`, Figures 3.3f–g). `mlflow.tensorflow.autolog()` hooks into `model.fit` and captures, without any code: - every `fit` argument and optimizer setting (43 parameters, e.g. `opt_name=adam`, `opt_learning_rate`, `batch_size`, `class_weight`); - per-epoch metrics; - a model summary; - TensorBoard logs; - early-stopping info.

What each approach captures or misses. - **Autolog is broad but generic.** - Every `fit()` call starts its step counter at 0, so the stage-2 curves overwrite stage 1 instead of continuing it (its charts show only 2 steps). - It can't know domain values: the validation-chosen threshold, the test metrics, the confusion matrix, or the data hash. - **Manual logging is precise but only as complete as my code.** It missed the optimizer internals, which autolog logged for free.

I kept both: autolog for the automatic extras, plus manual calls for the domain values.

What went wrong. - The first autolog run **failed** (red *X* in Figures 3.3h–i). Autolog tried to log the model with `mlflow.keras.log_model`, which failed for the nested MobileNetV2 model. - MLflow 3 had also deprecated `artifact_path` there. - I set `log_models=False`, wrapped `log_model` in try/except, and save the `.keras` file as a plain artifact (`model_file/`) as a fallback. `scripts/finish_autolog_run.py` completed the logging for the autolog run.

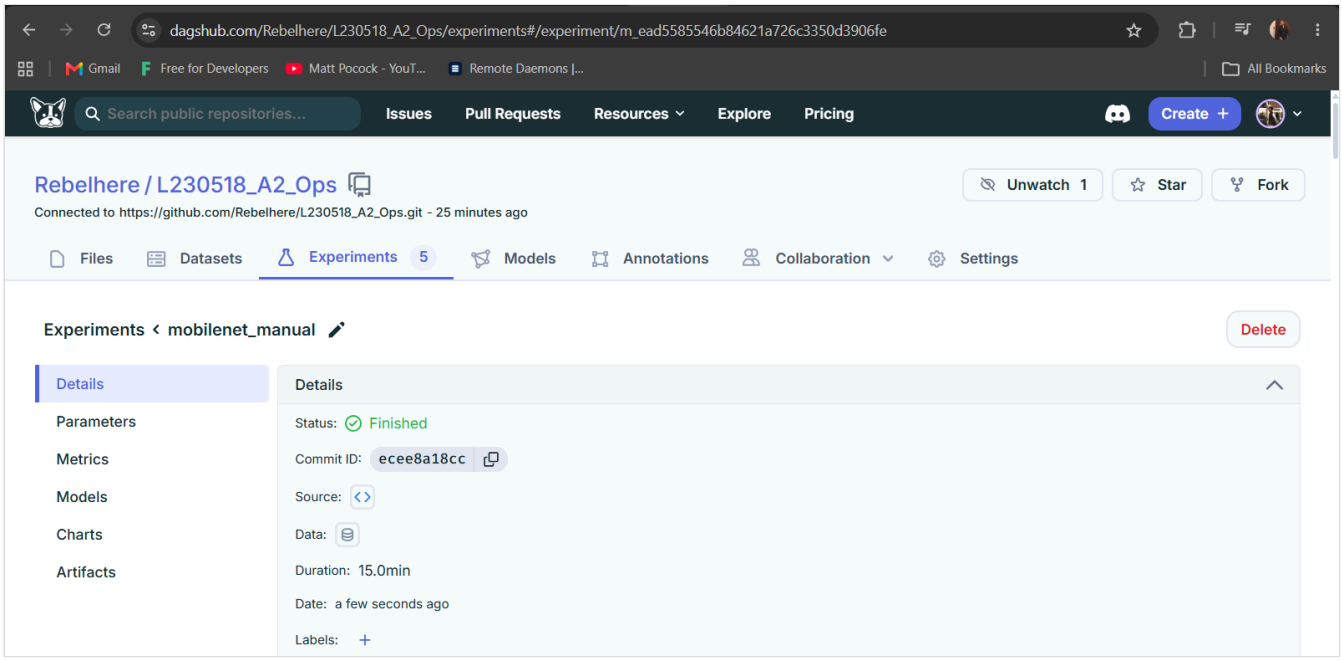


Figure 3.3a – manual run details (commit, source, duration)

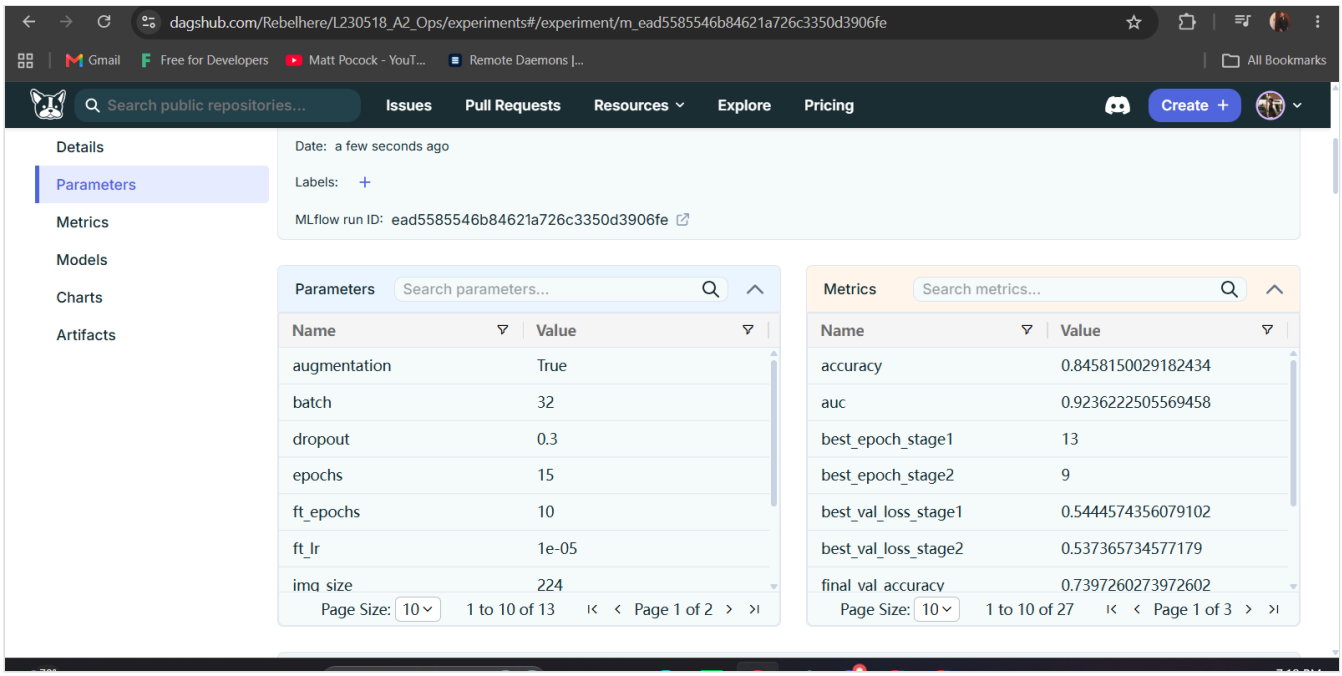


Figure 3.3b – manual run parameters and metrics

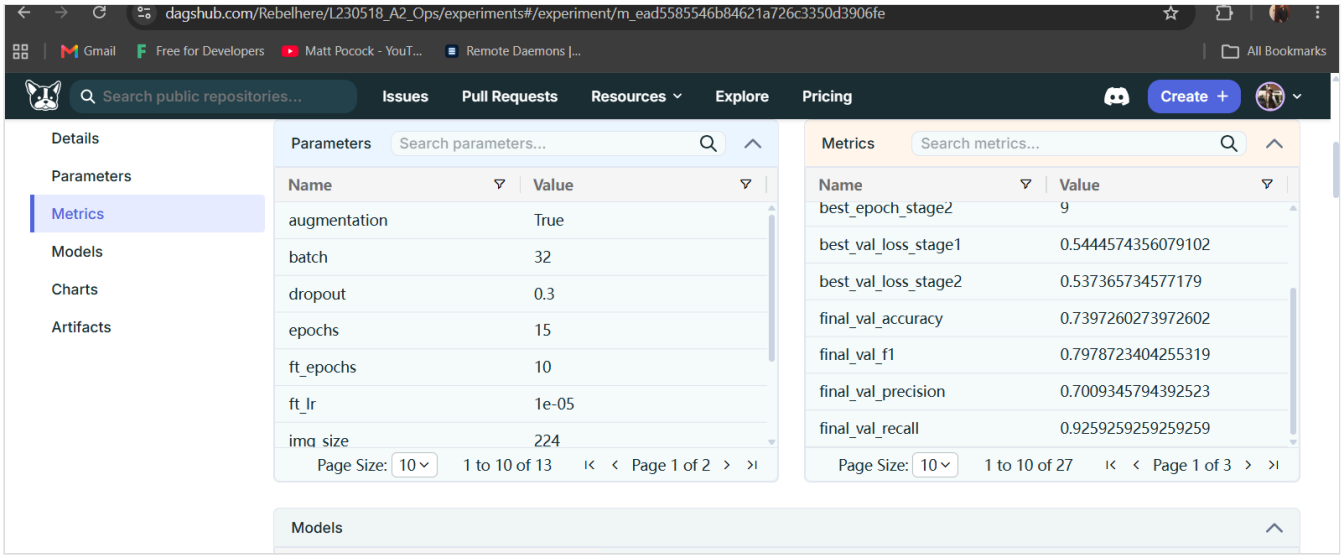


Figure 3.3c – manual run final validation metrics

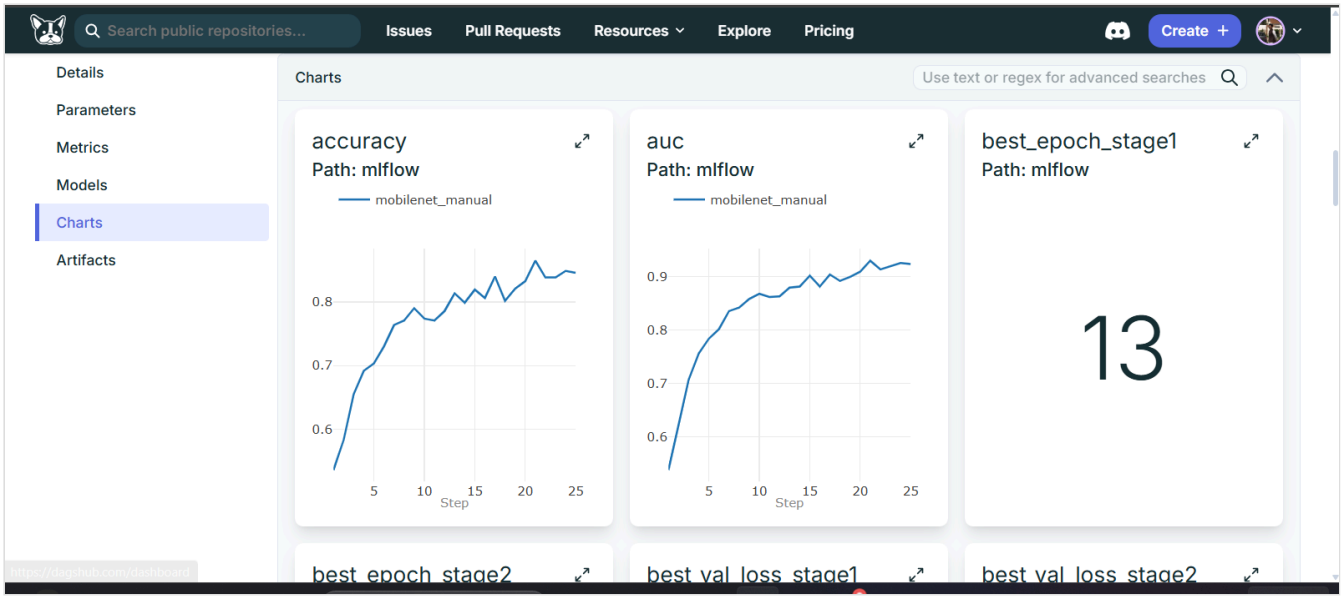


Figure 3.3d – manual per-epoch charts over both stages (25 steps)

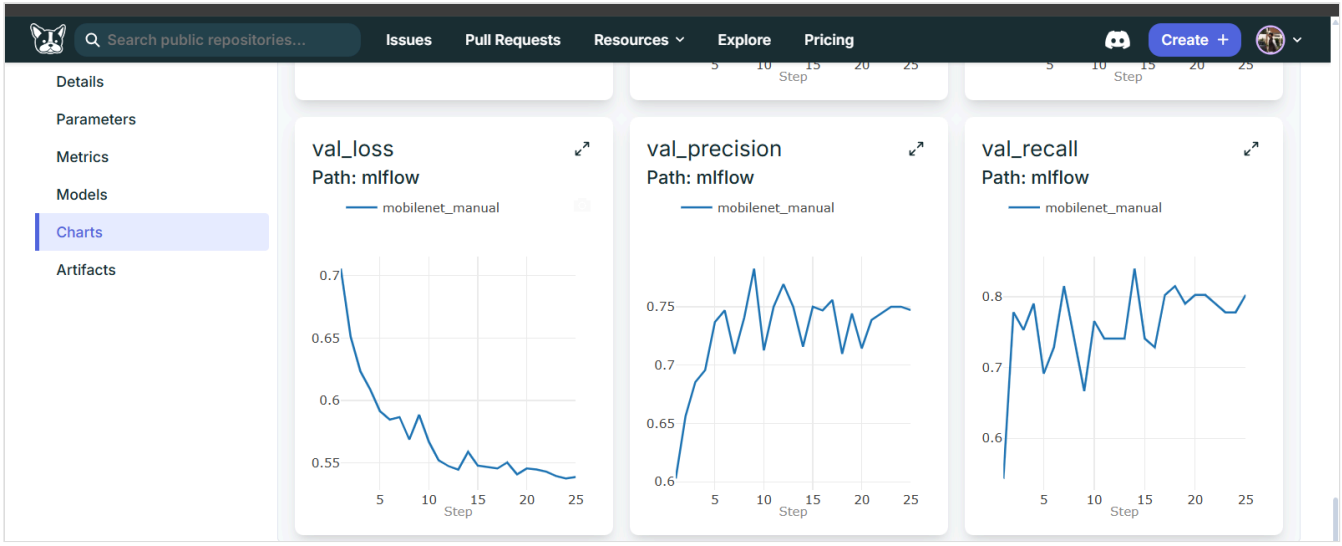


Figure 3.3e – val_loss / precision / recall curves

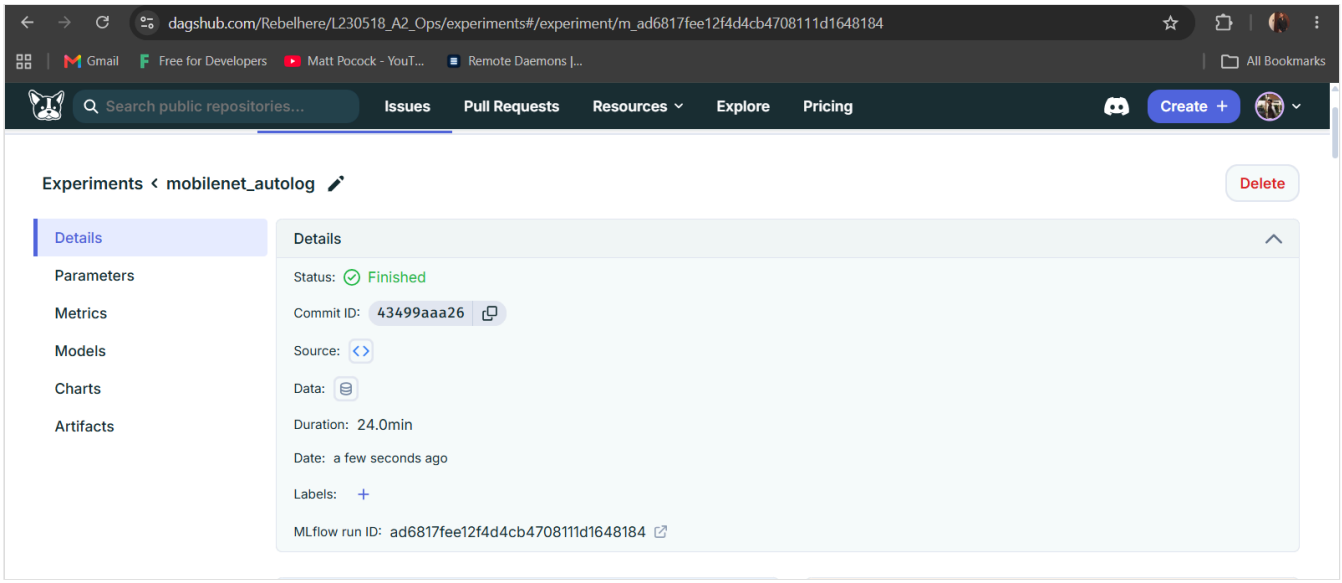


Figure 3.3f – autolog run details

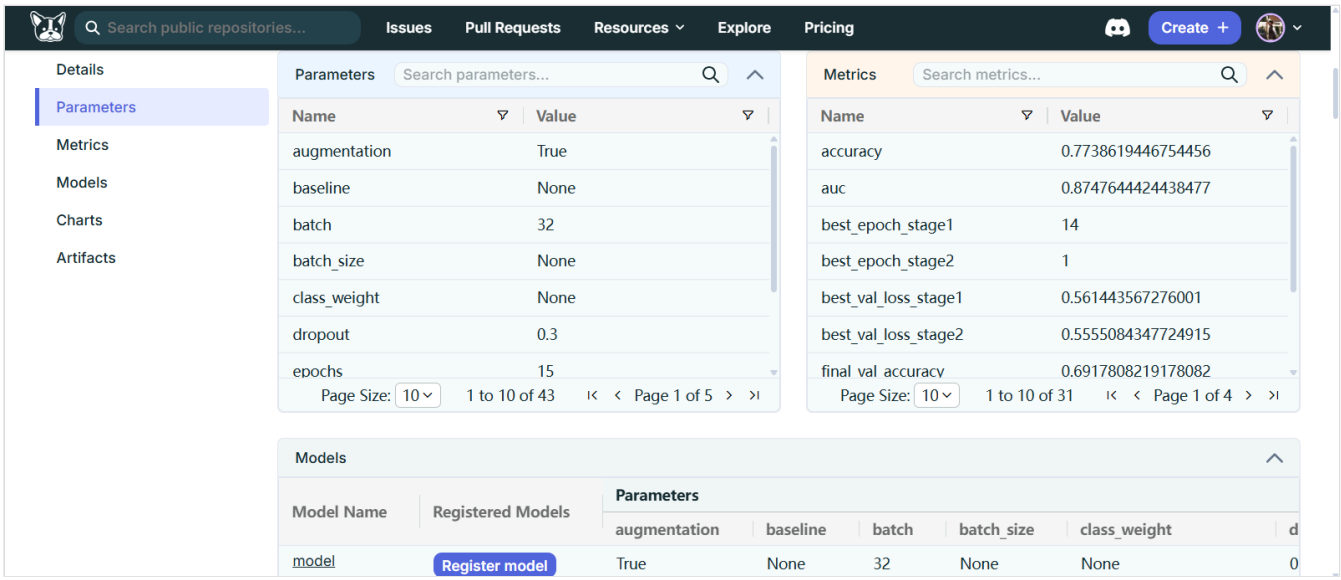


Figure 3.3g – autolog captured 43 parameters including optimizer settings

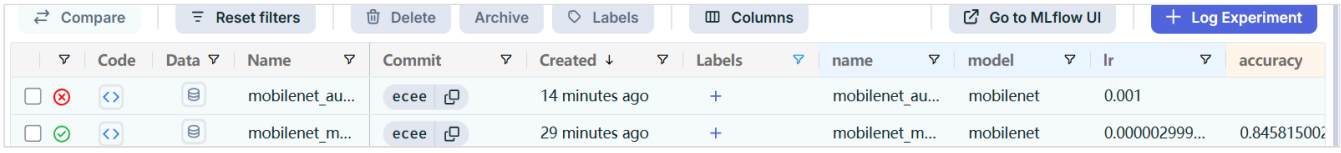


Figure 3.3h – the first autolog run failed

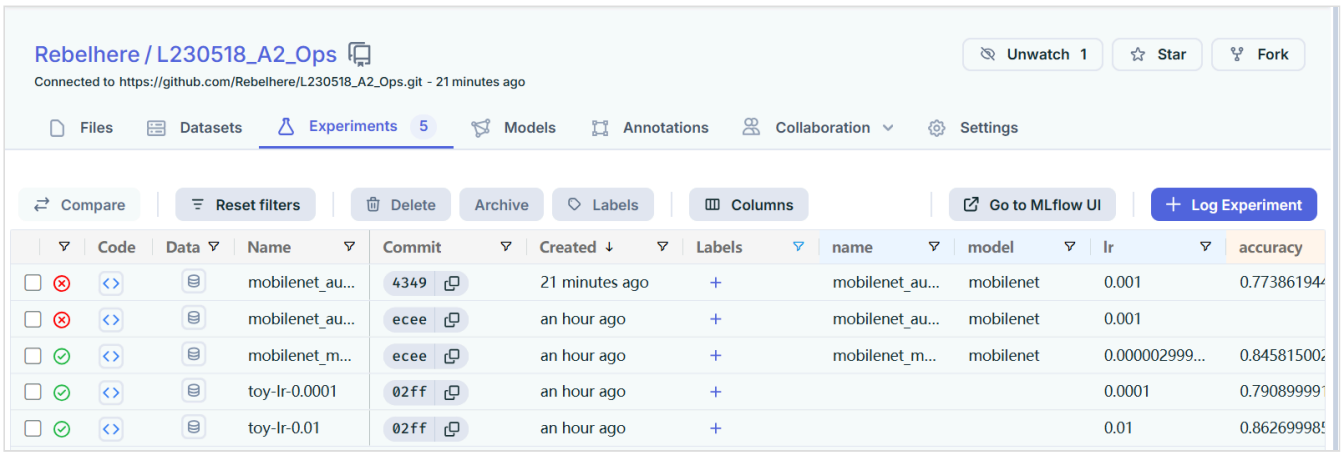


Figure 3.3i – experiments list after the fix

3.4 Artifacts

Every run attaches these artifacts (Figures 3.4a–d): - `confusion_matrix_<split>.png` and `roc_curve_<split>.png`; - `splits/train.csv`, `val.csv` and `test.csv` (the exact split lists); - `pip_freeze.txt` (the package list); - the trained Keras model (`model/`, or the `.keras` file in `model_file/`); - `curves.png`.

The autolog run additionally has `checkpoints/`, `tensorboard_logs/` and `model_summary.txt`.

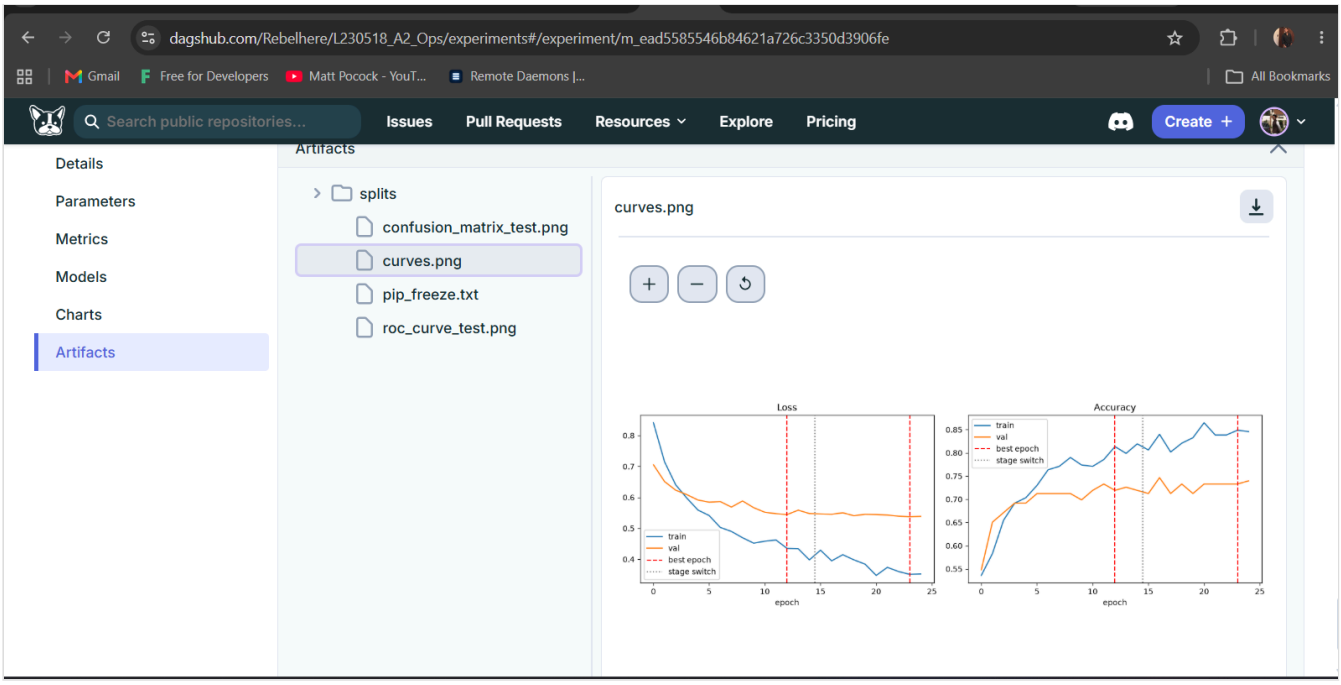


Figure 3.4a – artifacts of the manual run

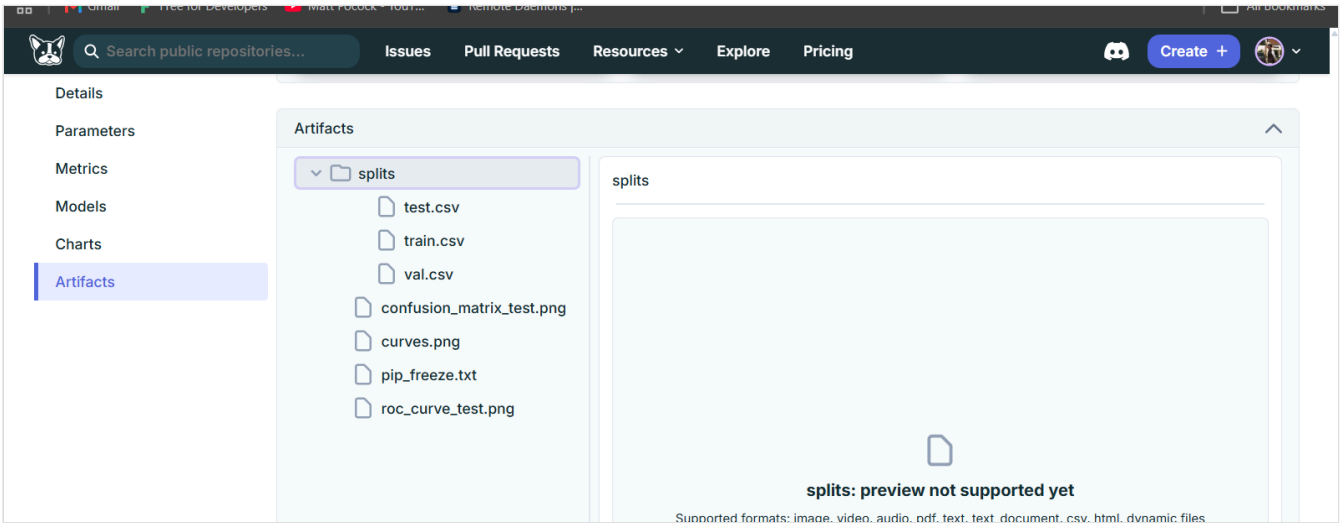


Figure 3.4b – split lists attached to the run

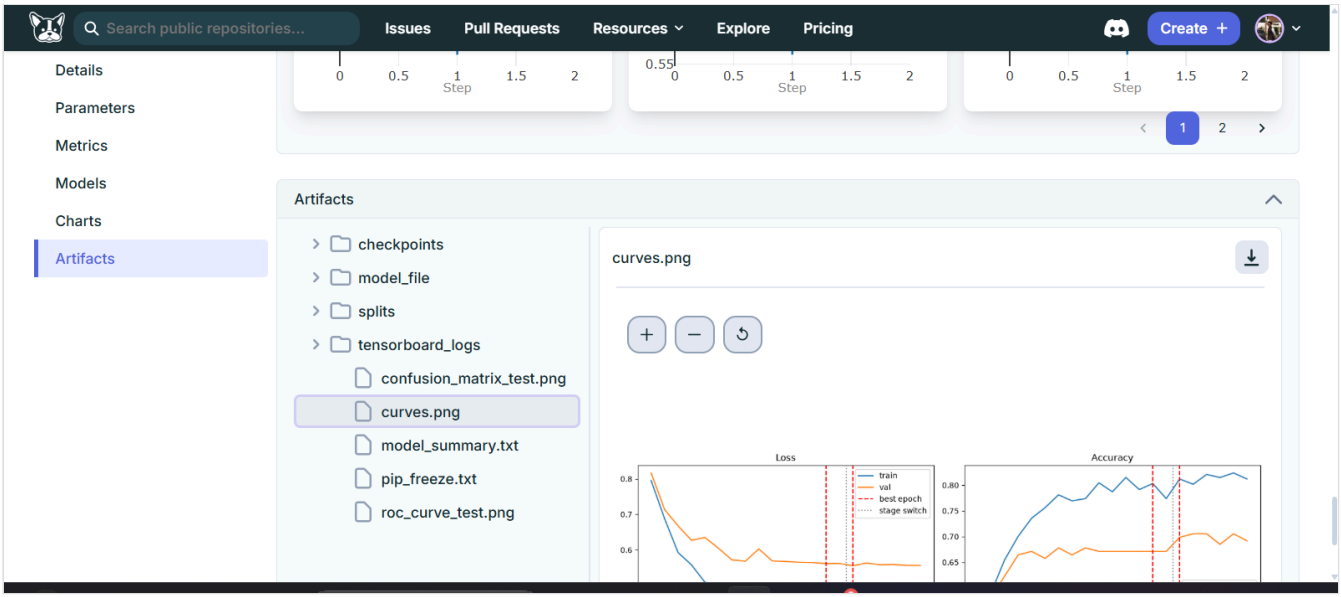


Figure 3.4c – artifacts of the autolog run

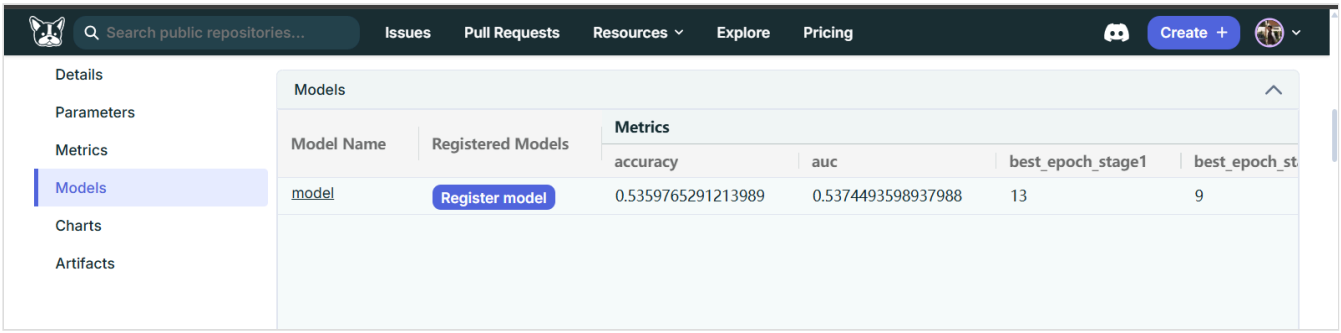


Figure 3.4d – logged Keras model

3.5 Experiment comparison

I ran 7 runs (Figures 3.5a–i, `reports/comparison.csv`). Each differs from `mobilenet_manual` (head lr 1e-3, ft lr 1e-5, augmentation on, 10 fine-tune epochs) in **one** change:

Run	Single change vs mobilenet_manual	val acc	val prec	val rec	val F1	val AUC
mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4	fine-tune lr 1e-5 → **1e-4**	**0.753**	**0.718**	0.914	**0.804**	**0.835**
mobilenet_manual	(reference)	0.740	0.701	0.926	0.798	0.807
mobilenet_no_aug	augmentation off	0.705	0.670	0.926	0.777	0.803
mobilenet_head_only	no fine-tuning stage (frozen base)	0.712	0.689	0.877	0.772	0.781
mobilenet_autolog	logging method only (control)	0.692	0.658	0.926	0.769	0.779
mobilenet_lr1e-4	head lr 1e-3 → 1e-4	0.658	0.637	0.889	0.742	0.752
cnn_baseline	backbone: MobileNetV2 → own CNN	0.610	0.590	0.975	0.735	0.639

Choice: `mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4`**.** These are the metrics I consider most important, in order: 1. **ROC-AUC.** It is independent of the threshold. I move the threshold afterwards to control false alarms, so ranking quality is what the model itself must provide. 2. **Precision.** Few real photos are called fake. 3. **F1.**

The chosen run is best on all three. It is the only run that also improved stage-2 val_loss clearly (0.524 vs 0.537).

What each single change taught me: - Fine-tuning helps (head_only is −0.03 AUC). - Augmentation helps slightly. - A smaller head lr under-trains in 15 epochs. - A from-scratch CNN is far worse. - The autolog "control" differs from manual by 0.03 AUC with an identical configuration. That is a reminder of run-to-run noise on 146 validation images, the same effect discussed in 2.7.

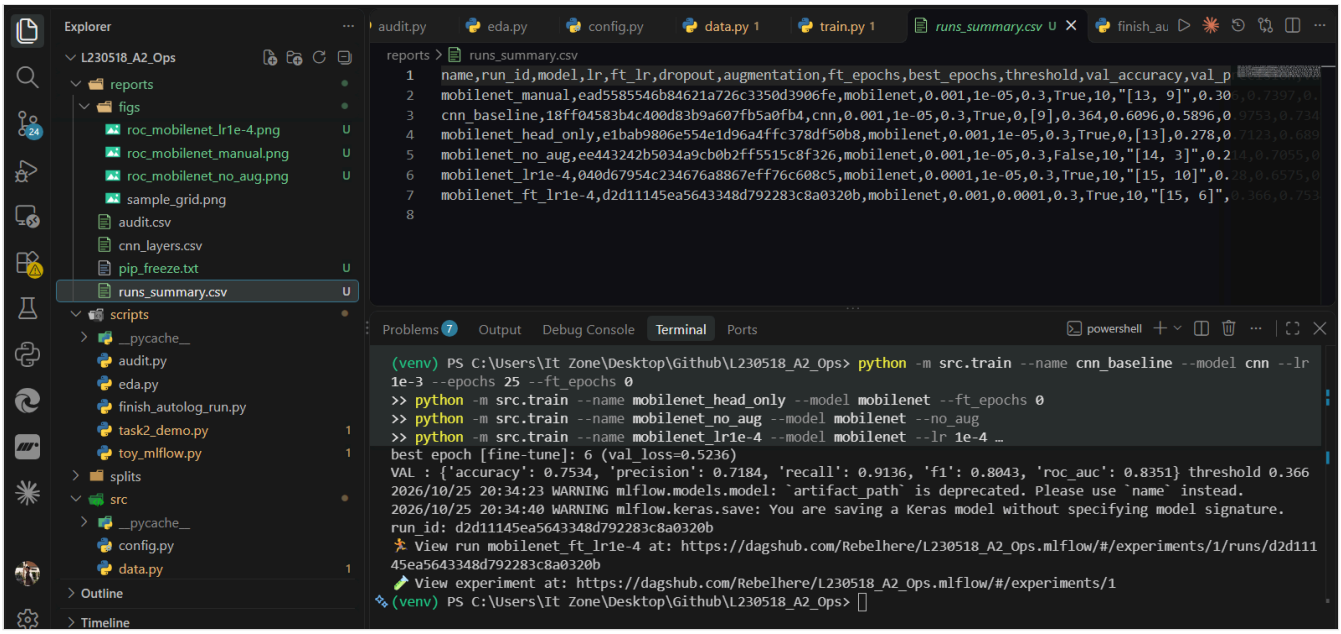
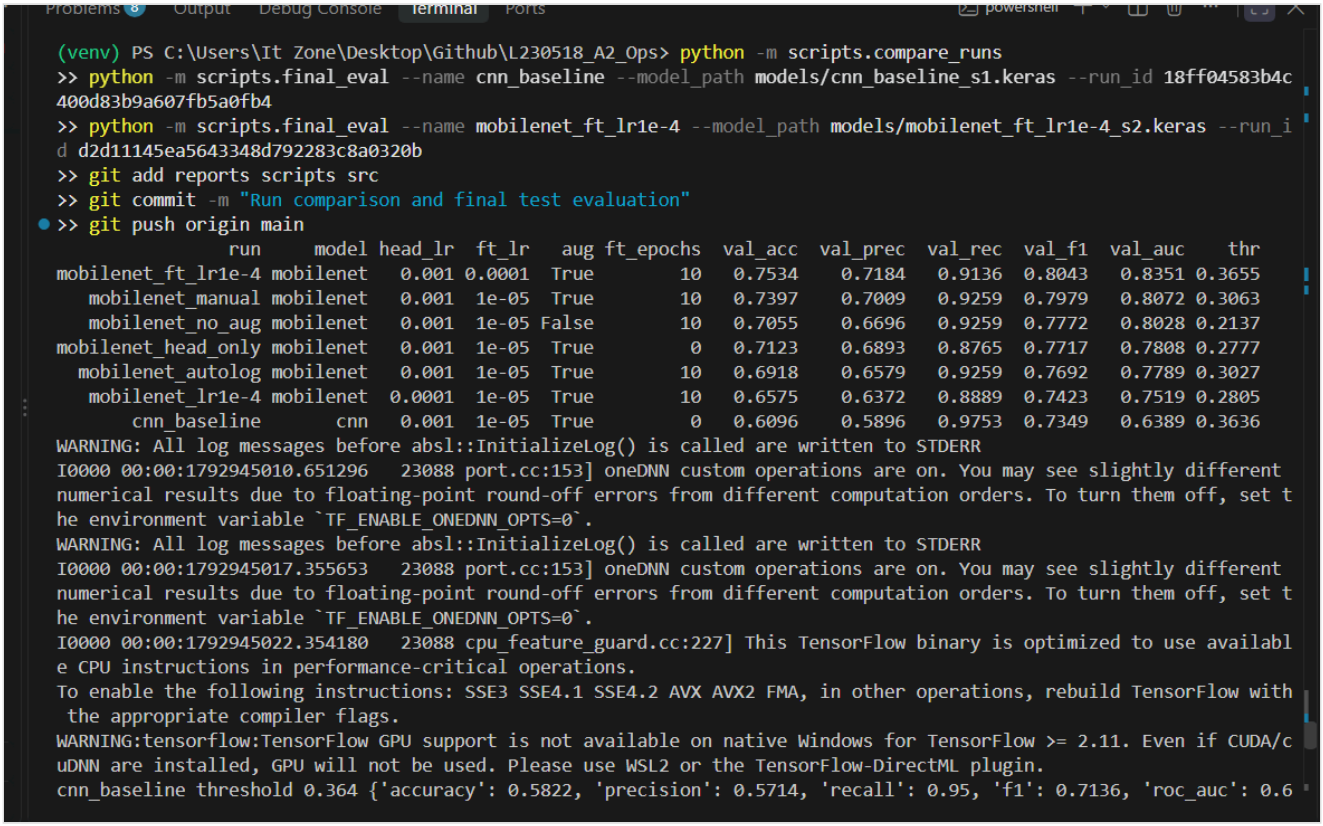


Figure 3.5a – training commands for the comparison runs



```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> python -m scripts.compare_runs
>> python -m scripts.final_eval --name cnn_baseline --model_path models/cnn_baseline_s1.keras --run_id 18ff04583b4c400d83b9a607fb5a0fb4
>> python -m scripts.final_eval --name mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 --model_path models/mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4_s2.keras --run_id d2d11145ea5643348d792283c8a0320b
>> git add reports scripts src
>> git commit -m "Run comparison and final test evaluation"
>> git push origin main
                run     model head_lr  ft_lr   aug ft_epochs  val_acc  val_prec  val_rec  val_f1  val_auc    thr
mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 mobilenet   0.001 0.0001  True        10   0.7534    0.7184   0.9136  0.8043   0.8351 0.3655
   mobilenet_manual mobilenet   0.001  1e-05  True        10   0.7397    0.7009   0.9259  0.7979   0.8072 0.3063
   mobilenet_no_aug mobilenet   0.001  1e-05 False        10   0.7055    0.6696   0.9259  0.7772   0.8028 0.2137
mobilenet_head_only mobilenet   0.001  1e-05  True         0   0.7123    0.6893   0.8765  0.7717   0.7808 0.2777
  mobilenet_autolog mobilenet   0.001  1e-05  True        10   0.6918    0.6579   0.9259  0.7692   0.7789 0.3027
   mobilenet_lr1e-4 mobilenet  0.0001  1e-05  True        10   0.6575    0.6372   0.8889  0.7423   0.7519 0.2805
       cnn_baseline       cnn   0.001  1e-05  True         0   0.6096    0.5896   0.9753  0.7349   0.6389 0.3636
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792945010.651296   23088 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792945017.355653   23088 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see slightly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
I0000 00:00:1792945022.354180   23088 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized to use available CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild TensorFlow with the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11. Even if CUDA/cuDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
cnn_baseline threshold 0.364 {'accuracy': 0.5822, 'precision': 0.5714, 'recall': 0.95, 'f1': 0.7136, 'roc_auc': 0.6
```

Figure 3.5b – comparison table printed by scripts/compare_runs.py

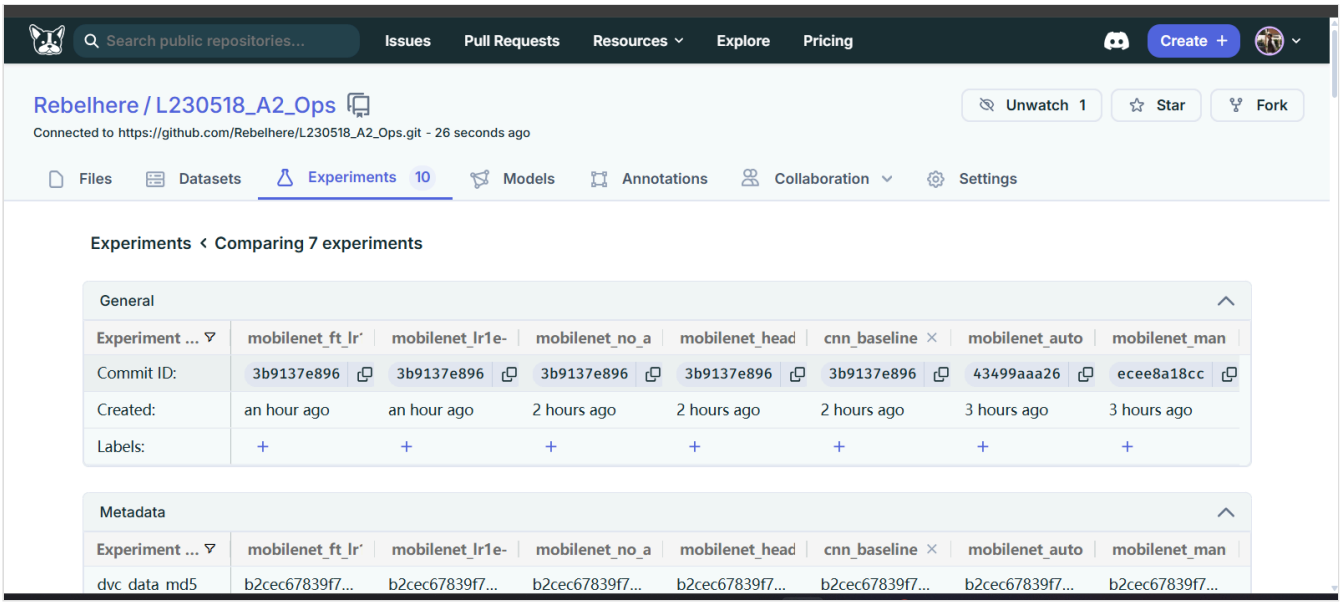


Figure 3.5c – DagsHub: comparing 7 experiments

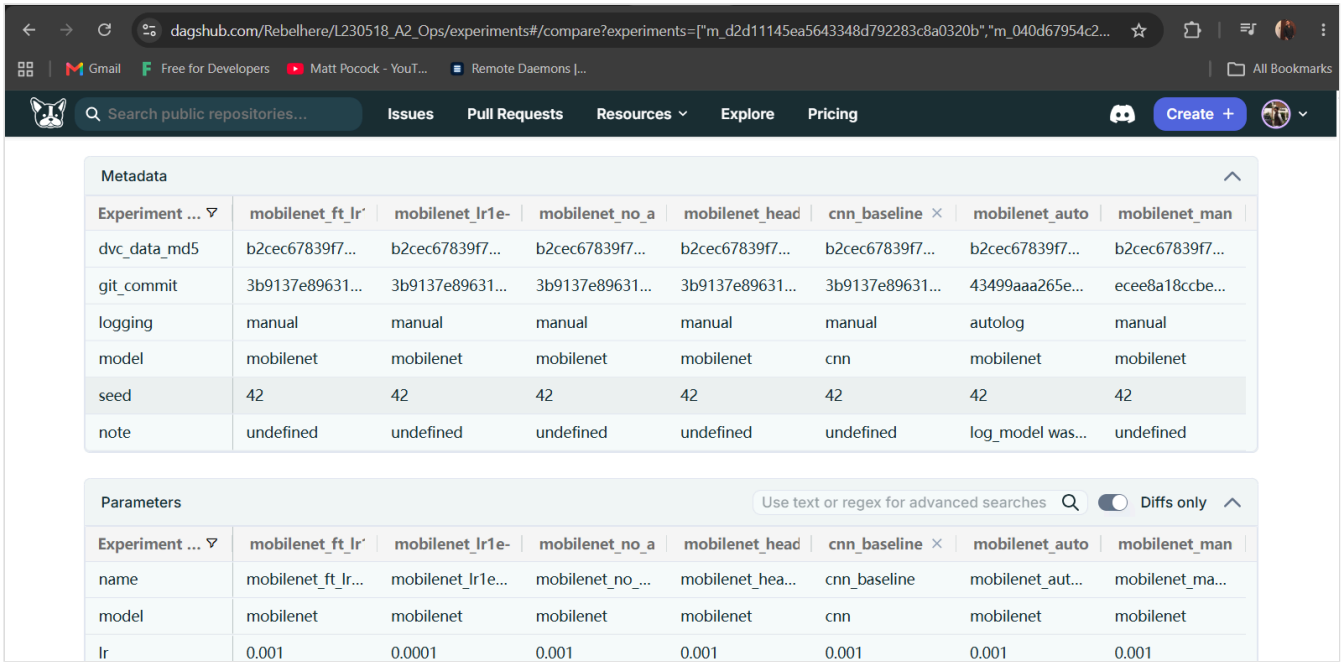
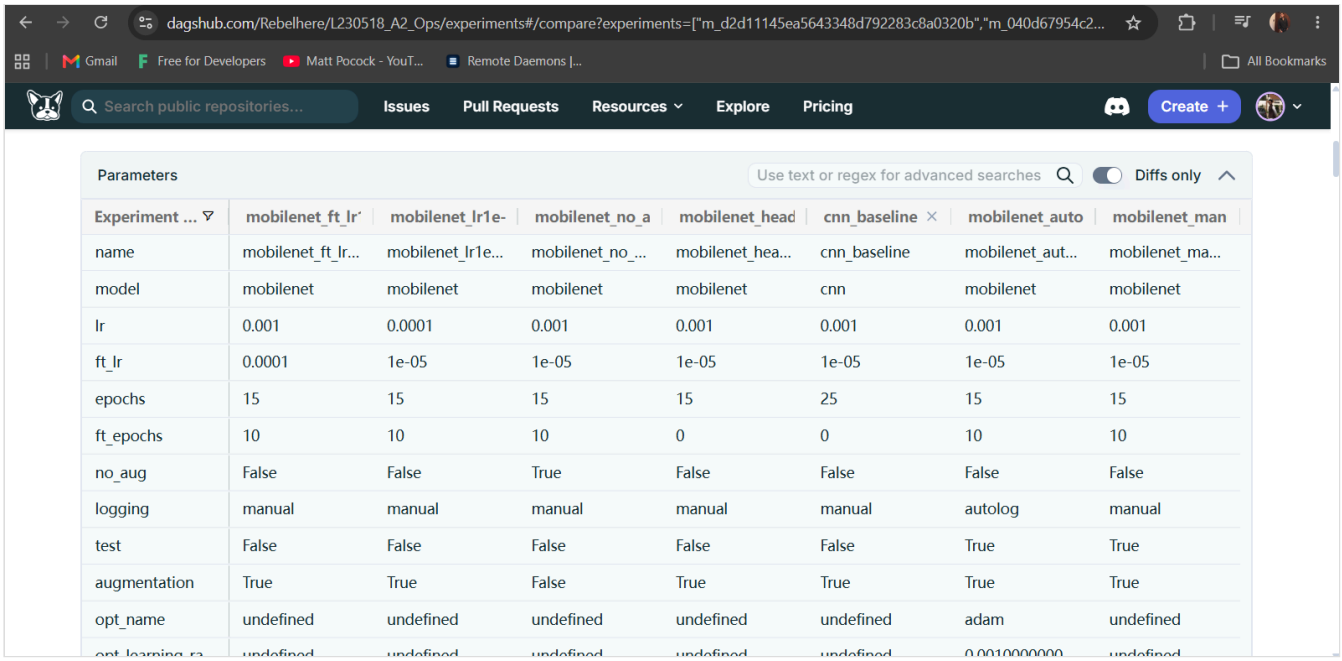
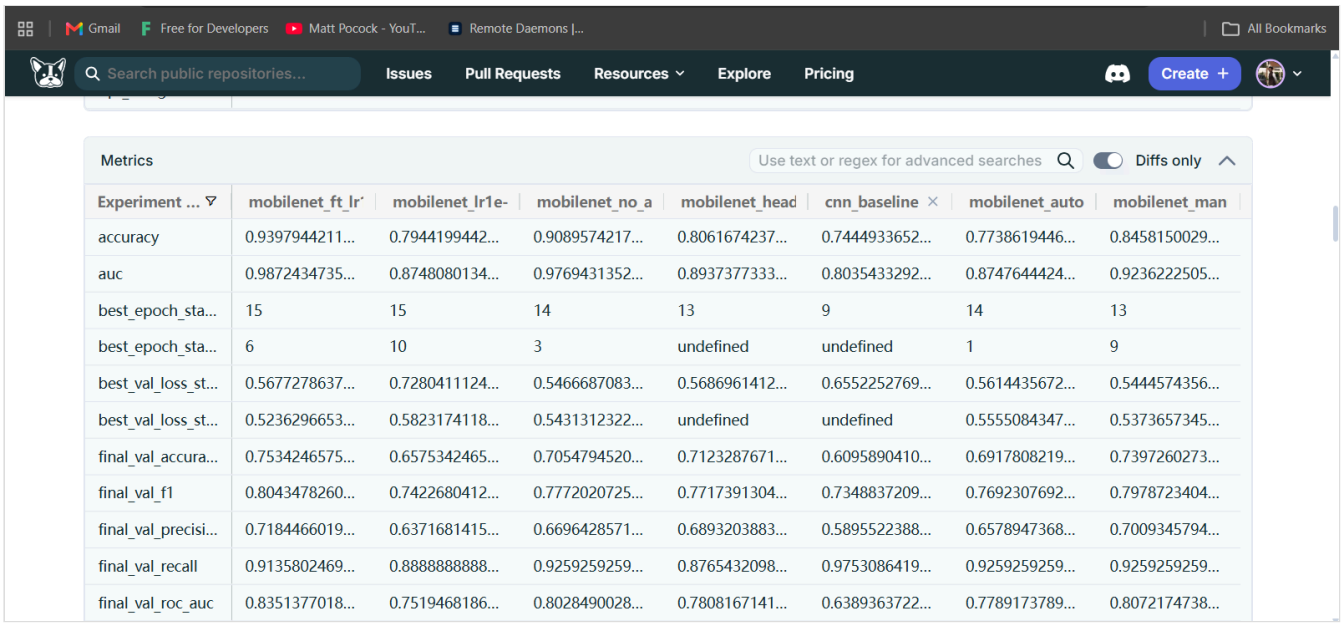


Figure 3.5d – tags differ only in commit; data hash and seed equal



Experiment ...	mobilenet_ft_lr'	mobilenet_lr1e-	mobilenet_no_a	mobilenet_head	cnn_baseline	mobilenet_auto	mobilenet_man
name	mobilenet_ft_lr...	mobilenet_lr1e...	mobilenet_no_...	mobilenet_hea...	cnn_baseline	mobilenet_aut...	mobilenet_ma...
model	mobilenet	mobilenet	mobilenet	mobilenet	cnn	mobilenet	mobilenet
lr	0.001	0.0001	0.001	0.001	0.001	0.001	0.001
ft_lr	0.0001	1e-05	1e-05	1e-05	1e-05	1e-05	1e-05
epochs	15	15	15	15	25	15	15
ft_epochs	10	10	10	0	0	10	10
no_aug	False	False	True	False	False	False	False
logging	manual	manual	manual	manual	manual	autolog	manual
test	False	False	False	False	False	True	True
augmentation	True	True	False	True	True	True	True
opt_name	undefined	undefined	undefined	undefined	undefined	adam	undefined
opt_learning_ra	undefined	undefined	undefined	undefined	undefined	0.0010000000	undefined

Figure 3.5e – parameters, diffs only



Experiment ...	mobilenet_ft_lr'	mobilenet_lr1e-	mobilenet_no_a	mobilenet_head	cnn_baseline	mobilenet_auto	mobilenet_man
accuracy	0.9397944211...	0.7944199442...	0.9089574217...	0.8061674237...	0.7444933652...	0.7738619446...	0.8458150029...
auc	0.9872434735...	0.8748080134...	0.9769431352...	0.8937377333...	0.8035433292...	0.8747644424...	0.9236222505...
best_epoch_sta...	15	15	14	13	9	14	13
best_epoch_sta...	6	10	3	undefined	undefined	1	9
best_val_loss_st...	0.5677278637...	0.7280411124...	0.5466687083...	0.5686961412...	0.6552252769...	0.5614435672...	0.5444574356...
best_val_loss_st...	0.5236296653...	0.5823174118...	0.5431312322...	undefined	undefined	0.5555084347...	0.5373657345...
final_val_accura...	0.7534246575...	0.6575342465...	0.7054794520...	0.7123287671...	0.6095890410...	0.6917808219...	0.7397260273...
final_val_f1	0.8043478260...	0.7422680412...	0.7772020725...	0.7717391304...	0.7348837209...	0.7692307692...	0.7978723404...
final_val_precisi...	0.7184466019...	0.6371681415...	0.6696428571...	0.6893203883...	0.5895522388...	0.6578947368...	0.7009345794...
final_val_recall	0.9135802469...	0.8888888888...	0.9259259259...	0.8765432098...	0.9753086419...	0.9259259259...	0.9259259259...
final_val_roc_auc	0.8351377018...	0.7519468186...	0.8028490028...	0.7808167141...	0.6389363722...	0.7789173789...	0.8072174738...

Figure 3.5f – metrics side by side

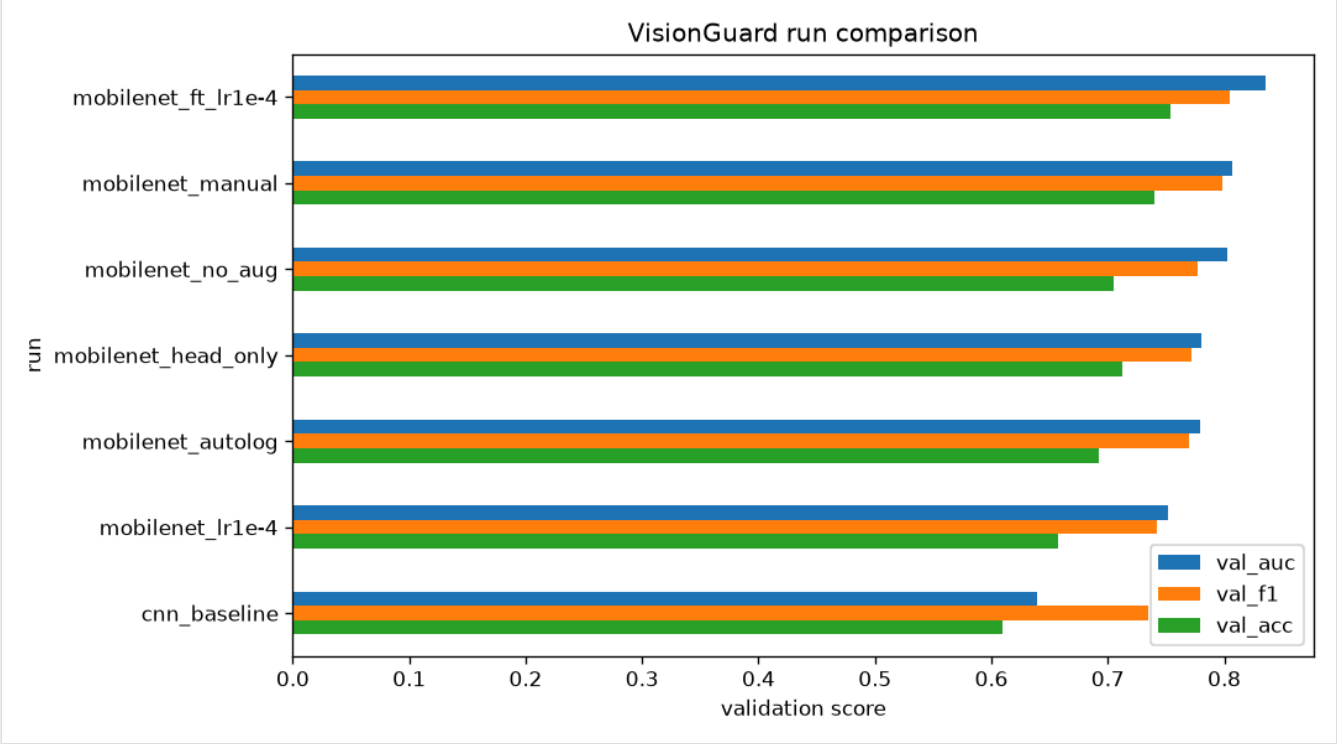


Figure 3.5g – summary chart

```
>> python -m scripts.final_eval --name cnn_baseline --model_path models/cnn_baseline_s1.keras --run_id 18ff04583b4c
400d83b9a607fb5a0fb4
>> python -m scripts.final_eval --name mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 --model_path models/mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4_s2.keras --run_i
d d2d11145ea5643348d792283c8a0320b …
uDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectML plugin.
mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 threshold 0.366 {'accuracy': 0.7877, 'precision': 0.7248, 'recall': 0.9875, 'f1': 0.836, 'roc_a
uc': 0.8695}
[[36 30]
 [ 1 79]]
🏃 View run mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4 at: https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops.mlflow/#/experiments/1/runs/d2d111
45ea5643348d792283c8a0320b
🧪 View experiment at: https://dagshub.com/Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops.mlflow/#/experiments/1
[main e93ab25] Run comparison and final test evaluation
 34 files changed, 301 insertions(+)
 create mode 100644 reports/comparison.csv
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_cnn_baseline.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_autolog.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_head_only.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_lr1e-4.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_manual.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/cm_mobilenet_no_aug.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/comparison.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_cnn_baseline.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_autolog.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_head_only.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_lr1e-4.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_manual.png
 create mode 100644 reports/figs/curves_mobilenet_no_aug.png
```

Figure 3.5h – final evaluation of both models logged to their runs

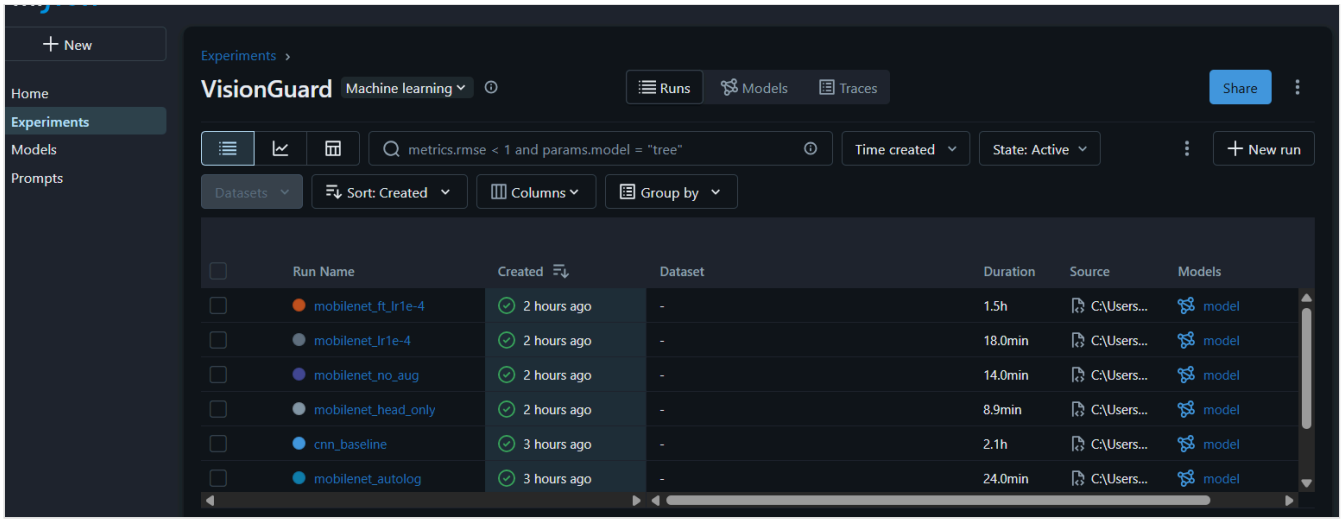


Figure 3.5i – VisionGuard runs in the MLflow UI

3.6 Model registry

What I did. - `scripts/register_models.py` registered `L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard` from the runs' model files, with two versions: - **version 1** is `mobilenet_manual`, alias `challenger`; - **version 2** is `mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4`, alias `champion`. - Each version carries the tags `run_name` and `threshold` (Figure 3.6a). - `scripts/load_champion.py <image>` resolves `models:/…@champion` with `MlflowClient.get_model_version_by_alias`, downloads that version's `.keras`, loads it and classifies one image.

How the champion file reaches the server (and why not per request). - `scripts/export_champion.py` downloads the champion **once** into `models/champion.keras` and writes `champion_meta.json` (version 2, run id). - The web container mounts that folder, and the cloud API image has it built in. - Serving therefore never calls DagsHub. A registry call per request would add seconds of latency, fail whenever DagsHub is down, and hit API rate limits. - Promoting a new model means: move the alias, re-run the export, then restart or rebuild.

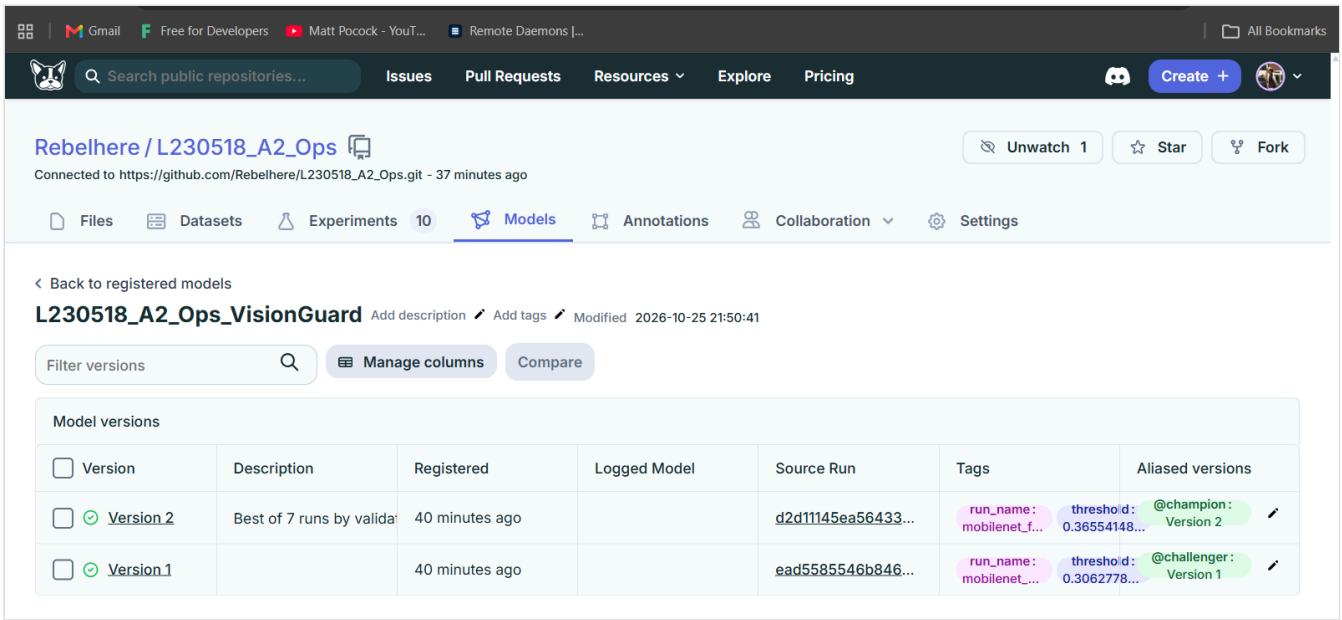


Figure 3.6a – registry with two versions and the champion alias

```
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792965564.933208    7172 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see sli
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
Downloading artifacts: 100%|| 1/1 [00:21<00:
I0000 00:00:1792965669.473880    7172 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized
 to use available CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild
 TensorFlow with the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11
. Even if CUDA/cuDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectM
L plugin.
champion = version 2 (run mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4), registry threshold 0.366
data\AiArtData\AiArtData\64efd48f24bacac40feae0b4_qFcGNfN66Fp4nrvBHhQp89Kg425rczlCMKCbW2cNCCs.jpeg
p(AI) = 0.999 -> AI-generated
```

Figure 3.6b – scripts/load_champion.py resolves @champion → version 2 (run mobilenet_ft_lr1e-4), downloads it once and classifies one image: p(AI) = 0.999 → AI-generated

This script prints the registry tag threshold 0.366, the validation-F1 threshold stored when the version was registered. The deployed services use the stricter **0.771** chosen in 2.5, set through the `THRESHOLD` environment variable, so promoting a model never silently changes the false-alarm policy.

Chapter 4: Flask web application

Code layout: - `app/` is the web app: the factory, routes, database and templates. - `serving/` holds the inference and validation code shared with the API. - `api/` is the cloud model API. - `wsgi.py` is the production entrypoint.

4.1 Inference module

`serving/inference.py::Predictor` (Figure 4.1): - loads `champion.keras` **once** in its constructor; - reads the version from `champion_meta.json`; - runs one warm-up prediction.

`predict(bytes)` calls the **same function used in training**, `src/preprocess.py::decode_resize` (decode to 3 channels, then bilinear resize to 224×224). Then it runs the model, which contains `preprocess_input` internally, and returns: - `label`: "AI-generated" if p ≥ threshold, else "Real"; - `p_ai`; - `confidence`: p for AI, 1−p for Real; - `threshold`, `model_name`, `model_version` and `latency_ms`.

Measured on my laptop: **loading the model takes 36.7 s; one prediction takes about 0.3 s.**

```
 model v2 loaded once in 36.7s, threshold 0.771
…/AiArtData/…qFcGNfN66Fp4….jpeg   -> {'label': 'AI-generated', 'p_ai': 0.9994, 'confidence': 0.9994, …,
'latency_ms': 337.2}
…/RealArt/…lindsey-pattison….jpg  -> {'label': 'Real', 'p_ai': 0.0462, 'confidence': 0.9538, …, 'latency_ms':
268.5}
```

Why loading per request is unacceptable. - Every request would take about 37 s instead of 0.3 s, roughly a 100× slowdown. - Every request would re-read 17 MB from disk and re-allocate the whole TF graph. - Concurrent users would multiply the memory use and crash the container.

Loading once at start-up pays the cost one time, and every request after that is fast.

Why training and serving preprocessing must match. - The model only learned the mapping for inputs prepared the training way. - Typical drifts include: - [0, 1] instead of [0, 255] scaling; - a crop instead of a stretch; - RGBA handled differently; - nearest-neighbour instead of bilinear resizing. - Any of these produces inputs the model never saw. The predictions then silently degrade (training/serving skew), and no error is raised. - I avoid this by construction: both paths import the same `decode_resize`, and the [-1, 1] scaling lives inside the saved model.

```
>>
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792965684.017678    5952 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see sli
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
WARNING: All log messages before absl::InitializeLog() is called are written to STDERR
I0000 00:00:1792965700.098144    5952 port.cc:153] oneDNN custom operations are on. You may see sli
ghtly different numerical results due to floating-point round-off errors from different computation
 orders. To turn them off, set the environment variable `TF_ENABLE_ONEDNN_OPTS=0`.
I0000 00:00:1792965709.260464    5952 cpu_feature_guard.cc:227] This TensorFlow binary is optimized
 to use available CPU instructions in performance-critical operations.
To enable the following instructions: SSE3 SSE4.1 SSE4.2 AVX AVX2 FMA, in other operations, rebuild
 TensorFlow with the appropriate compiler flags.
WARNING:tensorflow:TensorFlow GPU support is not available on native Windows for TensorFlow >= 2.11
. Even if CUDA/cuDNN are installed, GPU will not be used. Please use WSL2 or the TensorFlow-DirectM
L plugin.
model v2 loaded once in 29.5s, threshold 0.771
data\AiArtData\AiArtData\64efd48f24bacac40feae0b4_qFcGNfN66Fp4nrvBHhQp89Kg425rczlCMKCbW2cNCCs.jpeg
-> {'label': 'AI-generated', 'p_ai': 0.9994, 'confidence': 0.9994, 'threshold': 0.771, 'model_name'
: 'L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard', 'model_version': '2', 'latency_ms': 908.0}
data\RealArt\RealArt\lindsey-pattison_october-2023_hero.jpg -> {'label': 'Real', 'p_ai': 0.0462, 'c
onfidence': 0.9538, 'threshold': 0.771, 'model_name': 'L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard', 'model_version'
: '2', 'latency_ms': 272.2}
(venv) PS C:Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 4.1 – the inference module: model loaded once (29.5 s on this run), then each image in well under a second

4.2 Routes and validation

Route	Purpose
`GET /`	upload page
`POST /predict`	validate, predict, write a DB row, then redirect (303) to the result. The Post/Redirect/Get pattern means a refresh doesn't resubmit.
`GET /result/<id>`	result page, read back from the DB
`GET /history`	paginated history from the DB
`GET /health`	JSON health check

Validation (`serving/validation.py`): 1. **Wrong type.** Only `.jpg`, `.jpeg` and `.png` are accepted, the formats the model was trained on. Anything else returns 400 "Unsupported file type". 2. **Too large.** `MAX_CONTENT_LENGTH` = `MAX_UPLOAD_MB` (5 MB). Werkzeug rejects larger uploads *before reading them*, and a custom 413 page explains the limit. 3. **Looks like an image but can't be decoded.** Pillow fully decodes the bytes (`Image.open` + `load`). A `.jpg` containing junk returns 400 "could not be decoded". The content format must also really be JPEG or PNG, whatever the extension says.

Other protections: - **File names** are sanitised with `werkzeug.secure_filename`, so `../../evil name.png` is stored as `evil_name.png` and can't escape a folder. - **Nothing is kept on disk.** Werkzeug normally spools uploads over 500 KB into a temporary file. `app/__init__.py::InMemoryRequest` overrides `_get_file_stream` to use `BytesIO`, so the image only ever exists in RAM (bounded by the size limit) and is discarded after the request. Only its SHA-256 is stored. - **Friendly error pages** (`error.html`) cover 400, 404, 413, 503 (model API down) and 500. The 500 page logs the stack trace but never shows it to the user. - **Tests.** `tests/test_app.py` checks all three failure cases, file-name sanitising, the DB trail, `/health`, the 404 page and the API key (8 tests, all passing).

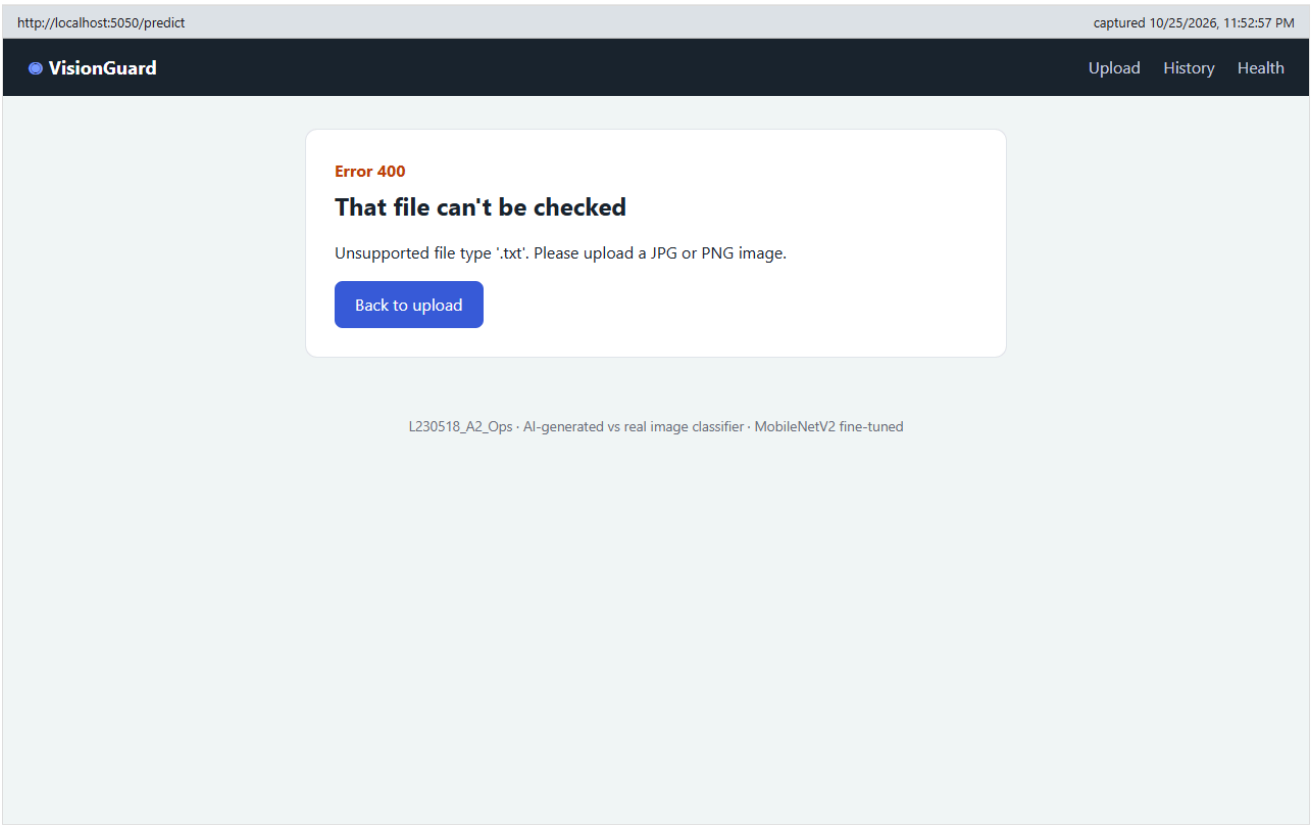


Figure 4.2a – wrong file type

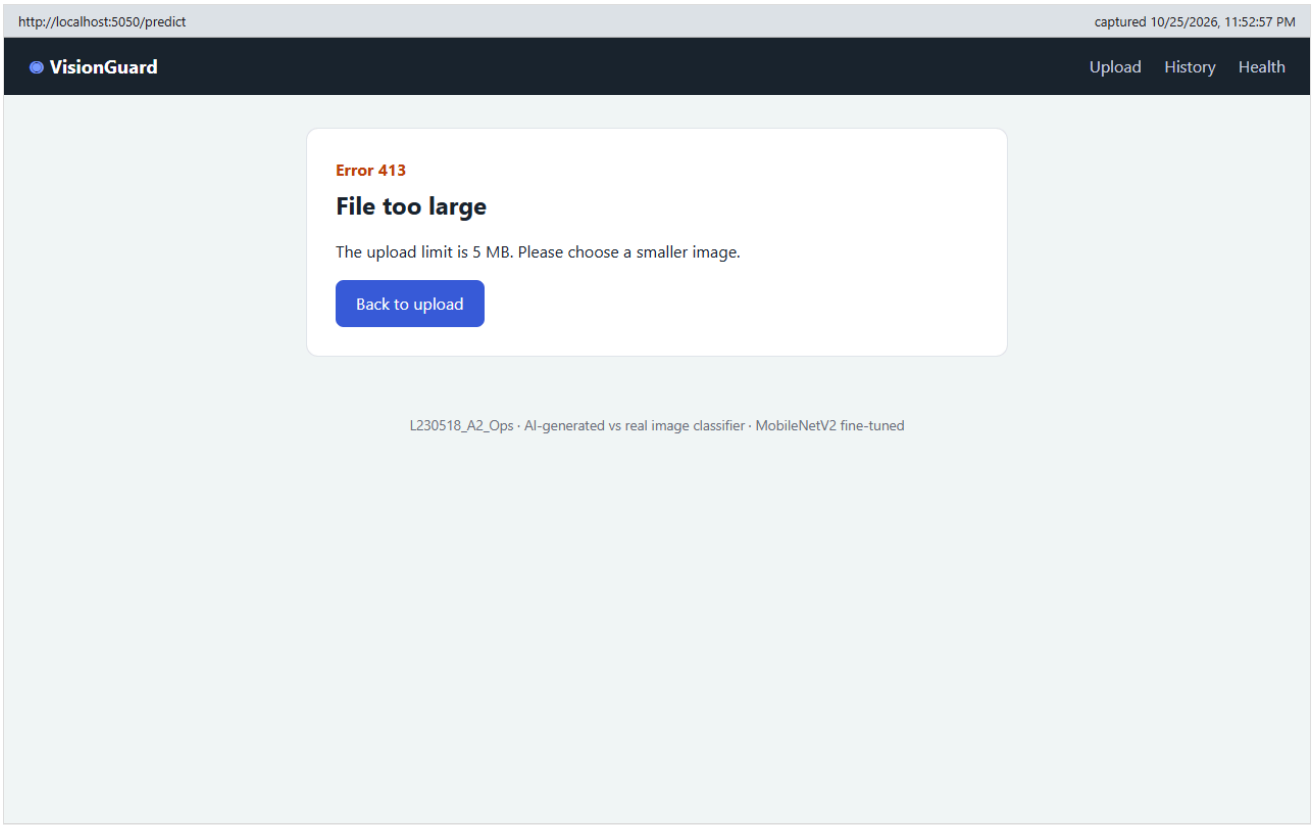


Figure 4.2b – file over the size limit

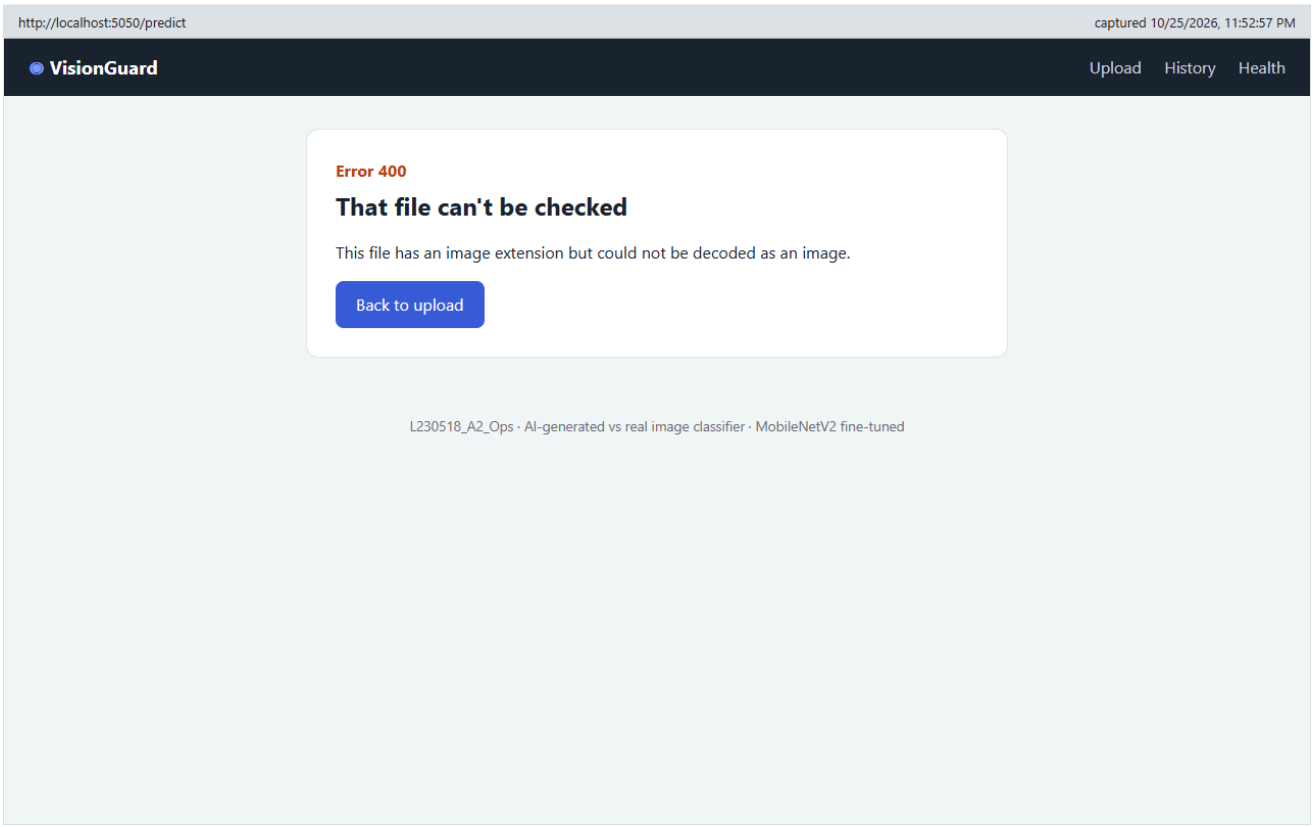


Figure 4.2c – file that looks like an image but cannot be decoded

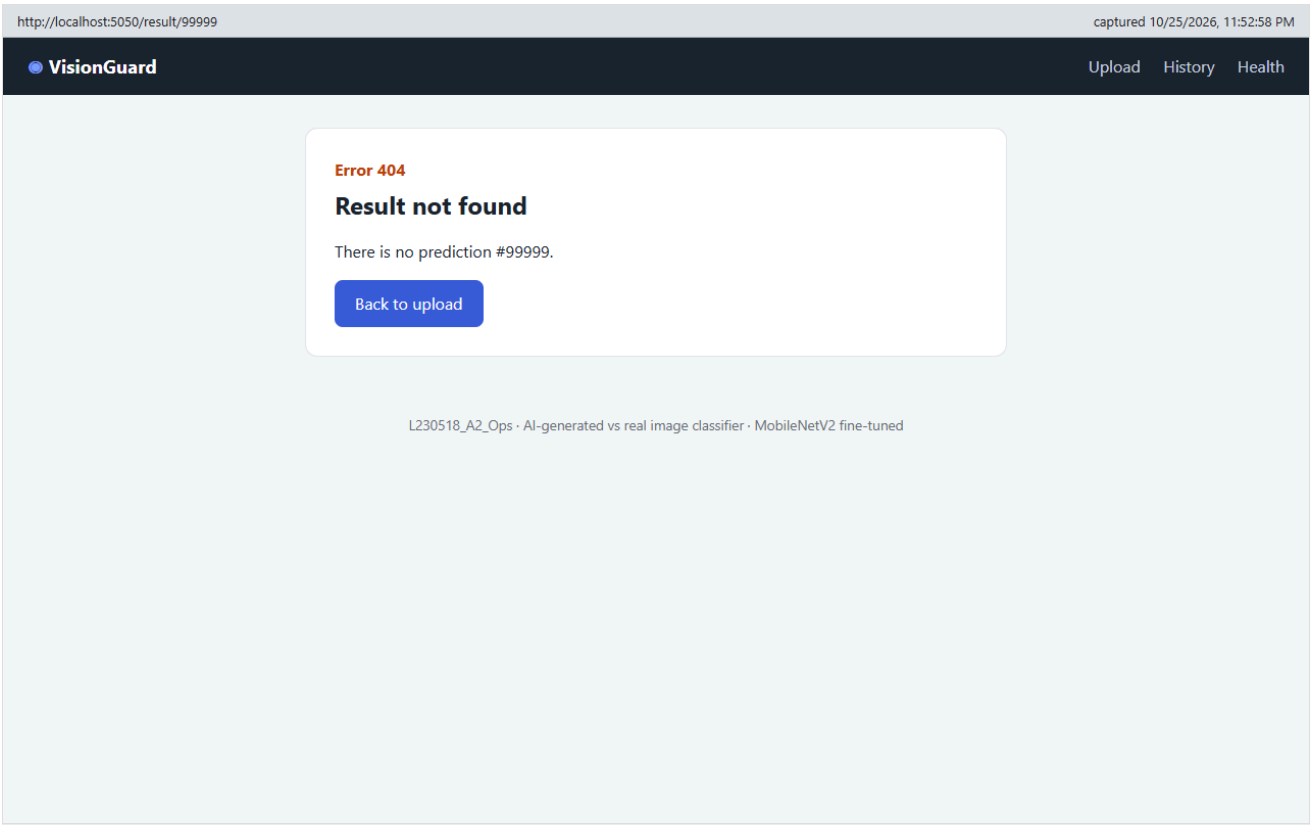


Figure 4.2d – unknown result id: friendly 404

4.3 HTML and CSS

There are four Jinja templates extending `base.html`, which has a nav bar with **Upload · History · Health** and one stylesheet (`app/static/style.css`). It uses no JavaScript framework; a 5-line script shows a preview of the chosen image.

The result page shows: - the verdict ("Likely AI-generated" or "Likely real"); - the confidence; - a bar with the p(AI) position and the threshold mark; - the model name and version, where the prediction was served from, the latency and the timestamp; - an **honest caveat** in plain words: the model is right about 3 in 4 times, flags roughly 1 in 5 real photos, and is confused by paintings and edited images, so the user shouldn't accuse anyone on this basis alone.

The caveat numbers are the measured test results from 2.5. The layout is responsive down to phone width.

The grey bar at the top of Figures 4.2–4.4 shows the page URL and capture time. A Playwright script added it while driving my local Chrome against the app on `localhost:5050` (real champion model, SQLite), because headless screenshots don't include the browser's own address bar.

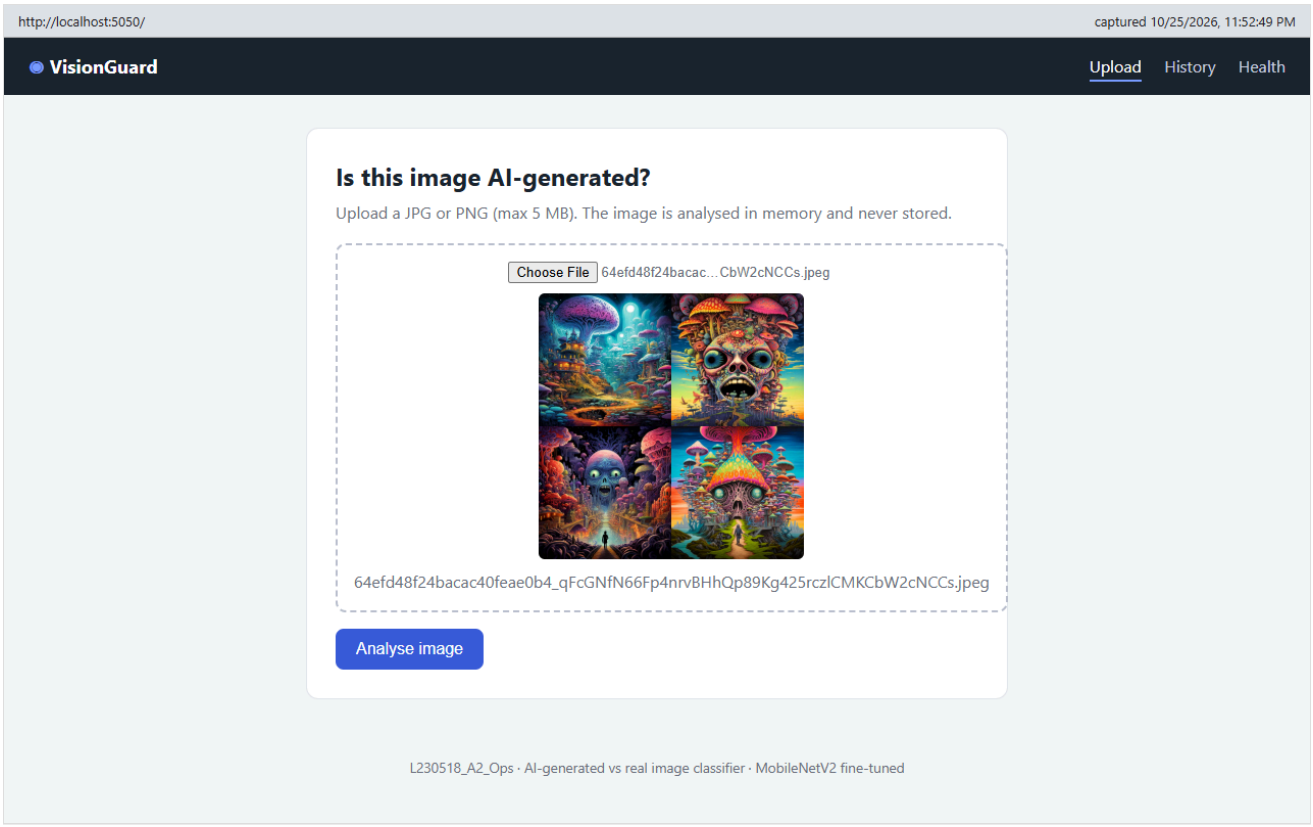


Figure 4.3a – upload page with preview

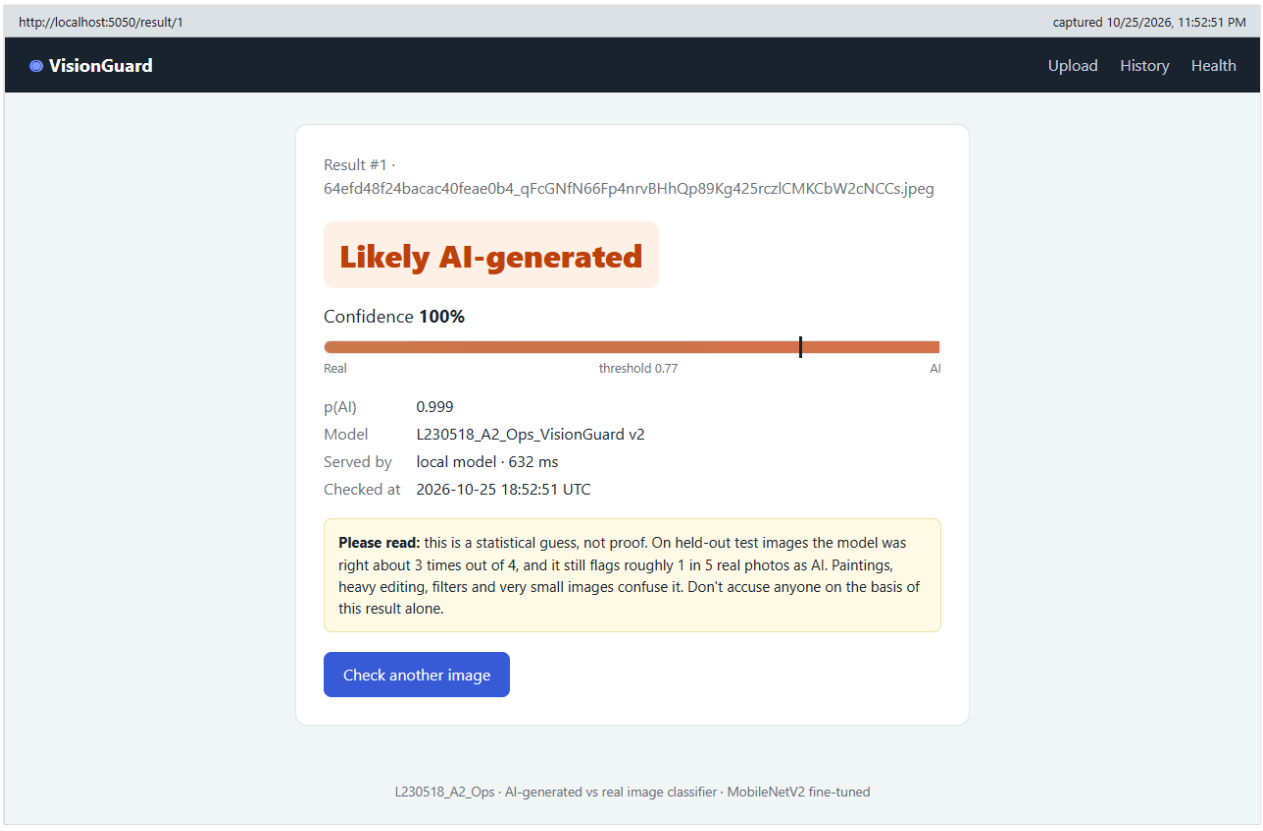


Figure 4.3b – result page: AI image, p(AI) = 0.999

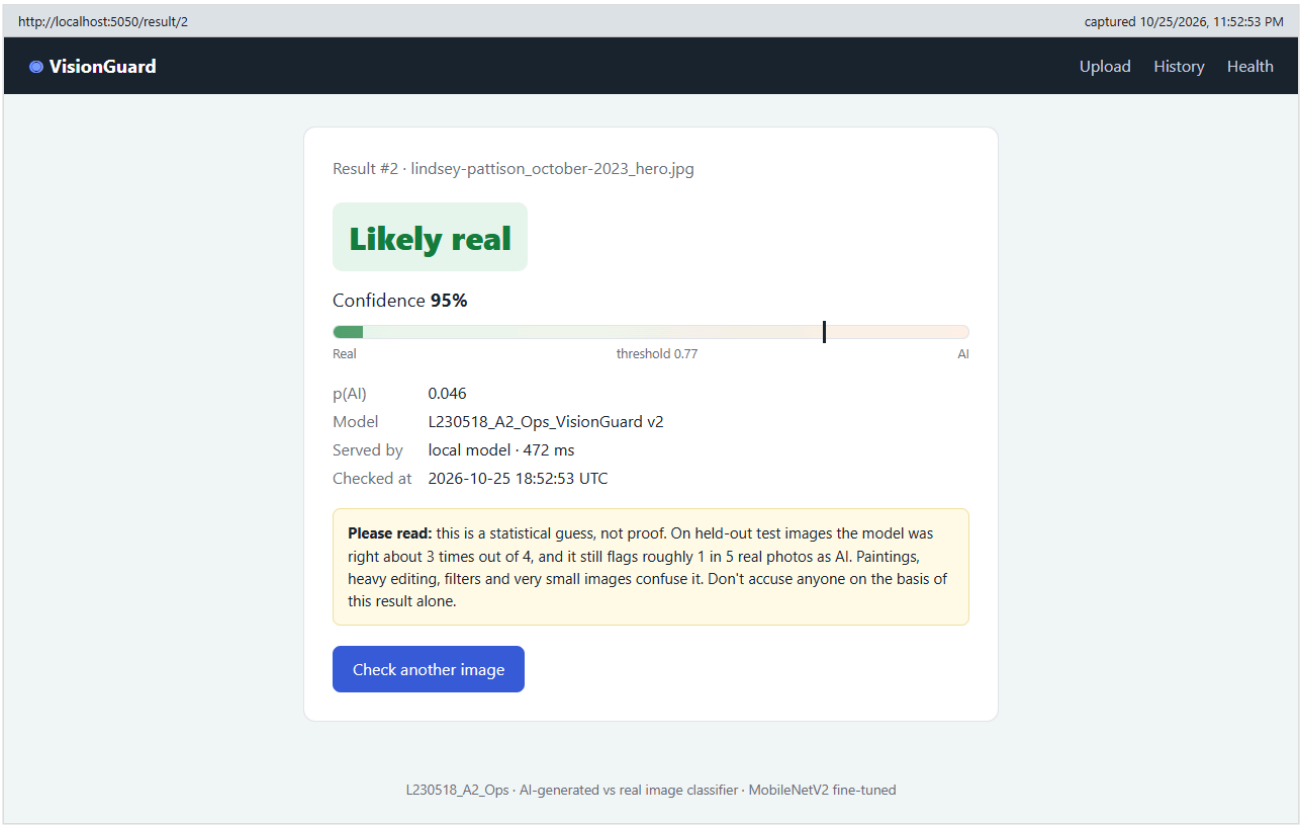


Figure 4.3c – result page: real photo, p(AI) = 0.046

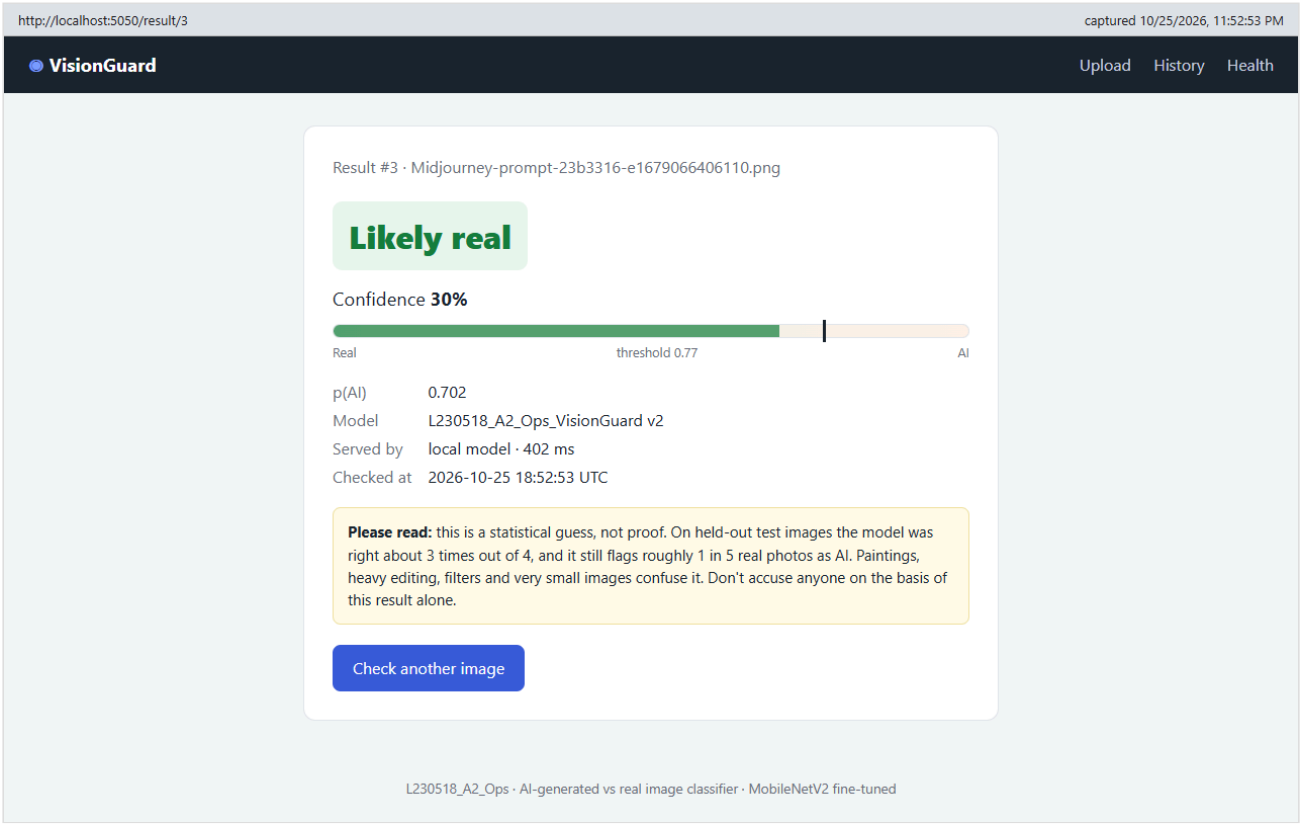


Figure 4.3d – result page: an AI image just below the threshold (p = 0.702) is shown as "Likely real" with only 30% confidence, which is exactly the case the caveat warns about

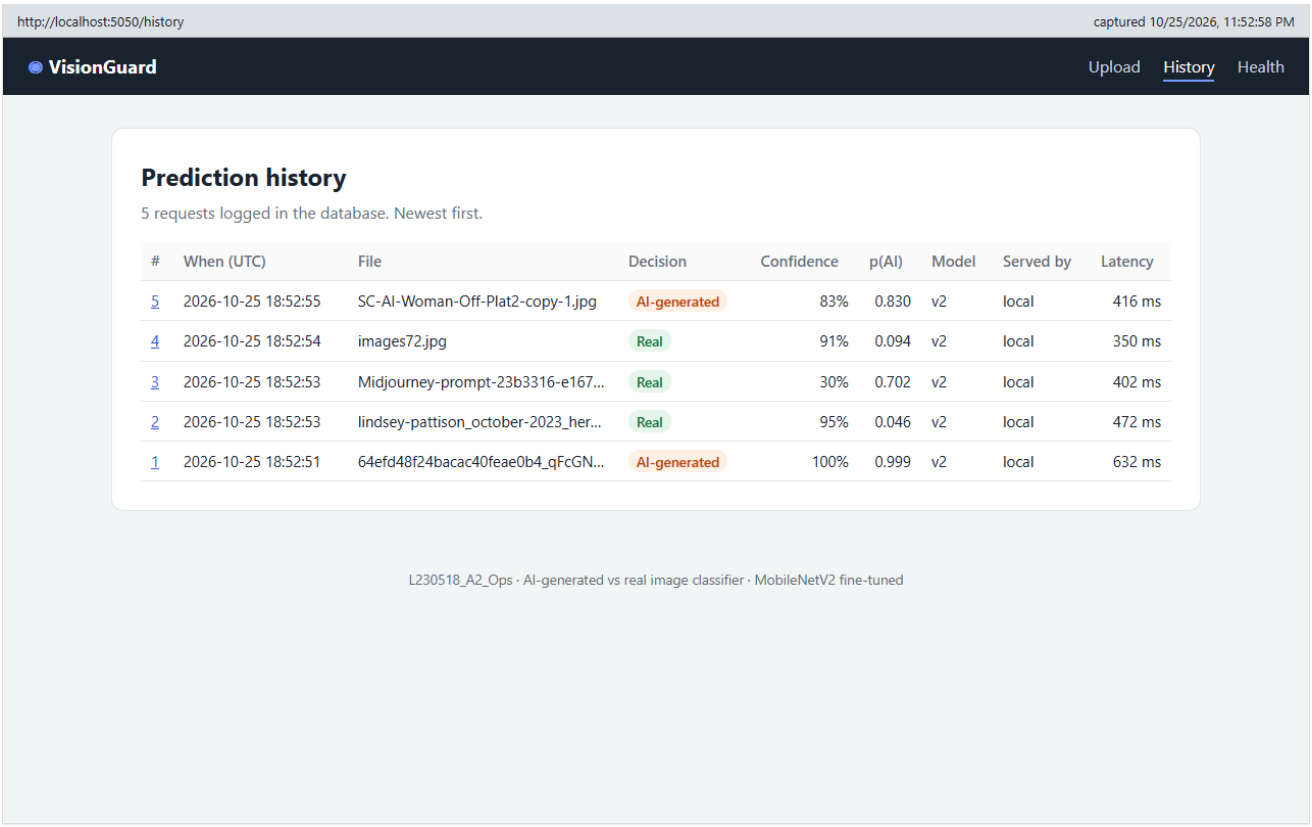


Figure 4.3e – history page

4.4 Configuration and production server

Configuration. `app/config.py` reads **every** setting from environment variables: `MODEL_PATH`, `THRESHOLD`, `DATABASE_URL`, `MAX_UPLOAD_MB`, `INFERENCE_MODE`, `MODEL_API_URL`, `MODEL_API_KEY`, `MODEL_API_TIMEOUT` and `SECRET_KEY`. The same image therefore runs locally, in Compose or in the cloud, with nothing hard-coded, and secrets stay out of Git and out of the image.

Server. - The app runs with `python wsgi.py web`, which serves the Flask app through **waitress**, a production WSGI server, with `debug=False`. - **Why not** `flask run --debug`**.** The Werkzeug development server is single-process and not hardened. Debug mode exposes an interactive debugger that can execute arbitrary Python from the browser, which means remote code execution. It also reloads code and leaks stack traces. - **Why waitress.** It handles concurrent requests with a thread pool and runs on both Windows and Linux.

Health check. `/health` returns:

```
{"database":"ok","inference_mode":"local","model_loaded":true,"model_version":"2","status":"ok","threshold":0.771}
```

The status code is 503 if the DB is unreachable. Docker uses this endpoint as the container `HEALTHCHECK`.

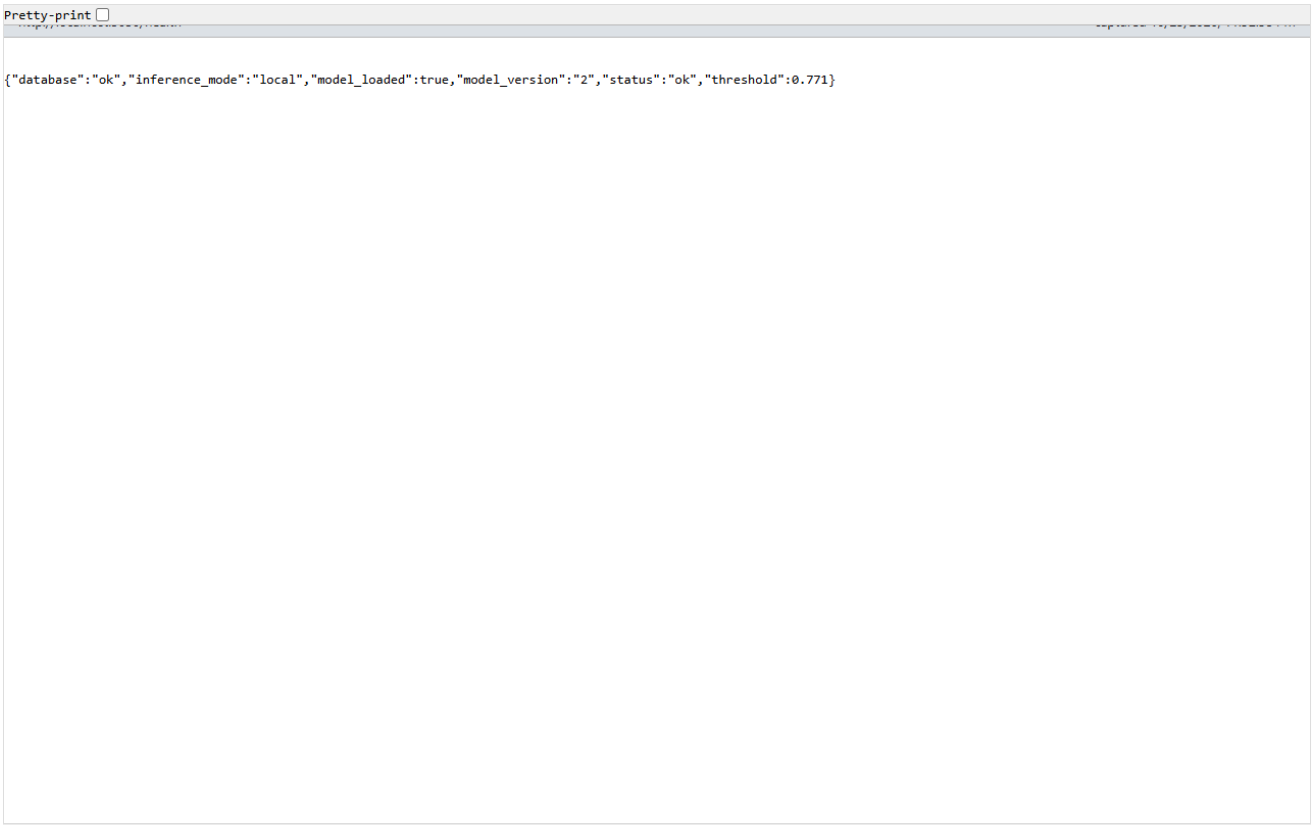


Figure 4.4 – health-check response

Chapter 5: Database trail

Table. `app/db.py` defines one SQLAlchemy table, `predictions`:

Column	Answers
`id`, `created_at` (UTC, indexed)	**when**
`filename` (sanitised), `sha256`	which image, without storing it
`label`, `p_ai`, `threshold`	**what was decided**
`confidence`	**how confidently**
`model_name`, `model_version`	**by which model**
`mode` (local / remote), `latency_ms`	where it ran, and how fast

Database. In Docker it is **PostgreSQL 16**. Without Docker the same code uses SQLite; only `DATABASE_URL` changes.

The view. - `POST /predict` inserts a row after every successful prediction, before redirecting. - The **History** menu (`/history`) reads the rows newest first, 20 per page, and shows time, file, decision, confidence, p(AI), model version, where it was served and latency. - Each row links to its result page, which is also rendered from the database. - Rejected uploads are not stored (no decision was made), but they are logged.

Querying it directly (Figure 5b):

```
SELECT id, created_at, label, round(p_ai::numeric,3), model_version, mode FROM predictions ORDER BY id DESC;
```

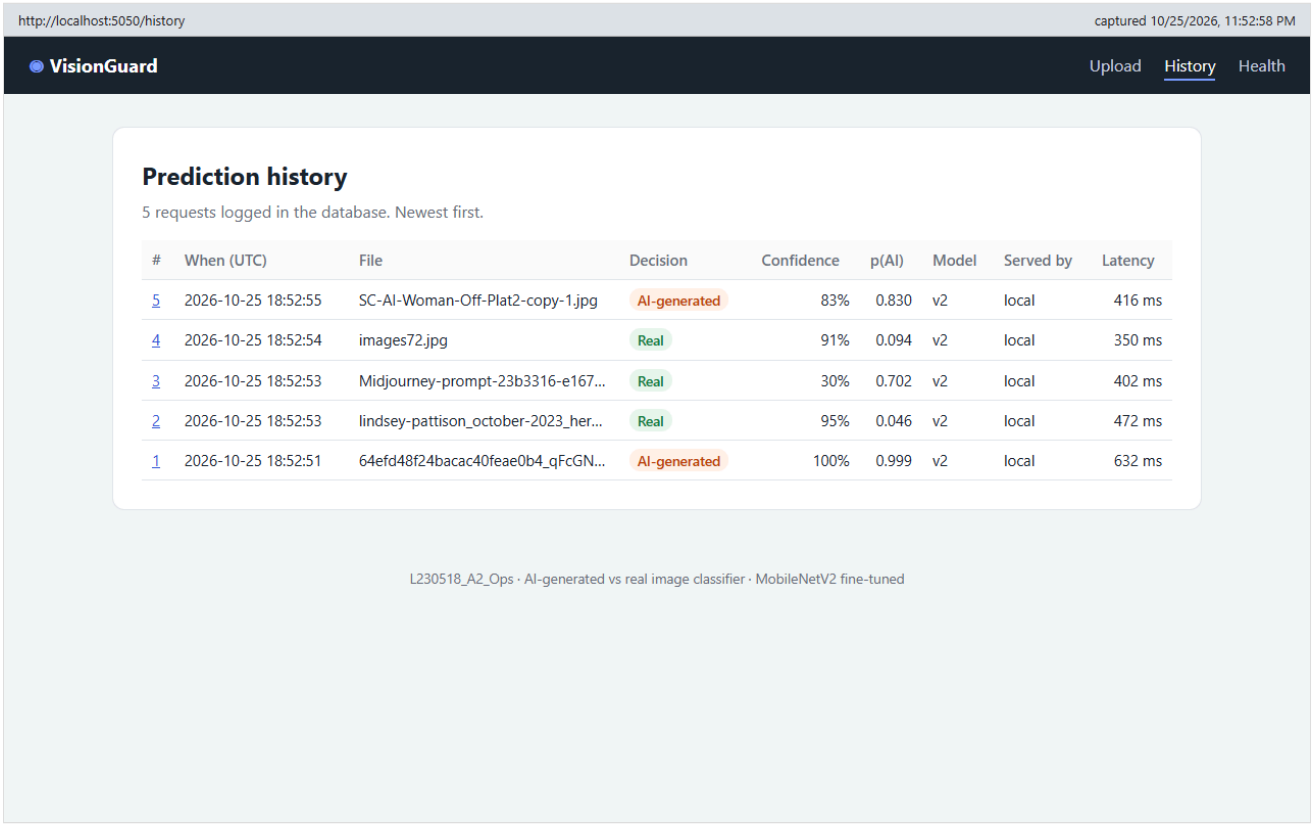


Figure 5a – history page from the database

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> docker compose exec db psql -U visionguar
d -d visionguard -c "select id, created_at, label, round(p_ai::numeric,3), model_version, mode from
 predictions order by id desc limit 10;"
 id | created_at | label | round | model_version | mode
----+------------+-------+-------+---------------+------
(0 rows)
```

Figure 5b – the predictions table was empty right after the stack started

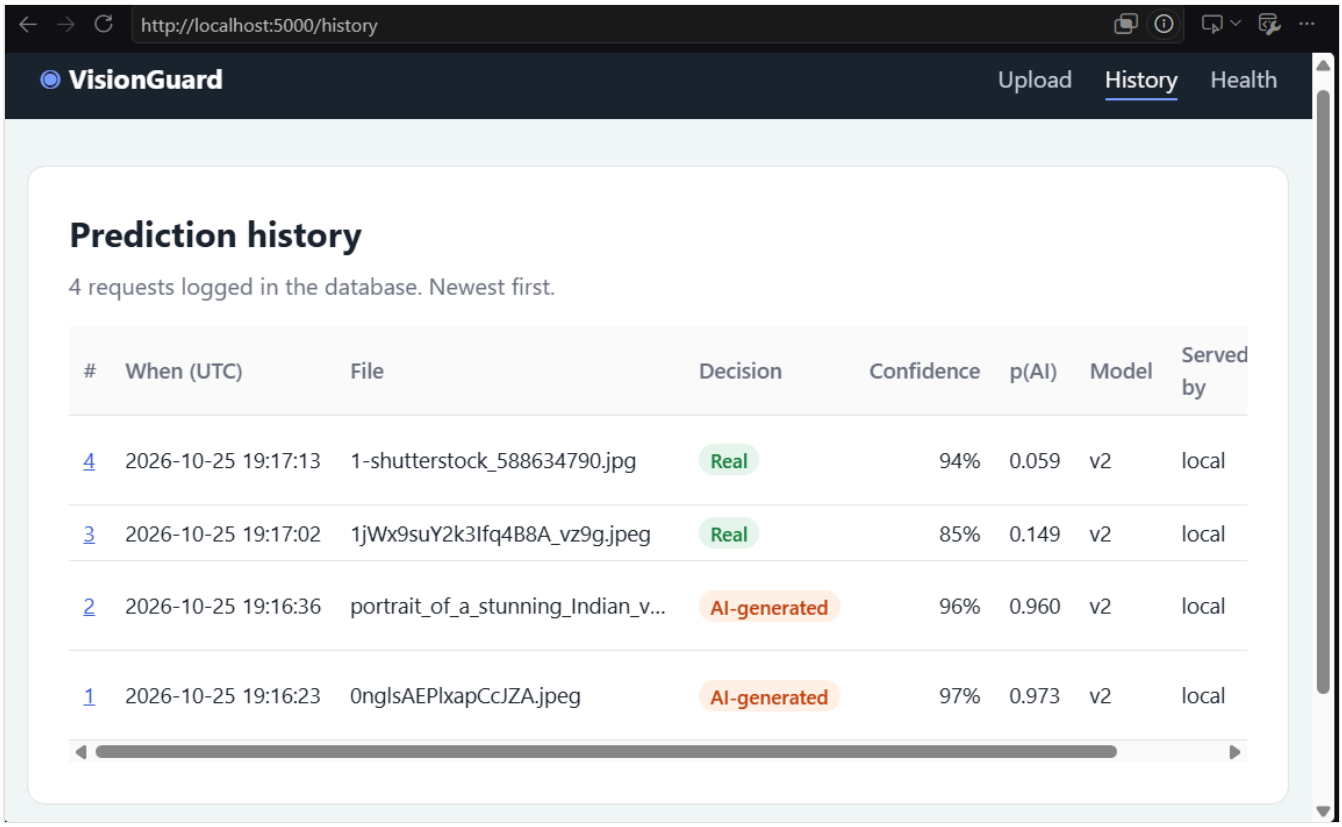


Figure 5c – history page served by the Compose stack (Postgres)

After 4 local and 6 remote predictions, the same table queried directly in Postgres (`docker compose exec db psql …`):

```
 id |     created_utc     |    label     | p_ai  | ver |  mode  |  ms
----+---------------------+--------------+-------+-----+--------+------
  1 | 2026-10-25 19:16:23 | AI-generated | 0.973 | 2   | local  | 1614
  2 | 2026-10-25 19:16:36 | AI-generated | 0.960 | 2   | local  | 1197
  3 | 2026-10-25 19:17:02 | Real         | 0.149 | 2   | local  |  338
  4 | 2026-10-25 19:17:13 | Real         | 0.059 | 2   | local  | 1018
  5 | 2026-10-25 21:33:36 | AI-generated | 0.999 | 2   | remote |   40
  6 | 2026-10-25 21:33:53 | AI-generated | 0.973 | 2   | remote |   57
  7 | 2026-10-25 21:34:15 | AI-generated | 0.996 | 2   | remote |   23
  8 | 2026-10-25 21:34:29 | Real         | 0.252 | 2   | remote |   24
  9 | 2026-10-25 21:34:41 | Real         | 0.151 | 2   | remote |   42
 10 | 2026-10-25 21:35:20 | AI-generated | 0.803 | 2   | remote |   23
(10 rows)
```

Each row answers what was decided (`label`, `p_ai`), when (`created_utc`), by which model (`ver` 2 of `L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard`) and how confidently. Rows survive container restarts because Postgres stores them in the `pgdata` volume.

Chapter 6: Containerisation with Docker and Docker Compose

6.1 Docker warm-up

I practised with the ready-made `nginx:alpine` image before touching my own project:

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> docker pull nginx:alpine
>> docker images
b9b388a21ecf: Downloading  8.389MB/20.53MB
b9b388a21ecf: Pull complete
7cc330898115: Pull complete
26185d08a3ec: Pull complete
2ec5fb117ffa: Pull complete
12b85cff06fd: Pull complete
9b0f7dfe35b2: Pull complete
657023555a2a: Pull complete
a4d5b1f57abc: Download complete
acc2d54c3743: Download complete
Digest: sha256:a3554c0d0b48177b1413c26e01f695334428020d9df01243fbae3e11cfd17417
Status: Downloaded newer image for nginx:alpine
docker.io/library/nginx:alpine

What's next:
    View a summary of image vulnerabilities and recommendations → docker scout quickview nginx:alpi
ne

                                                                  i Info →   U  In Use
IMAGE                                ID             DISK USAGE   CONTENT SIZE   EXTRA
axllent/mailpit:v1.31.3              ed9b00c609e7       50.7MB         14.3MB    U
caseguard-ai:latest                  cb1dc9856e37        410MB         98.8MB    U
caseguard-api:latest                 8df842766cc8        346MB           82MB    U
caseguard-web:latest                 6778deb1768e        382MB         92.6MB    U
gotenberg/gotenberg:8                aa552cc115db       2.43GB          674MB    U
livekit/livekit-server:latest        89ca9ce0791e        140MB         43.8MB    U
mysql:8.0                            7dcddc01f13b        1.1GB          249MB    U
n8nio/n8n:latest                     23a26975c21a       2.47GB          384MB
```

Figure 6.1a – docker pull downloads the image layer by layer; docker images lists local images

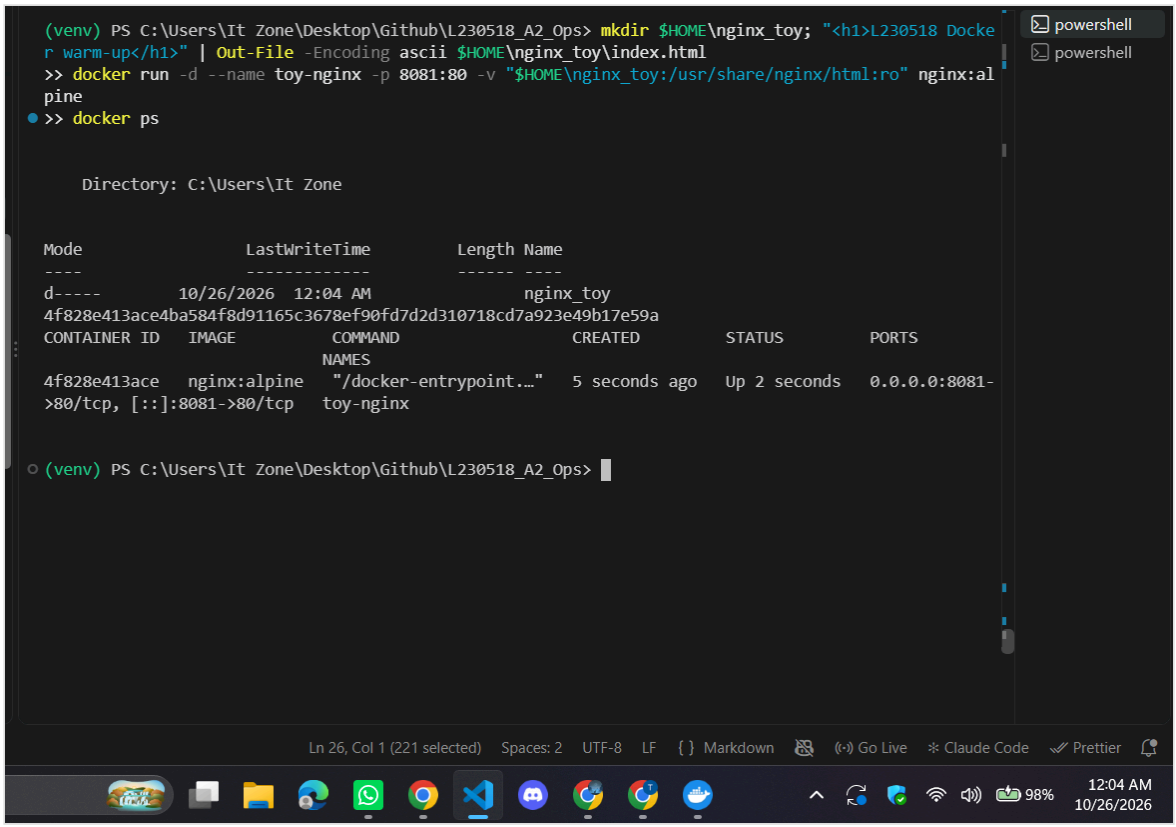


Figure 6.1b – docker run -d -p 8081:80 -v $HOME\nginx_toy:/usr/share/nginx/html:ro; docker ps shows the mapping 0.0.0.0:8081->80

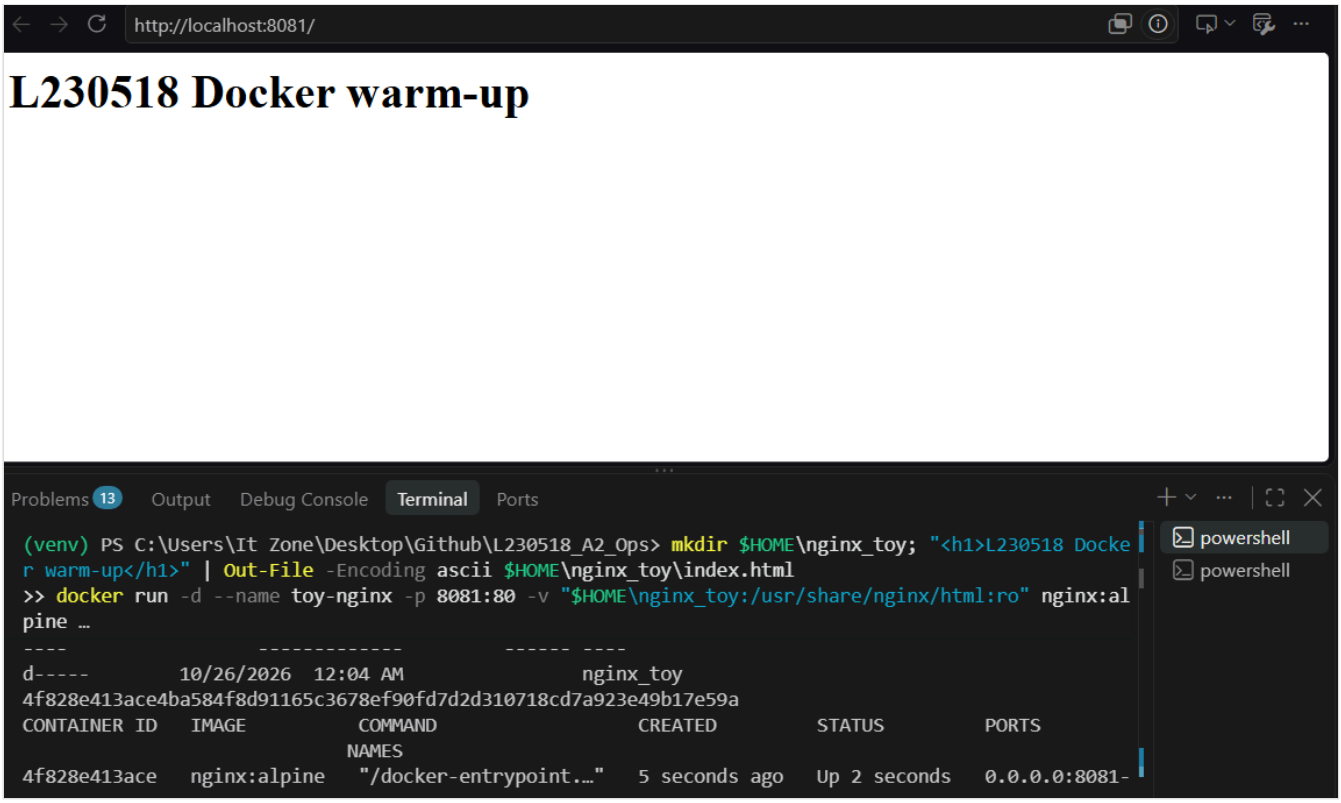


Figure 6.1c – the page served from my mounted folder at localhost:8081

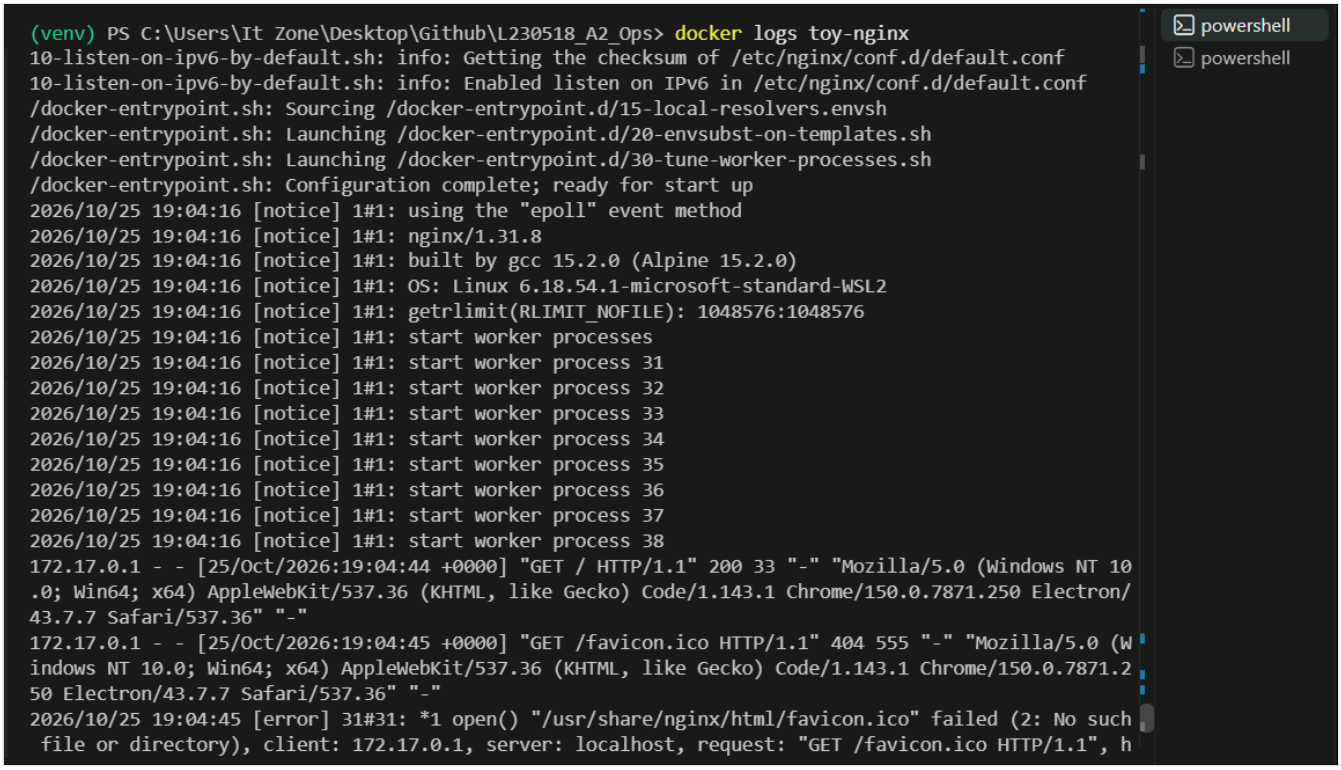


Figure 6.1d – docker logs: nginx start-up plus my two browser requests

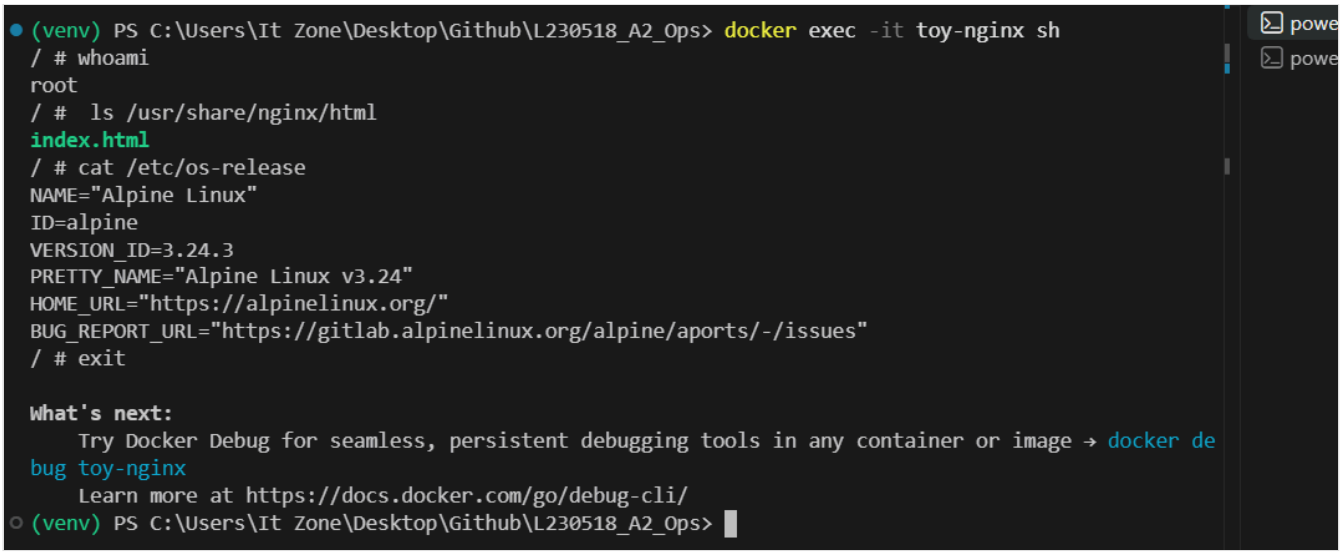


Figure 6.1e – docker exec -it toy-nginx sh: a shell inside the container (root, Alpine 3.24, my mounted index.html)

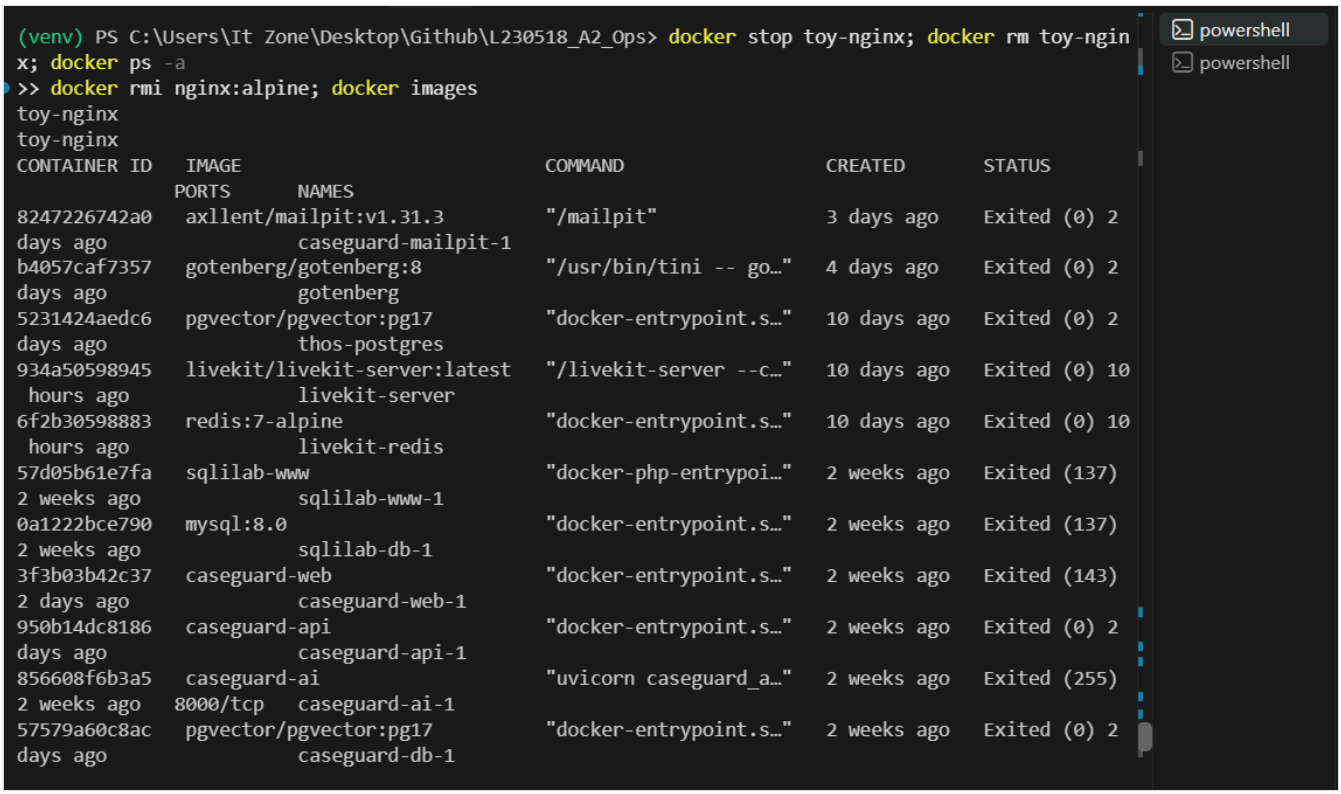


Figure 6.1f – docker stop / rm / ps -a / rmi

What each step shows: - `-v` made my host folder appear inside the container, so editing `index.html` on Windows changes the page without a rebuild. - `-p 8081:80` forwarded host port 8081 to the container's port 80. - Inside the container `whoami` returns `root`. That is the default which my own Dockerfile avoids (6.2).

Definitions (my own words): - **Image**: a read-only template (filesystem + metadata such as the default command), built from a Dockerfile and identified by name:tag. - **Container**: a running (or stopped) instance of an image. It is a process with its own isolated filesystem, network and process space, plus a thin writable layer on top of the image. - **Layer**: each Dockerfile instruction produces a filesystem diff. Layers are stacked, shared between images and cached, so unchanged steps are not rebuilt. - **Volume**: storage managed outside the container's writable layer. Data in it survives container removal (our Postgres data), or it maps a host folder into the container (our model). - **Port mapping** (`-p host:container`): forwards a port on the host to a port inside the container's private network, e.g. `-p 5000:5000` makes the app reachable at localhost:5000.

6.2 Dockerfile for the web app

The file is `Dockerfile`. The order of instructions, and why: 1. `FROM python:3.12-slim`. It is Debian slim: about 120 MB instead of about 1 GB for the full `python:3.12` image. It still uses glibc, so TensorFlow wheels install without compiling (Alpine's musl would force source builds). 2. `ENV`. No `.pyc` files, unbuffered logs, `PIP_NO_CACHE_DIR`, and TF log level 2. 3. **Copy only the requirements files, then** `pip install --no-cache-dir`. - This layer is the slowest and biggest (TensorFlow). - Docker reuses a cached layer as long as its inputs are unchanged. Because only the requirements files are copied before it, editing Python code **doesn't** invalidate this layer. - A code change rebuilds in seconds instead of re-downloading about 600 MB. 4. **Copy the source code last** (`src/config.py`, `src/preprocess.py`, `serving/`, `app/`, `api/`, `wsgi.py`). 5. `useradd app` + `USER app`. The container runs as an unprivileged user (UID 10001). A compromise of the app would not have root inside the container. 6. `HEALTHCHECK`. It calls `/health` every 30 s, with a 60 s start period because the model takes time to load. Docker and Compose then report `healthy` or `unhealthy`. 7. `CMD ["python", "wsgi.py", "web"]`. It starts waitress, with debug off.

Ignore file. `.dockerignore` excludes `venv/`, `data/` (500 MB), `mlruns/`, `tuner_logs/`, `.git`, `.env` and all non-champion models. This keeps the build context small and **keeps secrets out of the image**.

Secrets. No secret appears in the Dockerfile. Passwords and keys arrive at run time as environment variables, from Compose, or as encrypted environment variables on the cloud host.

TensorFlow package. I chose `tensorflow-cpu==2.21.0` (with `keras==3.15.1`, the training versions) instead of `tensorflow`. - The full Linux wheel bundles CUDA/GPU kernels, which the server (no GPU) would never use, and its installed size is several hundred MB bigger. - Inference on one 224×224 image takes about 0.3 s on a CPU, which is fast enough for this product.

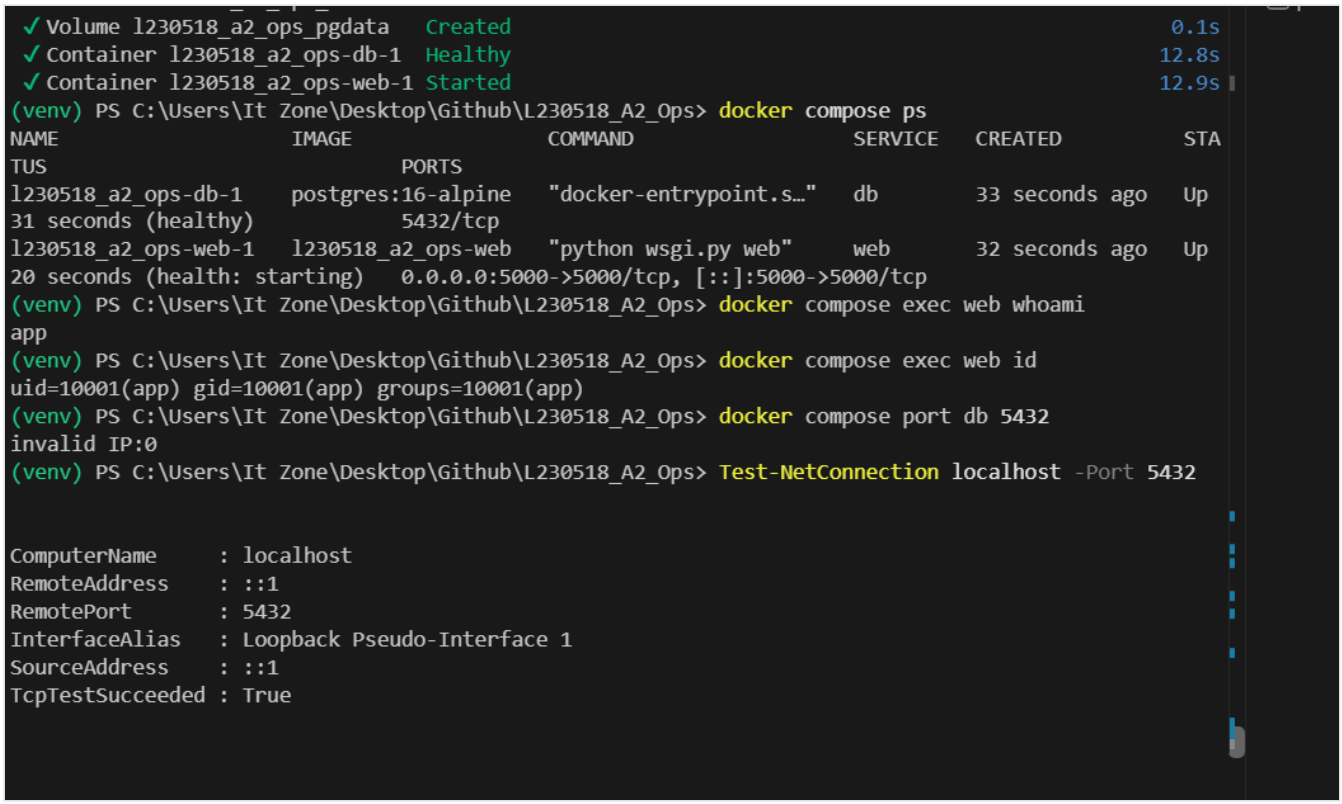


Figure 6.2 – docker compose exec web whoami → app; id → uid=10001(app), not root

6.3 Compose stack

The file is `docker-compose.yml`. It defines two services: - `db`: `postgres:16-alpine`. - Data lives in the **named volume** `pgdata`, so history survives `docker compose down` and rebuilds. - **Health check:** `pg_isready` every 5 s. - It has **no** `ports:` **section**, so Postgres is reachable only on Compose's internal network and is closed from outside. - `web`: built from the Dockerfile. - `depends_on: db: condition: service_healthy` means it starts only when Postgres accepts connections, so it never crashes on a not-yet-ready DB. - It reaches the DB **by service name**: `DATABASE_URL=postgresql+psycopg://…@db:5432/…`. Compose's internal DNS resolves `db`. - It publishes port 5000 for the browser.

Passwords. All passwords and keys are `${VAR}` substitutions read from the untracked `.env`. `.env.example` (committed) lists every variable with placeholder values.

How the model reaches the container: mounted. `./models:/models:ro` (read-only bind mount). Reasons: - The model is versioned by the **registry**, not by the image. Promoting a new champion means re-running `scripts/export_champion.py` and restarting the container, with no rebuild. - The 17 MB model is not baked into an image that CI builds from GitHub, where `models/` is git-ignored. - Read-only means the app can't modify it.

For the cloud, the opposite choice is right, and `Dockerfile.api` builds the model in. That is explained in Chapter 7.

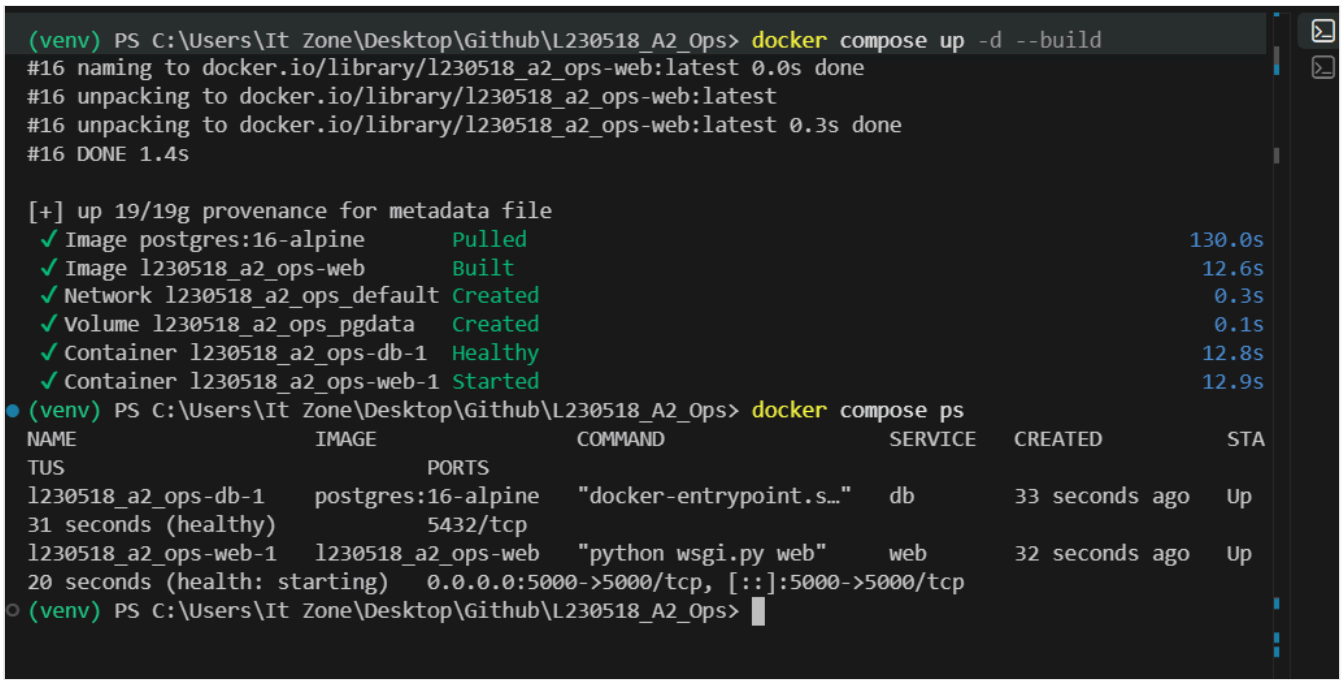


Figure 6.3a – docker compose up: network, named volume, db Healthy before web starts; ps shows db 5432/tcp with no host mapping

Proof that the database port is closed, and a trap I fell into. - `docker compose port db 5432` returns nothing usable ("invalid IP:0"): Compose publishes no host port for `db`. - `docker compose ps` lists it only as `5432/tcp`, with no `0.0.0.0:` mapping. - `docker inspect l230518_a2_ops-db-1` confirms it: `PortBindings {}` and `"5432/tcp": null`.

However, `Test-NetConnection localhost -Port 5432` returned **True** (Figure 6.2). From the logs and tools alone I traced why: - `netstat -ano` shows PID 7268 listening on 5432. - `tasklist` names it `postgres.exe`, which is the Windows service `postgresql-x64-17`, a separate PostgreSQL 17 installed natively on my laptop for another course. - The container runs PostgreSQL 16.

So the open port belongs to a different server. The Compose database itself is only reachable on the internal network, as `db:5432` from `web`. The lesson: a port check proves a port is open, not *which* process owns it.

```
 > netstat -ano | findstr :5432          TCP 0.0.0.0:5432  LISTENING  7268
> tasklist /FI "PID eq 7268"           postgres.exe   (service postgresql-x64-17)
> docker inspect l230518_a2_ops-db-1 --format '{{json .HostConfig.PortBindings}} {{json
.NetworkSettings.Ports}}'
{} {"5432/tcp":null}
```

6.4 Image analysis

Image	Base	TF package	pip cache	Size
`visionguard:naive` (`Dockerfile.naive`)	python:3.12 (full)	tensorflow	kept	**5.92 GB** on disk (1.75 GB compressed)
`l230518_a2_ops-web` (`Dockerfile`)	python:3.12-slim	tensorflow-cpu	none	**2.23 GB** on disk (0.42 GB compressed)

Largest layers (`docker history`, Figures 6.4b–c):

Layer	naive	optimised
`pip install` (TensorFlow + deps)	**2.96 GB**	**1.67 GB**
base OS (Debian full vs slim)	hundreds of MB (compilers, headers)	87.7 MB
source code	16.9 MB (`COPY . .` , everything)	about 0.2 MB in 5 small layers



Figure 6.4a – building the naive image (the pip step alone took 17 min)

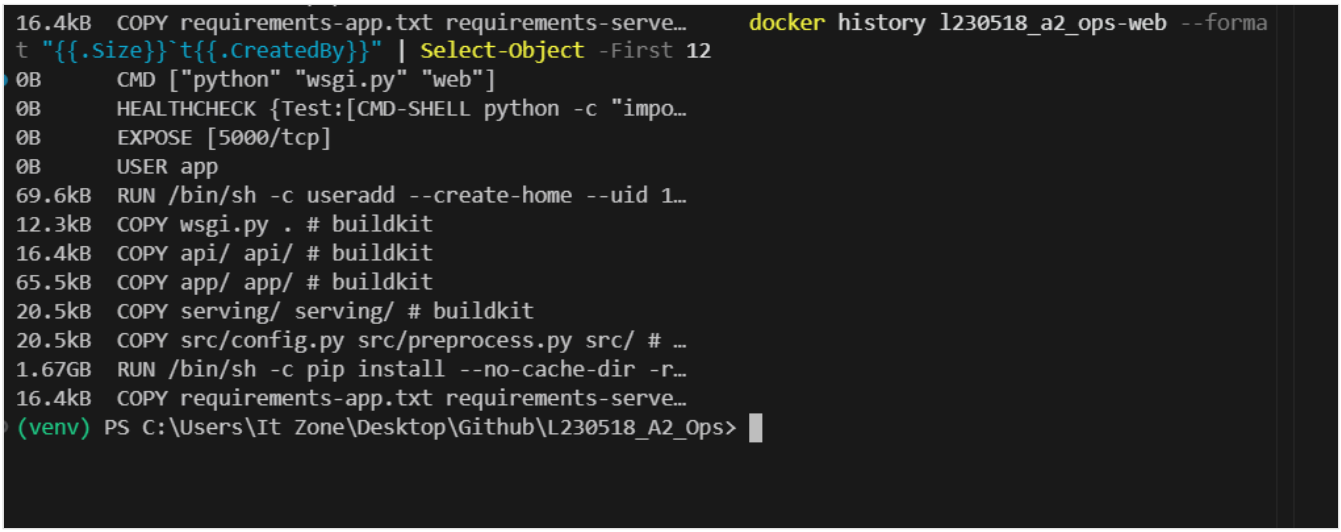


Figure 6.4b – layers of the optimised image: the pip layer dominates, code layers are kilobytes

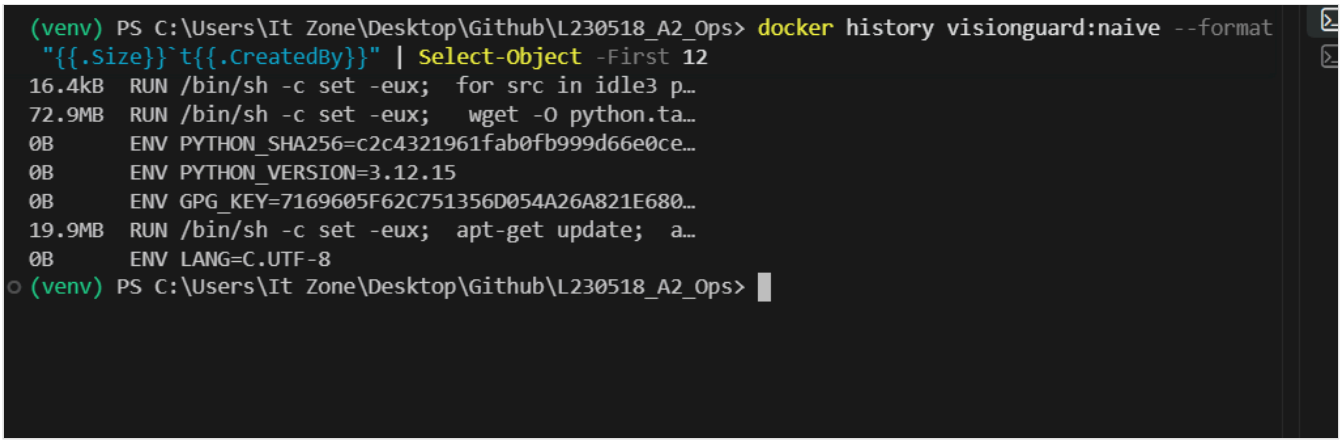


Figure 6.4c – layers of the naive image

Optimisation applied. A slim base, the CPU-only `tensorflow-cpu` wheel instead of `tensorflow`, `--no-cache-dir`, and the ignore file.

Conclusion. The image went from **5.92 GB to 2.23 GB on disk (−62%)** and from 1.75 GB to 0.42 GB compressed (−76%), which is what is pulled over the network. - Almost all of the saving is in the dependency layer (2.96 → 1.67 GB): the GPU/CUDA build of TensorFlow and the pip cache are gone. - The slim base removed most of the rest.

The naive `COPY . .` before `pip install` also means *any* code change re-runs the 17-minute install. The optimised order rebuilds in seconds.

6.5 Operations and troubleshooting

The everyday commands are `docker compose stop / start / restart web / logs --tail 30 <svc> / exec <svc> sh`. The listings for them are in RUNBOOK §6.5 (Figures 6.5c–f).

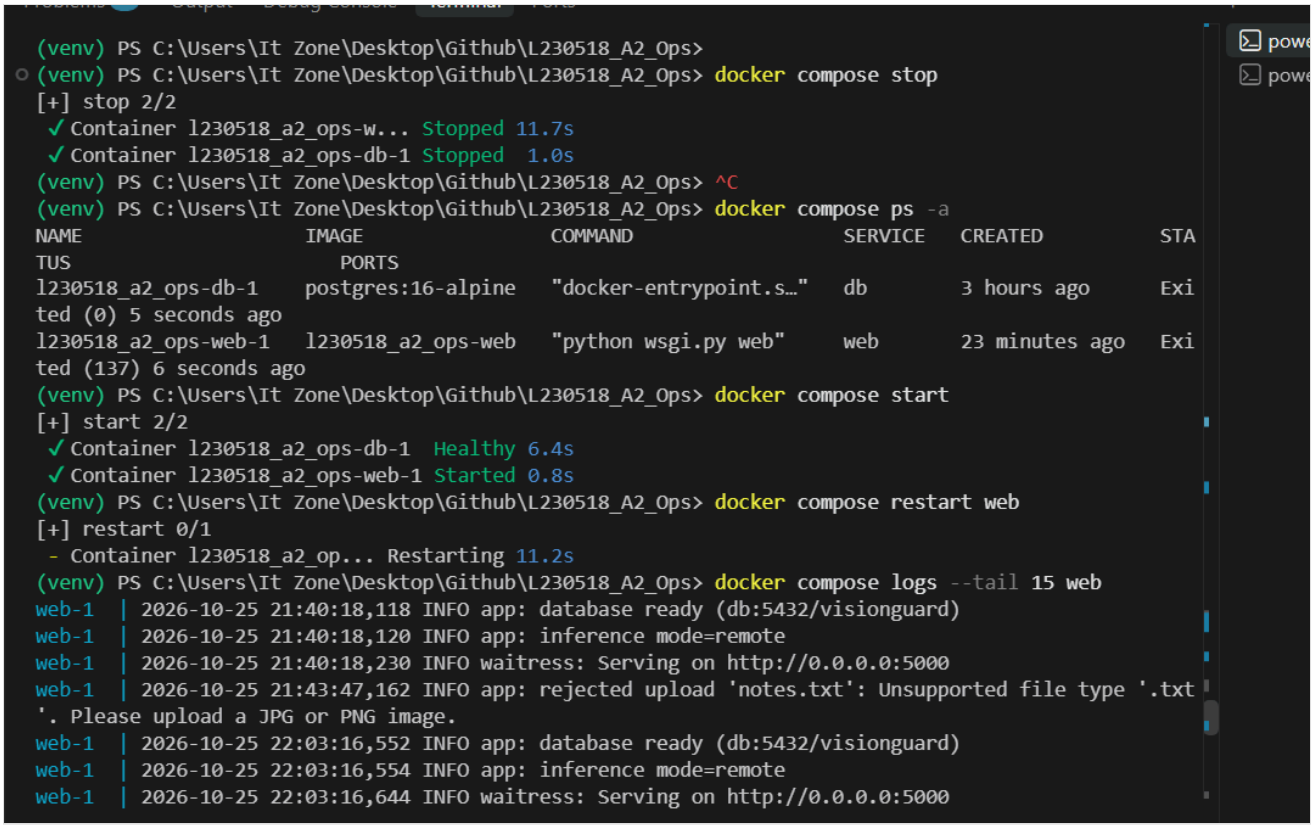


Figure 6.5c – stop (both services Exited), start (db Healthy first), restart web, logs of web

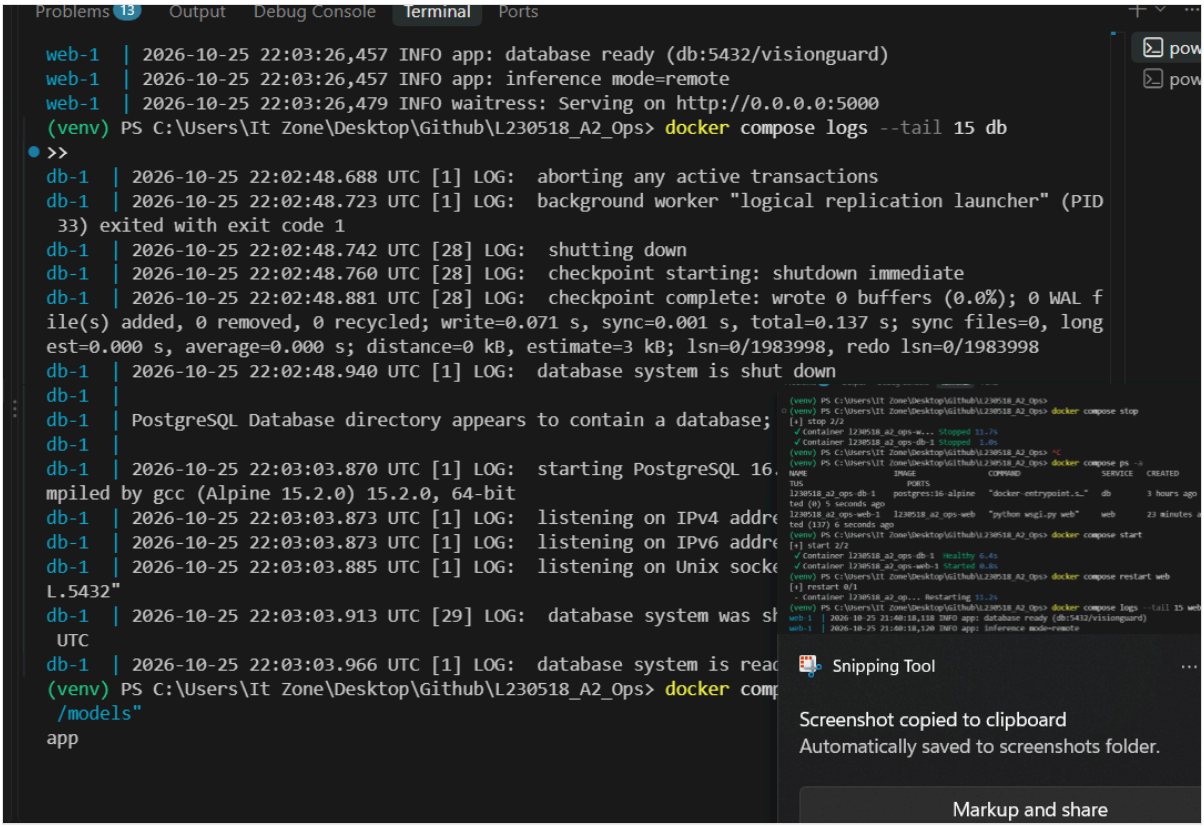


Figure 6.5d – logs of db: clean shutdown, then "database system is ready" on start; shell into web

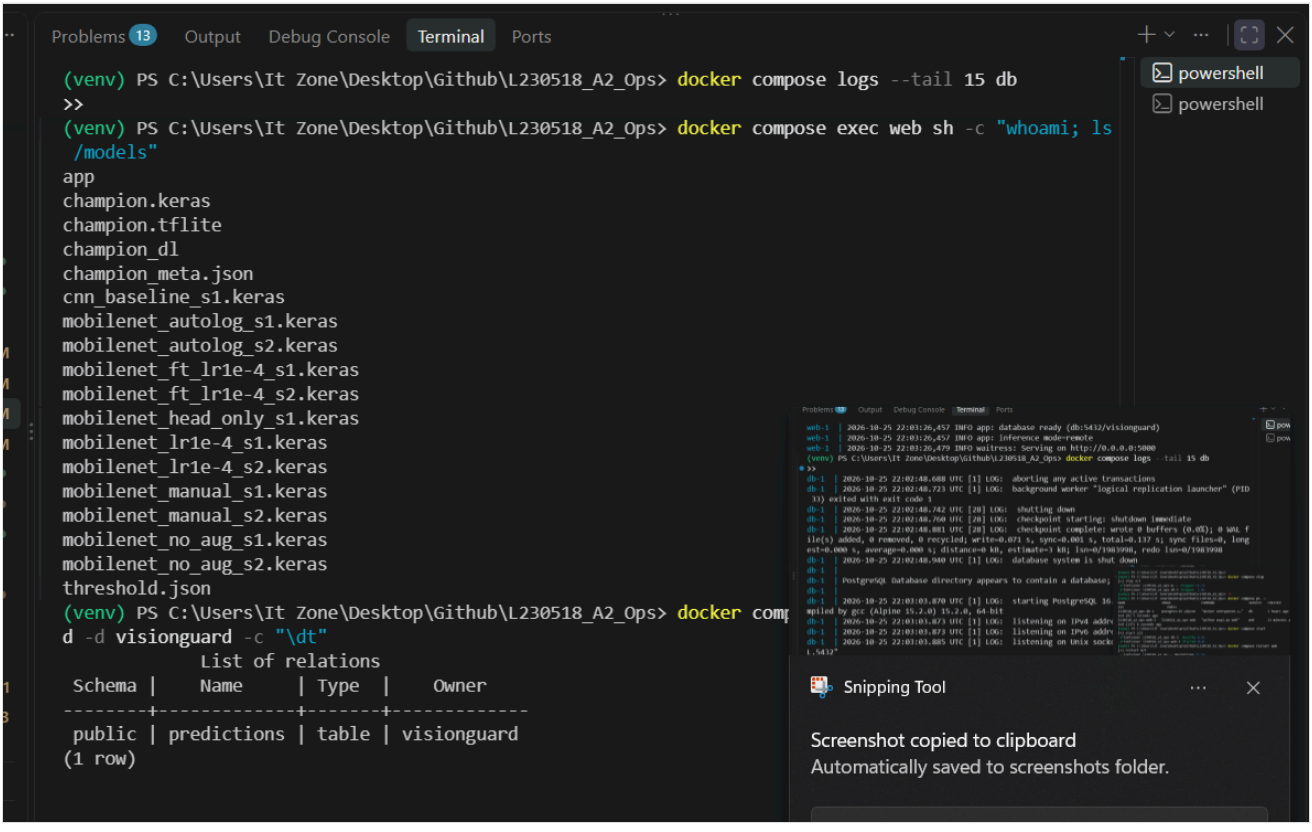


Figure 6.5e – a shell inside each service: web runs as app and sees the mounted /models; psql inside db lists the predictions table

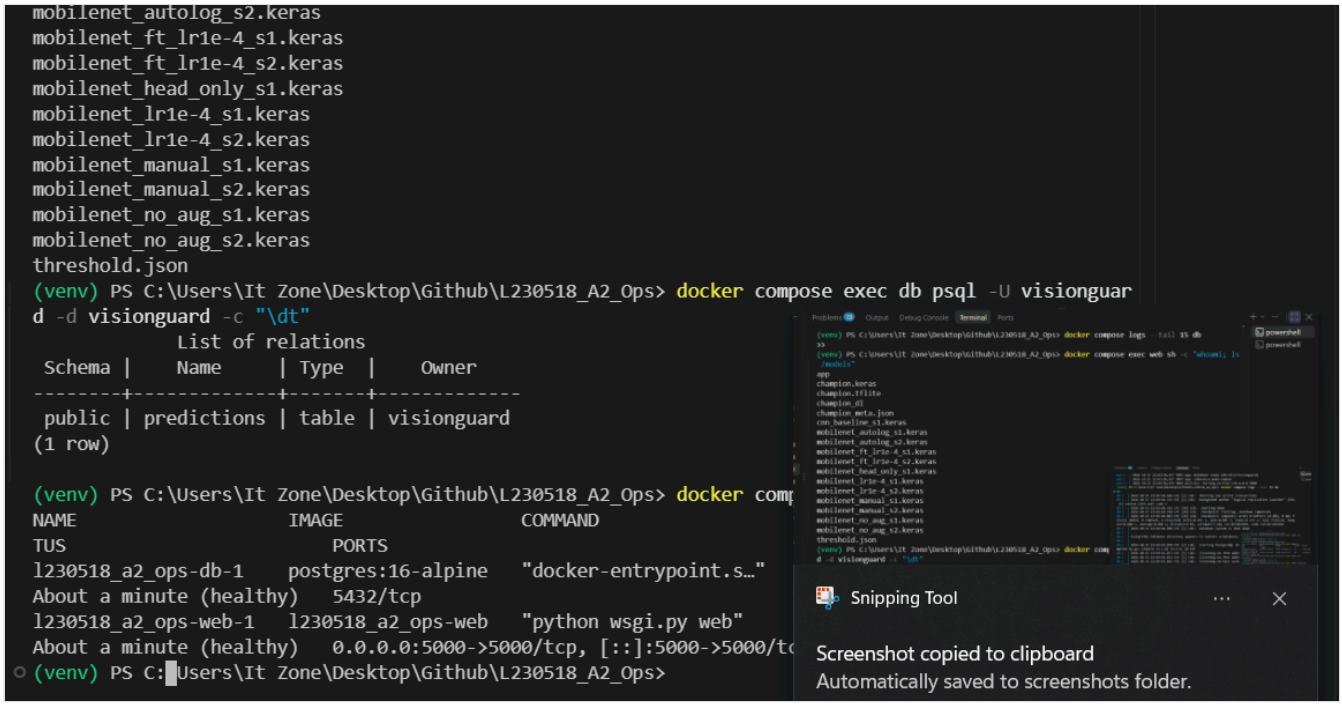


Figure 6.5f – both services healthy again after the restart cycle

The `web` container stopped with exit code 137. Docker sends SIGTERM and, after the 10 s grace period, SIGKILL, because waitress doesn't handle SIGTERM fast enough. That is harmless here: every prediction is committed before its response is sent.

Deliberate failure: missing model file. 1. I renamed `models/champion.keras` and recreated `web`. - My first `docker compose logs` ran **before** the new container had printed anything, so it showed nothing (Figure 6.5a). - A few seconds later the container was crash-looping (`Up 3 seconds`, restarted by `restart: unless-stopped`) and the logs showed the cause. 2. **Diagnosis, from the logs only** (`docker compose logs web`):

```
web-1 | INFO app: database ready (db:5432/visionguard) web-1 | Traceback (most recent call last): web-1 | File "/srv/wsgi.py", line 18, in <module> web-1 | app, port = create_app(), int(os.getenv("PORT", "5000")) web-1 | File "/srv/app/__init__.py", line 21, in create_app web-1 | app.extensions["vg_predictor"] = predictor or make_predictor(cfg) # model loaded ONCE here web-1 | File "/srv/app/predictors.py", line 11, in __init__ web-1 | self._p = Predictor(cfg.MODEL_PATH, cfg.THRESHOLD) web-1 | File "/srv/serving/inference.py", line 14, in __init__ web-1 | FileNotFoundError: model file not found at /models/champion.keras (run scripts/export_champion.py or mount the models folder)
```

The traceback ends in `Predictor.__init__`, which runs at start-up, so the problem is the mount or the file, not the code. The first line shows the database connection worked, which rules out the DB. 3. **Fix:** restore the file (or re-export the champion), then `docker compose up -d --force-recreate web`. The service returned to `healthy` (Figure 6.5b).

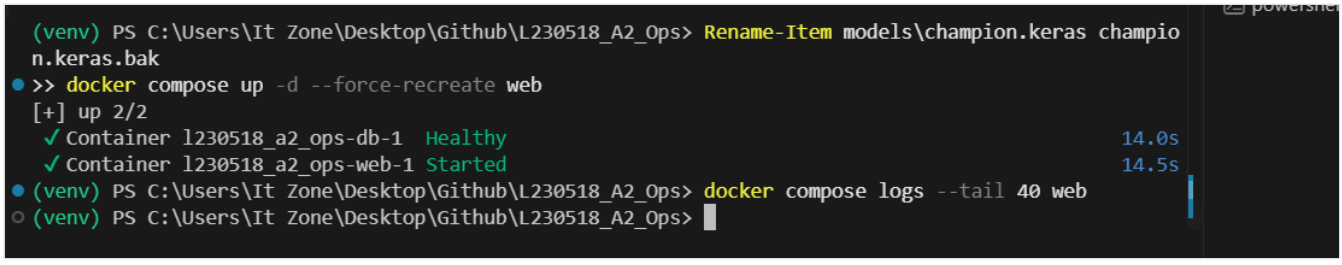


Figure 6.5a – breaking it: model renamed, container recreated (logs not yet written)

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops> Rename-Item models\champion.keras.bak c
mpion.keras
>> docker compose up -d --force-recreate web
>> docker compose ps
[+] up 2/2
 ✓ Container l230518_a2_ops-db-1  Healthy                                                    1.
 ✓ Container l230518_a2_ops-web-1 Started                                                    2.
NAME                   IMAGE                COMMAND                  SERVICE   CREATED
STATUS                          PORTS
l230518_a2_ops-db-1    postgres:16-alpine   "docker-entrypoint.s…"   db        About an hour ago
Up 13 minutes (healthy)         5432/tcp
l230518_a2_ops-web-1   l230518_a2_ops-web   "python wsgi.py web"     web       2 seconds ago
Up 1 second (health: starting)  0.0.0.0:5000->5000/tcp, [::]:5000->5000/tcp
(venv) PS C:\Users\It Zone\Desktop\Github\L230518_A2_Ops>
```

Figure 6.5b – fixed: model restored, web recreated and starting healthy

I made the error message name the exact path and the command that fixes it, so that this diagnosis works from logs alone.

6.6 Tool lab: GitHub Actions (CI)

Toy part. The repository `Rebelhere/L230518_A2_Ops_ci_toy` has a workflow `.github/workflows/ci.yml`: - it runs on every push; - it uses a **matrix of Python 3.11 and 3.12**; - it installs pytest and runs `test_calc.py`.

I changed one assertion to make it fail (red run), then fixed it (green run).

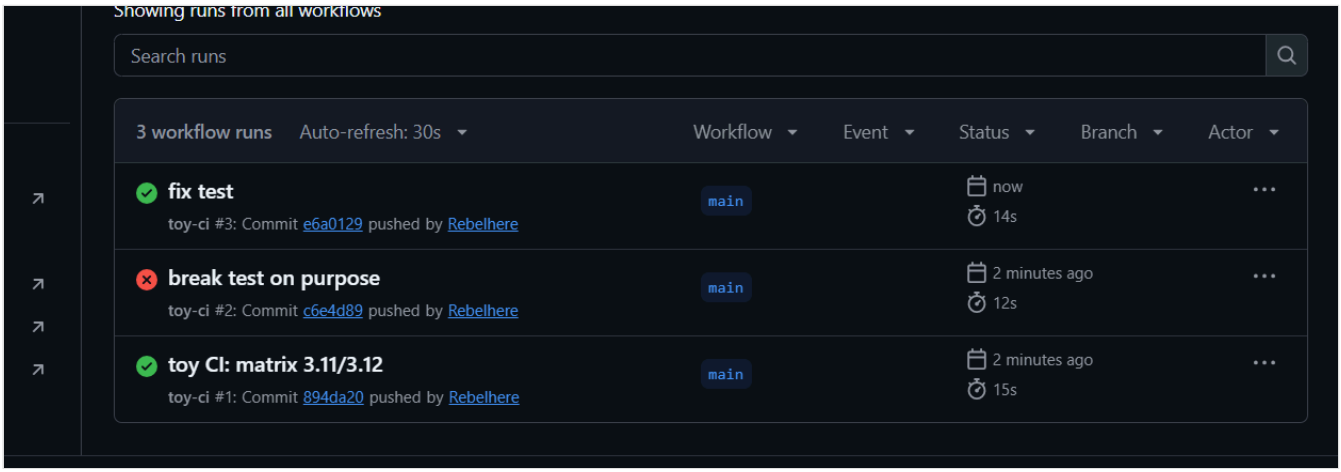


Figure 6.6a – toy repo Actions: green first run (matrix 3.11/3.12), red after breaking a test, green after the fix

Apply. The VisionGuard workflow (`.github/workflows/ci.yml`) has two jobs: - `test`: checkout, set up Python 3.12 with a pip cache, install `requirements-app.txt` + pytest + ruff, then **lint** with `ruff check` and run the **tests** with `pytest`. - The tests use a fake predictor and SQLite, so CI doesn't need TensorFlow or the model and takes about a minute. - `docker`: needs `test` to pass, then **builds the Docker image**, which proves the Dockerfile and requirements still work.

The README shows the status badge.

Where workflow secrets are stored. In the repository's **Settings → Secrets and variables → Actions**. They are encrypted at rest, injected only at run time as `${{ secrets.NAME }}`, and masked as `***` in logs. They must never be written in the workflow file. That file is committed to Git, so everyone who can read the repository (here, the whole internet) would see the secret, and it would stay in the Git history forever even after deletion. This workflow needs no secrets at all.

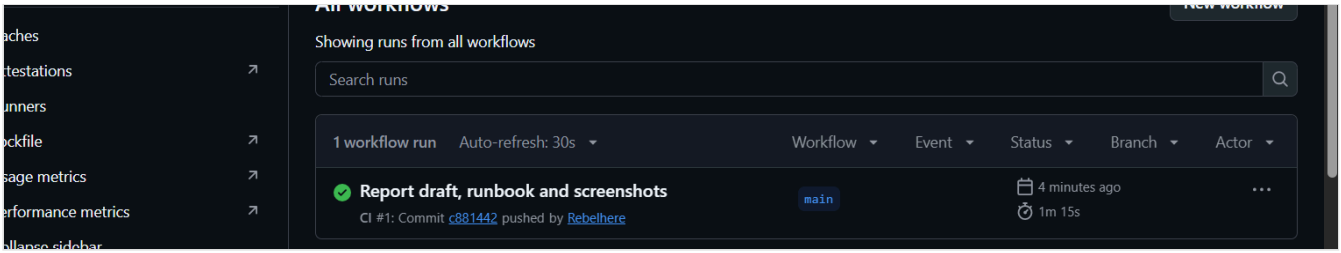


Figure 6.6b – first VisionGuard CI run: lint, tests and Docker build all green

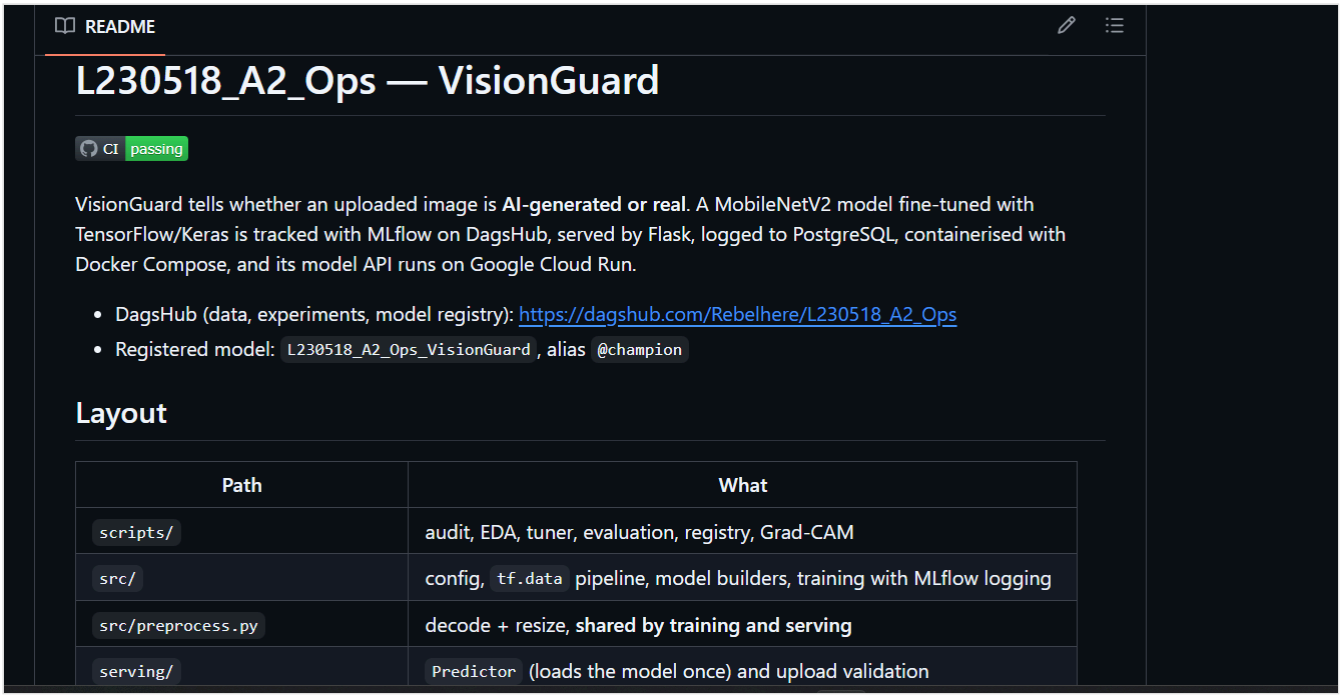


Figure 6.6c – the CI status badge (passing) at the top of the README on GitHub

Chapter 7: API deployment (Vercel)

7.1 Choosing the platform

I tried three platforms before settling on Vercel: - **Google Cloud Run** needs a billing account even for free-tier use. I created the project `l230518-a2-ops` (Figure 7.1a), but Google rejected my payment card, a SadaPay virtual card included (`OR_BACR2_31`, Figure 7.1b). - **Azure for Students** needs only a university email, but sign-in failed because of a problem with my university account password. - **Vercel** (the Hobby plan, signed in with GitHub, no card) is named in the assignment. It hosts the model API; Flask and the database stay on localhost, as Task 7 asks.

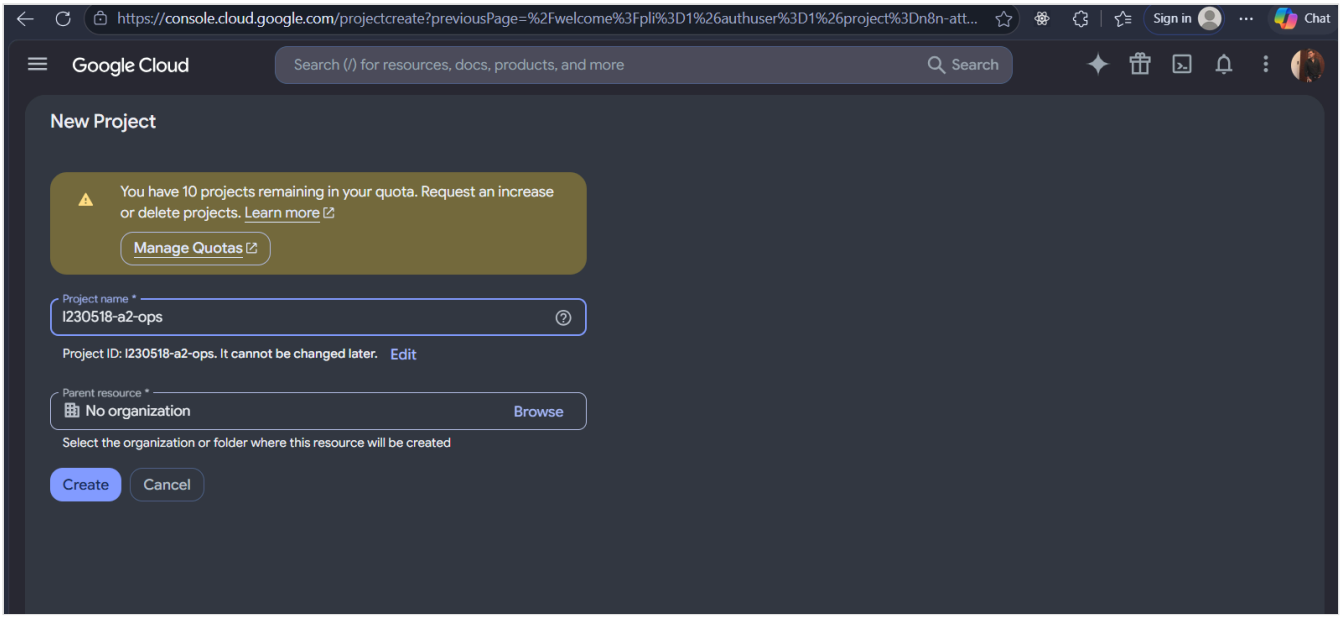


Figure 7.1a – GCP project l230518-a2-ops

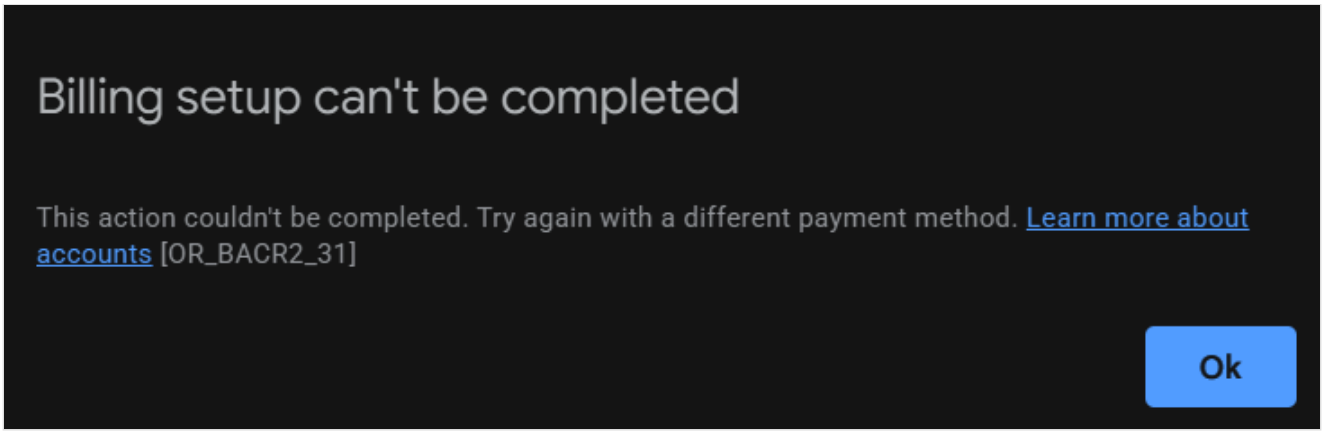


Figure 7.1b – billing rejected

The obstacle: Vercel can't run TensorFlow. A Python function there is limited to about 250 MB once unzipped, and `tensorflow-cpu` alone is larger. There is also no persistent disk and a **4.5 MB request-body limit**.

The solution: serve a TFLite copy of the champion. - `scripts/export_tflite.py` exports `champion.keras` to a SavedModel and converts it with `TFLiteConverter` to `champion.tflite`. It stays float32 (no quantisation) to keep accuracy identical, and is 8.9 MB. - The `[-1, 1]` `preprocess_input` op is part of the converted graph. - The function runs it with Google's **LiteRT** runtime (`ai-edge-litert`, about 60 MB unzipped). The whole function comes to roughly 130 MB. - `serving/lite.py::decode_resize_np` replaces TF preprocessing with Pillow decoding plus a NumPy port of `tf.image.resize`'s bilinear kernel (half-pixel centres, no antialiasing).

7.2 Checking that the cloud model gives the same answers

Changing the runtime and the preprocessing is a deliberate change to the serving path. That is exactly where training/serving skew (4.1) comes from, so I measured it before deploying. `scripts/check_tflite_parity.py` compares, on all 146 test images (`reports/tflite_parity.csv`):

Comparison	max abs Δp(AI)	mean abs Δp
Keras vs TFLite, **same** TF preprocessing (conversion only)	3.1×10^{-6}	5.3×10^{-7}
Keras + TF preprocessing vs TFLite + NumPy preprocessing (what Vercel computes)	3.6×10^{-2}	4.9×10^{-3}
Same decision at t = 0.771	**146 / 146**	

The conversion is exact. The remaining gap comes from preprocessing, and I traced it to the JPEG decoder rather than my resize code: - Decoding with TF and resizing with my NumPy code differs from `tf.image.resize` by at most 0.04 pixel levels, which is rounding. - `tf.io.decode_image` defaults to libjpeg's **fast integer DCT**, and Pillow uses the **accurate** one. Their pixels differ by up to 20/255. - With `dct_method="INTEGER_ACCURATE"`, TF matches Pillow **exactly**.

Both decoders are valid, and Pillow has no option for TF's fast mode. Because the effect is small (mean Δp 0.005) and never flips a decision on the test set, I accepted it and documented it, instead of shipping TensorFlow just to decode JPEGs.

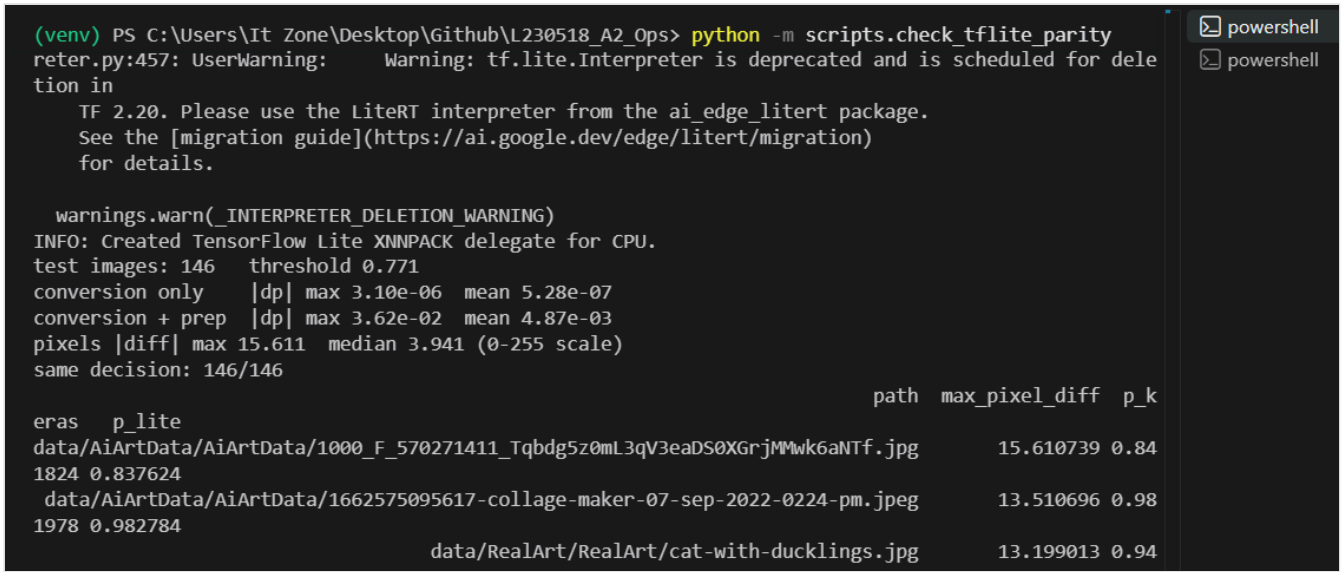


Figure 7.2 – parity check output

7.3 The model API

The Vercel function uses the same `api/main.py` as the container version. Only `MODEL_PATH` (`.tflite` vs `.keras`) selects the runtime.

Endpoint	Behaviour
`GET /health`	public: `{"status":"ok","model_name":"L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard","model_version":"2","threshold":0.771}`
`POST /predict`	header `X-API-Key` and multipart field `image`. Returns `{label, p_ai, confidence, threshold, model_version, latency_ms, filename, sha256}`; 401 without a valid key, 400 for wrong or undecodable files, 413 over 4 MB

Protection. - The key is checked with `hmac.compare_digest`, a constant-time comparison. - It is stored as an **encrypted Vercel environment variable** (`vercel env add`), piped in from my untracked `.env`, so it is in no file and no commit. - The API **refuses to start without a key**.

Model delivery. The TFLite file is bundled into the deployment, built from the registry champion via `export_champion.py` and then `export_tflite.py`. It loads **once per function instance**, in about 1 s instead of 37 s for Keras. Serving never calls DagsHub.

Mapping the Compose elements to Vercel:

Compose element	Vercel equivalent
image / `build:`	Vercel builds the function from `deploy/vercel` (`requirements.txt` without TF + `app.py`, Flask framework preset)
service container	serverless function from `app.py` (WSGI `app`); the Flask preset routes every path to it
`environment:` / `.env`	project environment variables (encrypted `MODEL_API_KEY`; defaults for threshold and limit)
`ports:`	HTTPS domain `l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app`
`HEALTHCHECK`	`/health`, plus Vercel's own deployment status
volume for the model	model bundled into the deployment (`includeFiles`)
`db` + `pgdata`	stays on localhost with Flask (Vercel has no persistent disk)

7.4 Deployment, step by step

The commands are in RUNBOOK §7a. 1. Sign up on Vercel with GitHub, then run `npx vercel login`. 2. `python -m scripts.export_tflite`, then `python -m scripts.check_tflite_parity`. 3. `python -m scripts.build_vercel`. It copies `serving/`, `api/main.py` (as `api_core/`) and the model into `deploy/vercel/`. 4. In `deploy/vercel`, run `npx vercel link --project l230518-a2-ops-api`. 5. `npx vercel env add MODEL_API_KEY production`, with the value piped from `.env`. 6. `npx vercel deploy --prod`. The build takes about 50 s and the public alias is `l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app` (Figure 7.4a). 7. Check the environment variables (Figure 7.4b) and the request logs (Figure 7.4c).

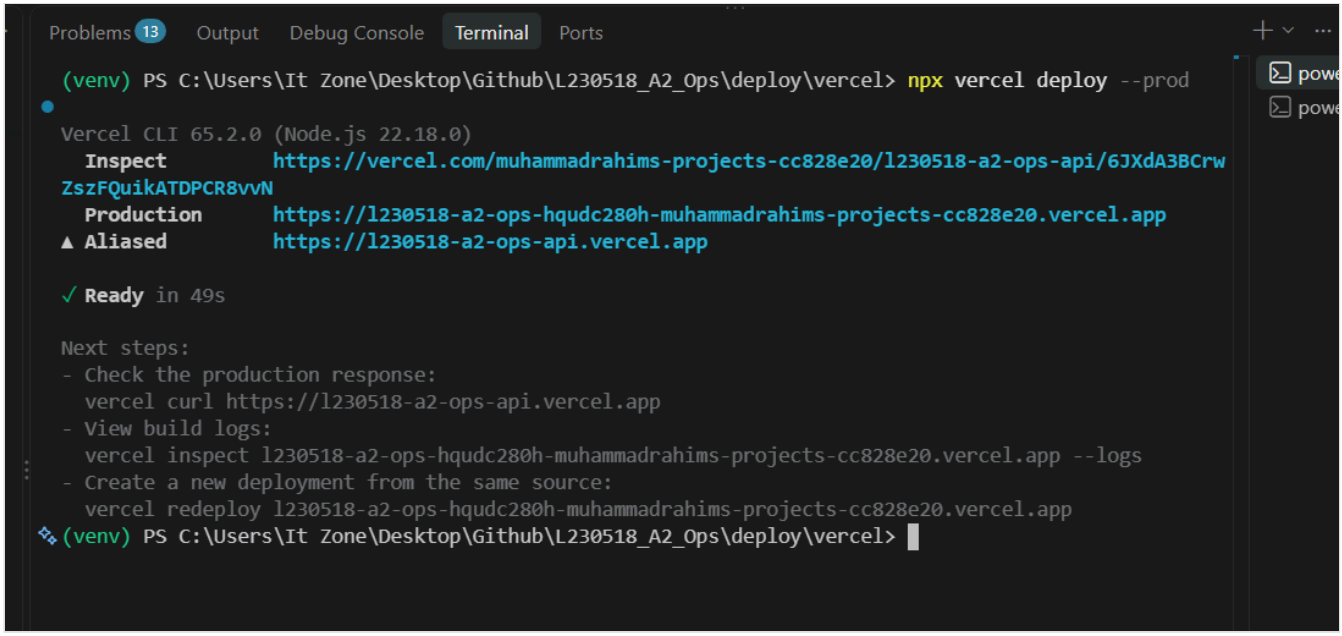


Figure 7.4a – production deployment ready, aliased to l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app

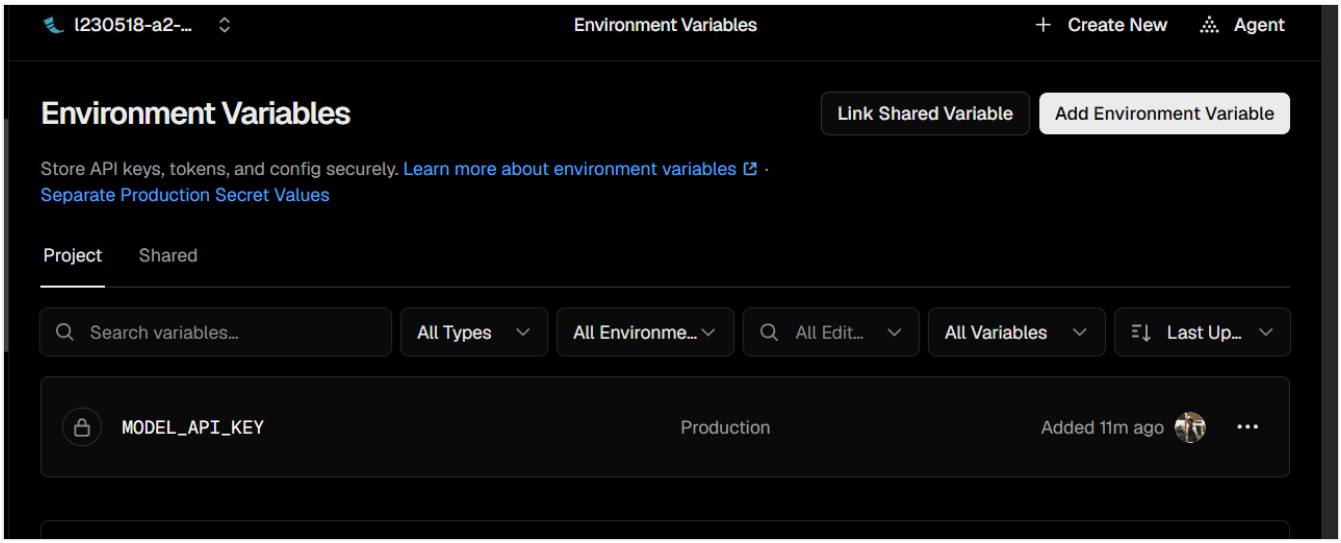


Figure 7.4b – MODEL_API_KEY stored as an encrypted production variable

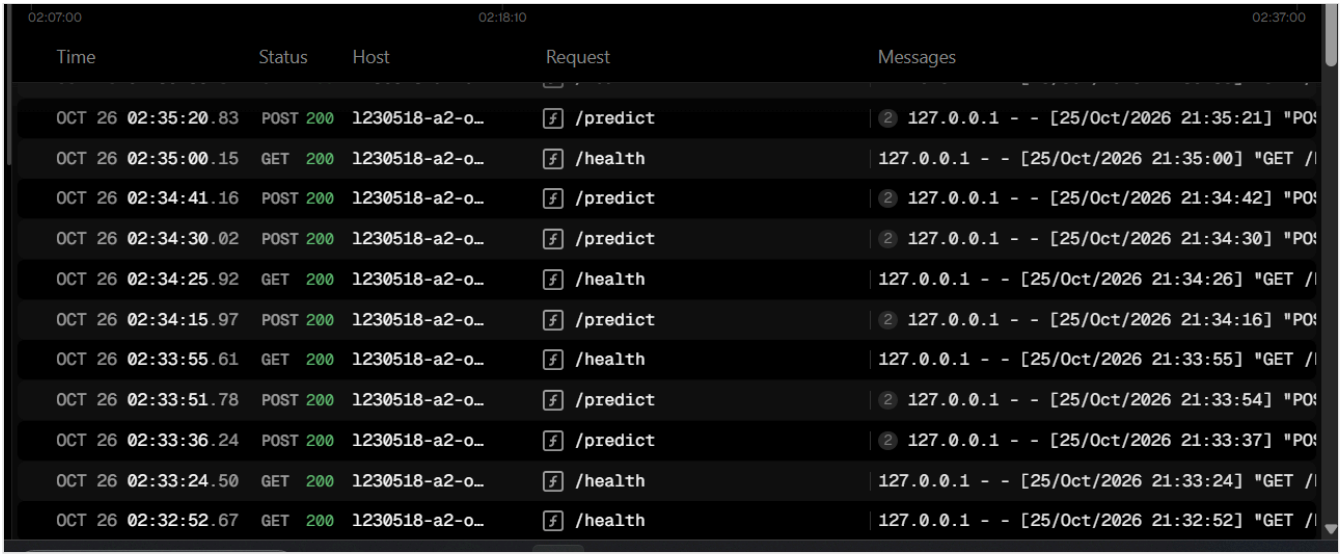


Figure 7.4c – Vercel request logs: /health and /predict calls from my Flask app, all 200

API URL: https://l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app (`/health` , `/predict`).

Responses from the deployed API, called with curl:

```
GET  /health                    200
{"model_name":"L230518_A2_Ops_VisionGuard","model_version":"2","status":"ok","threshold":0.771}
POST /predict  (key, AI image)   200 {"label":"AI-
generated","p_ai":0.9994,"confidence":0.9994,"latency_ms":68.5,...}
POST /predict  (key, real photo) 200 {"label":"Real","p_ai":0.0468,"confidence":0.9532,"latency_ms":443.3,...}
POST /predict  (no key)          401 {"error":"missing or invalid X-API-Key"}
POST /predict  (key, .txt)       400 {"error":"Unsupported file type '.txt'. Please upload a JPG or PNG image."}
```

Postman test from another network. I switched my laptop from home Wi-Fi to **mobile data**, so the requests came from a different network, then called the API from Postman:

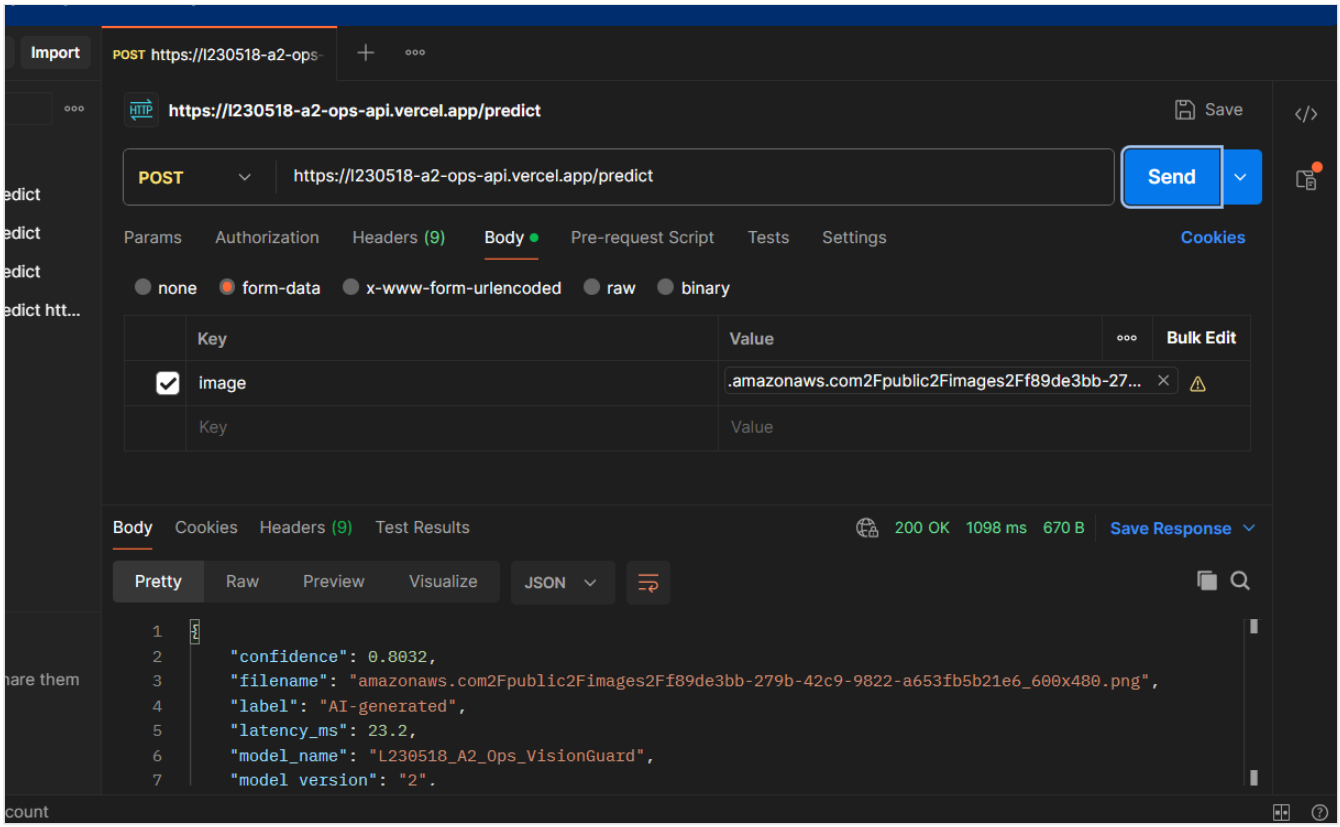


Figure 7.4d – POST /predict with the key and an AI image: 200 OK, label AI-generated, p(AI) 0.803, model v2

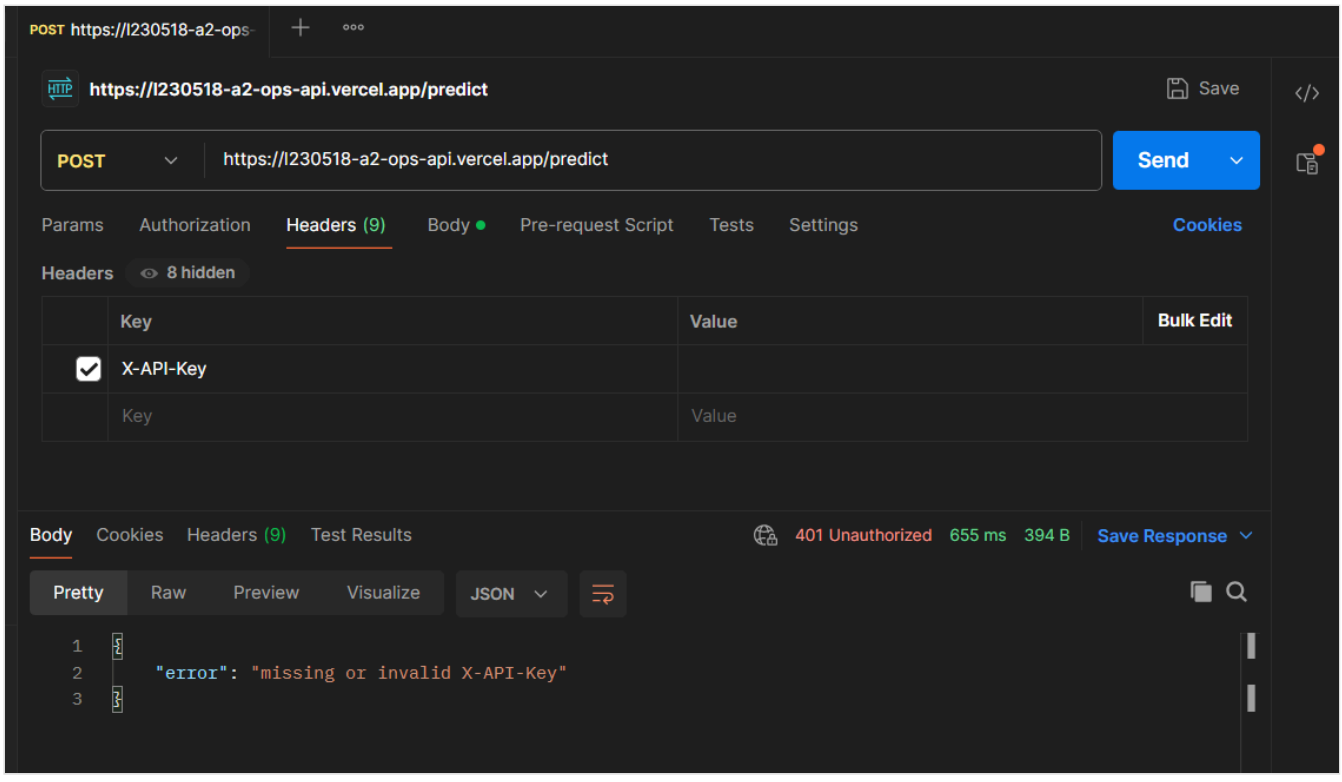


Figure 7.4e – the same request with an empty X-API-Key: 401 Unauthorized

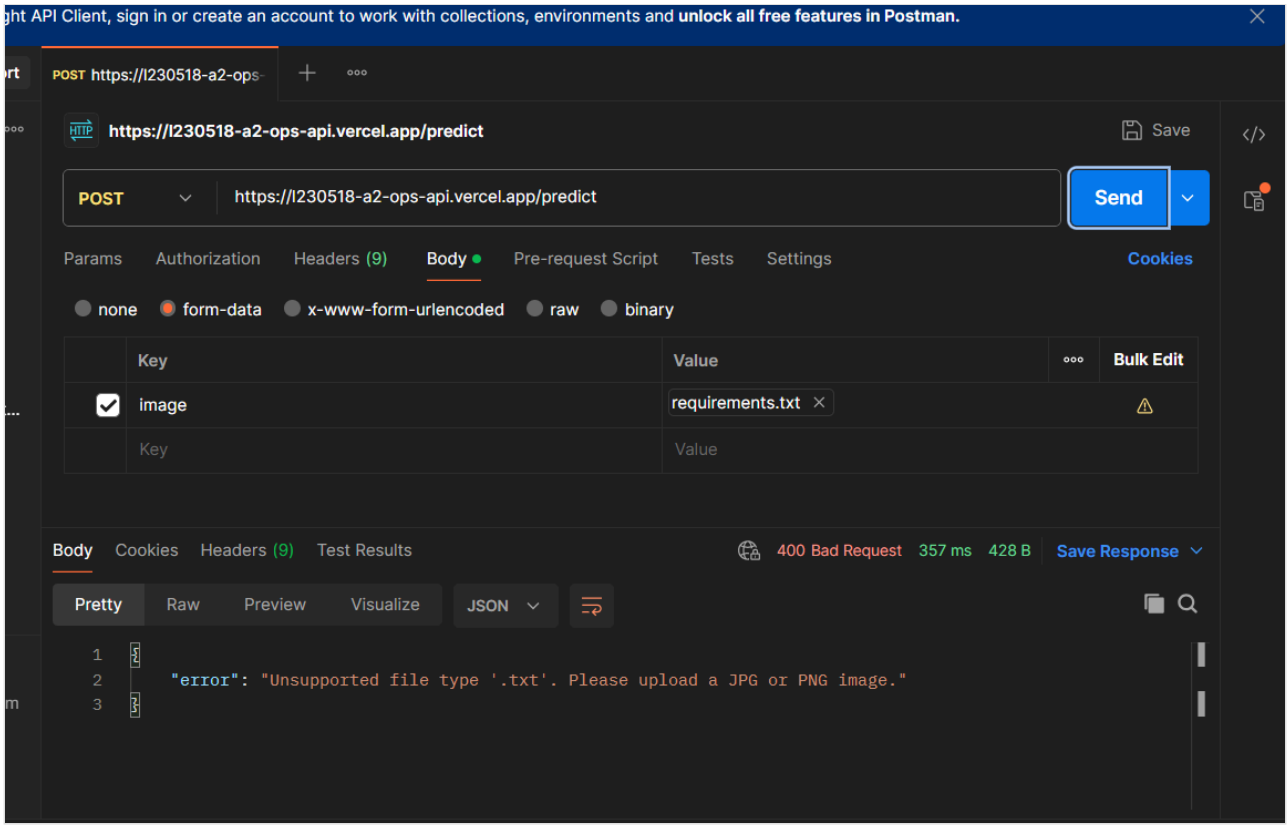


Figure 7.4f – a .txt file with a valid key: 400 Bad Request, "Unsupported file type"

My first Postman call returned **404** (Figure 7.4g). The URL I had pasted ended in an invisible line break (the ↵ after `predict`), so Postman requested `/predict%0A`. I reproduced it with curl: the clean URL answers normally, while `/predict%0A` returns exactly that 404. Retyping the URL fixed it.

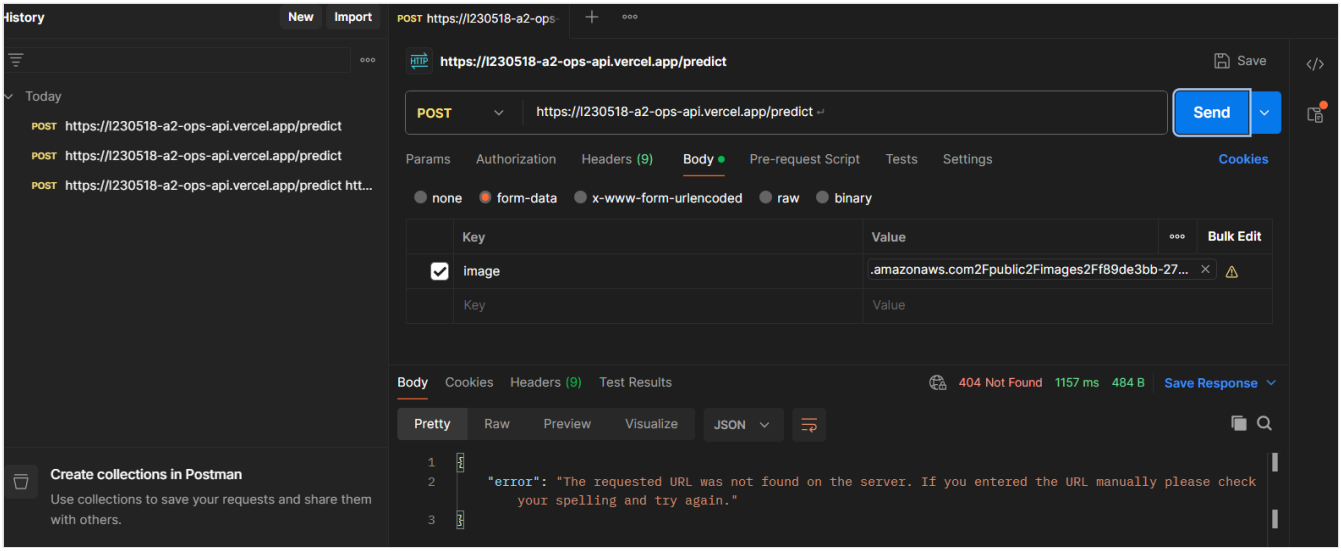


Figure 7.4g – the 404 caused by a pasted line break at the end of the URL

7.5 Limits and what went wrong

- **Two failed providers.** Google billing and Azure sign-in both failed. Because the API is an ordinary Flask app configured only through environment variables, moving between providers changed no application code.
- **Upload limit.** Vercel's 4.5 MB body limit forced the API limit down to 4 MB. In remote mode the web app also uses `MAX_UPLOAD_MB=4`, so users get the friendly 413 page locally instead of an opaque error from Vercel.
- **Routing bug on the first deploy** (Figure 7.5). I first used an `api/index.py` function with a `vercel.json` rewrite of `/(.*)` to `/api/index`. Every call returned Flask's 404, `/health` included. The Vercel logs showed `requestPath:`

`/health`, while Flask itself received `GET /api/index`, because the rewrite replaces the path the WSGI app sees. I switched to Vercel's Flask framework preset (`app.py` at the root, no rewrites), which forwards the original path.

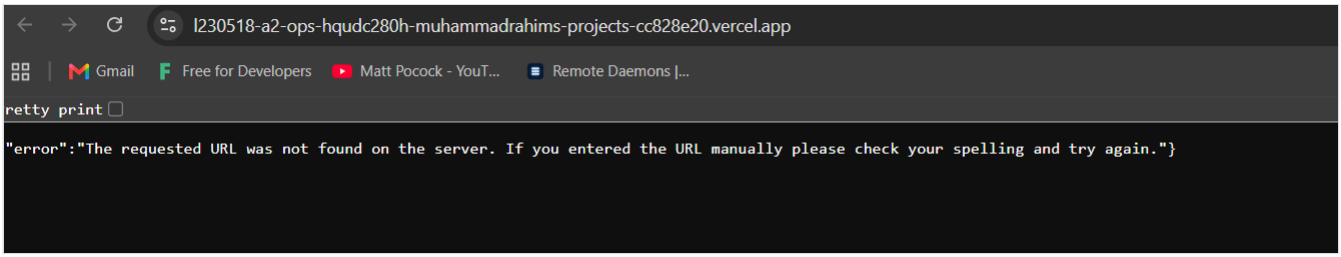


Figure 7.5 – first deploy: every path answered with Flask's 404

- **Cold starts.** The first request after idle starts a new function instance and loads the model (about 1–3 s).
- **Different runtime.** The deployed model is the TFLite conversion, not the `.keras` file. The parity check in 7.2 is the evidence that it makes the same decisions.

7.6 Alternative: Azure Container Apps (full TensorFlow container)

`Dockerfile.api` packages the same API with full TensorFlow and the Keras model built in, for container platforms. RUNBOOK §7b has the Azure Container Apps commands (`az acr build`, then `az containerapp create` with `--secrets` and `secretref:`). If I regain access to my Azure for Students account before submission, I will deploy there too. Switching the Flask app over only means changing `MODEL_API_URL`.

Compose element	Azure equivalent
image	Azure Container Registry `l230518a2ops`, image `api:v2`
service	Container App `l230518-a2-ops-api` (1 vCPU, 2 GiB, 0–1 replicas)
`.env`	`--env-vars` + Container Apps secret for `MODEL_API_KEY`
`ports:`	external HTTPS ingress → target port 8080

Chapter 8: Integrating Flask and the API

How it works. - The Flask app keeps running on **localhost** in Docker Compose, with Postgres beside it. - With `INFERENCE_MODE=remote`, `app/predictors.py::RemotePredictor`: - keeps one `requests.Session` with the `X-API-Key` header set; - POSTs the validated image bytes to `MODEL_API_URL/predict`, with a 30 s timeout that is enough for a cold start; - stores the returned decision in the database with `mode='remote'`. - If the API is unreachable or returns an error, the user sees a friendly 503 page and nothing wrong is logged as a decision. - `/health` also reports whether the cloud API is reachable and which model version it serves.

Why this design. - The same web code runs both ways; only environment variables change. - The heavy model runs in the cloud. - The database and the UI stay local, as the task asks.

Demonstration. 1. I set `INFERENCE_MODE=remote` and `MODEL_API_URL=https://l230518-a2-ops-api.vercel.app` in `.env`, then ran `docker compose up -d --force-recreate web`. 2. My first `curl /health` came back "Empty reply from server" (Figure 8.1). That was simply too early, because waitress was not listening yet. 3. Once the container was healthy, `/health` reported `inference_mode: remote` and `model_api_status: ok` (Figure 8.2).

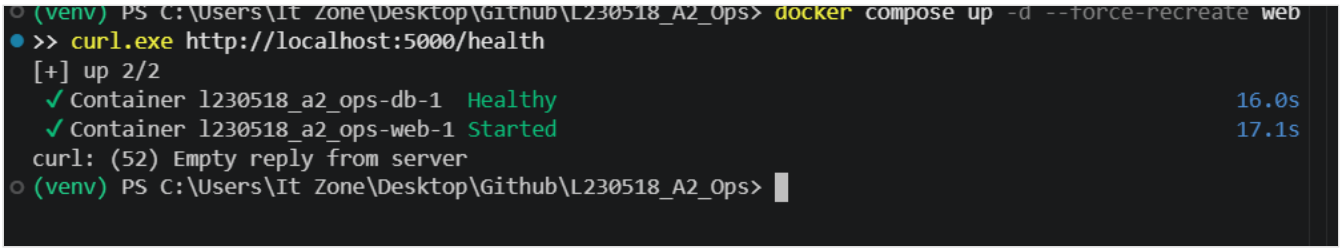


Figure 8.1 – curl before the web container finished starting



Figure 8.2 – health check in remote mode: database ok, cloud model API ok, model v2

I then uploaded six different images through the local UI (rows 5–10). Each one was sent to Vercel, classified, and logged in Postgres with `mode=remote`:

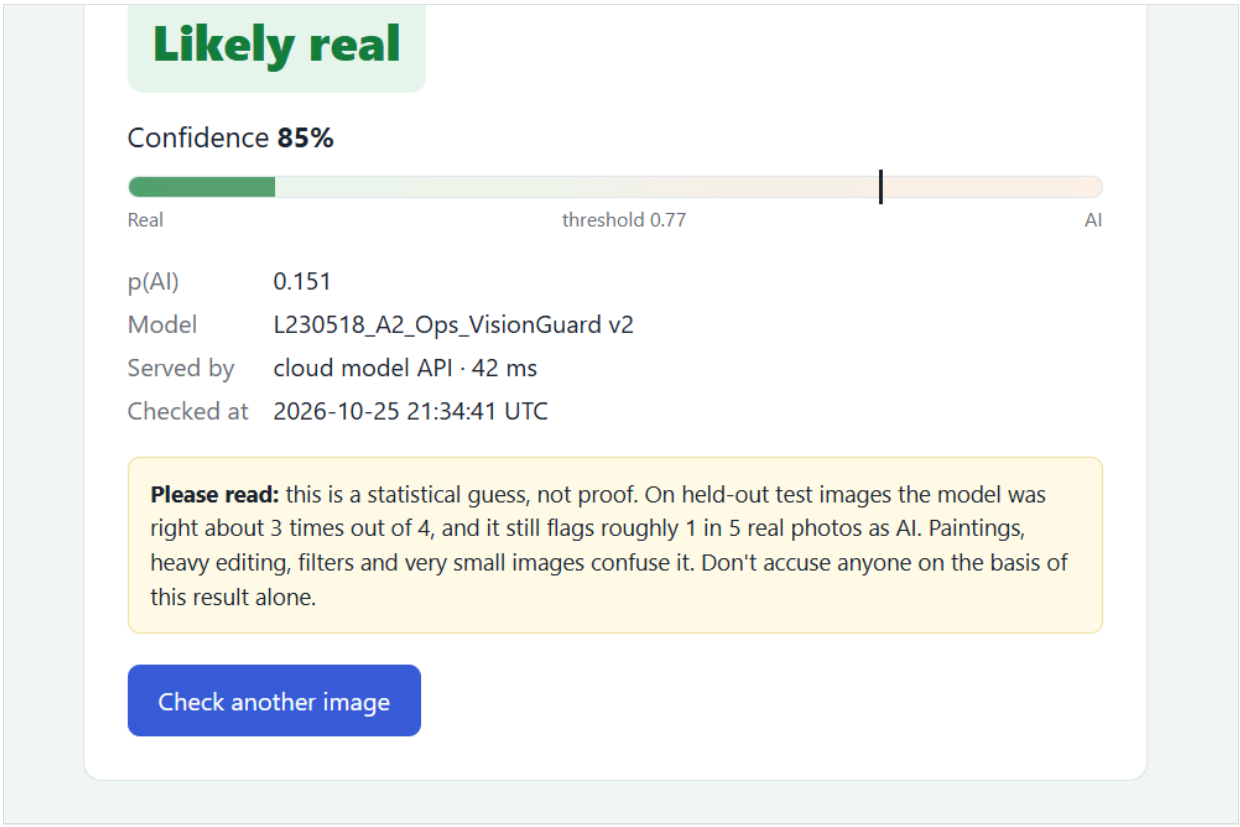


Figure 8.3 – result served by the cloud API: real photo, p(AI) = 0.151, 42 ms

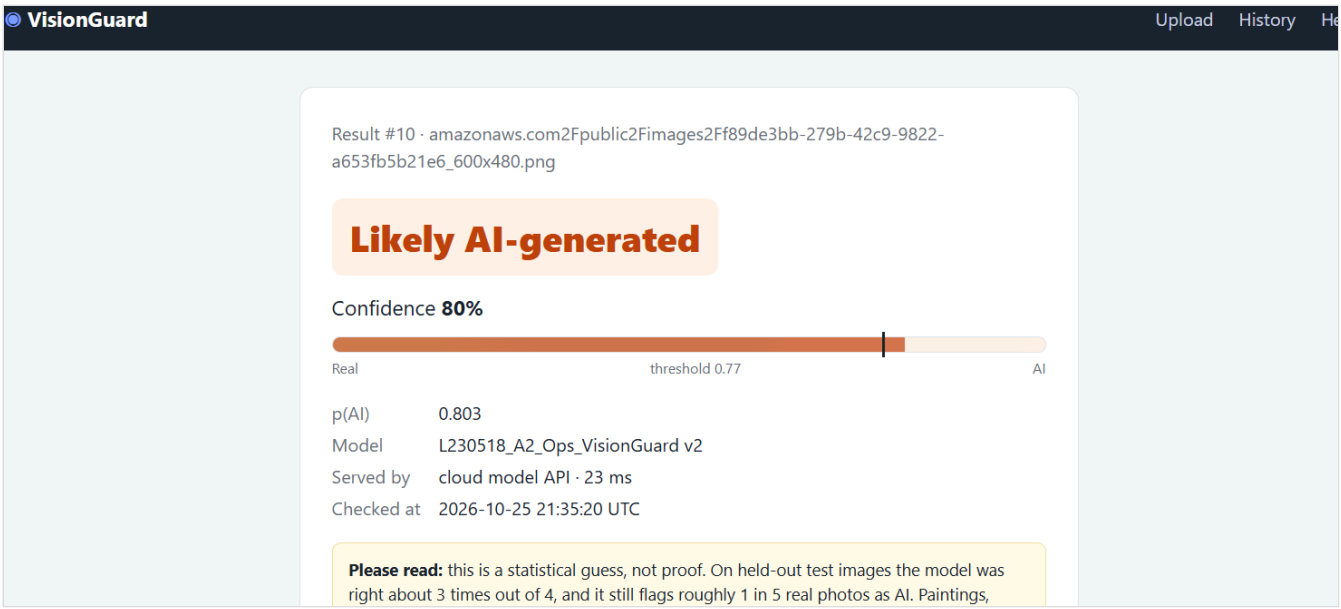


Figure 8.4 – result served by the cloud API: AI image (PNG), p(AI) = 0.803, 23 ms

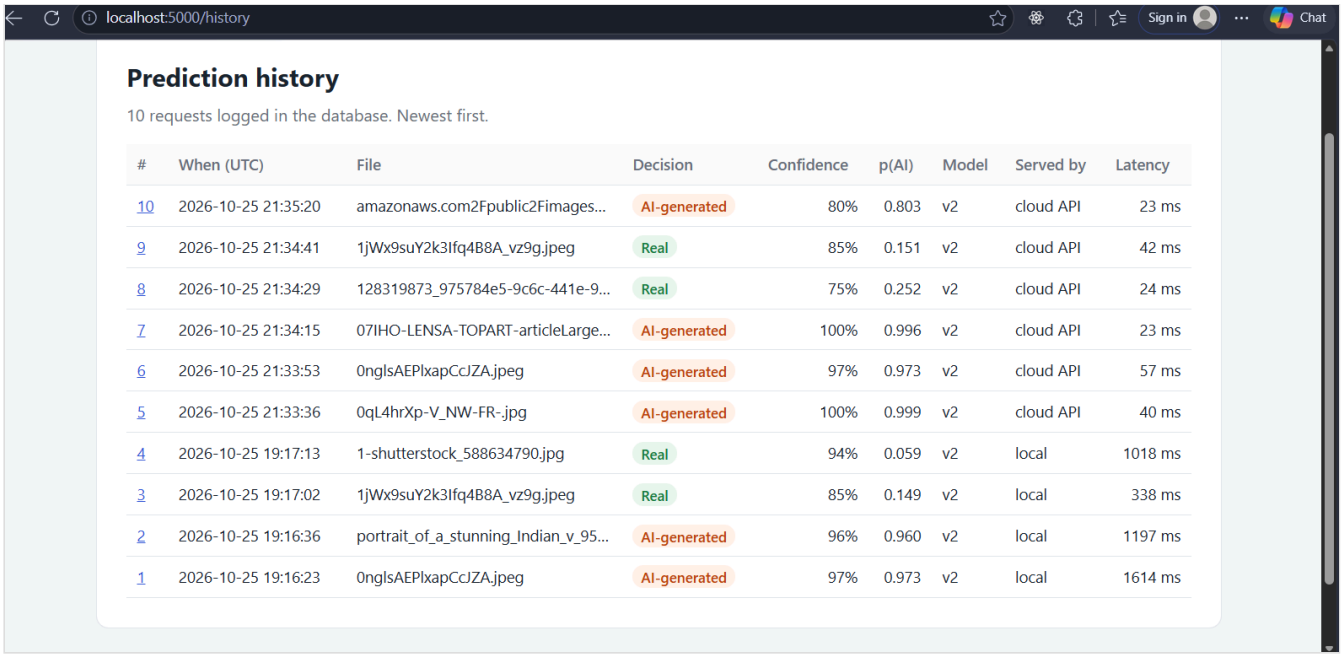


Figure 8.5 – history: rows 1–4 by the local model, rows 5–10 by the cloud API

What the history shows: - The same image was classified both ways. `0nglsAEPlxapCcJZA.jpeg` got 0.973 locally (row 1) and 0.973 in the cloud (row 6). `1jWx9suY2k3Ifq4B8A_vz9g.jpeg` got 0.149 vs 0.151 (rows 3 and 9). This is the TFLite parity from 7.2, confirmed on new images. - Cloud predictions take 23–57 ms of model time, against 0.3–1.6 s locally, where Keras runs on my laptop CPU. - The matching `/predict` calls appear in the Vercel request logs (Figure 7.4c).

A wrong file in remote mode gets the same friendly 400 page (Figure 8.6). Validation runs locally *before* anything is sent to the cloud, so invalid uploads never cost an API call.

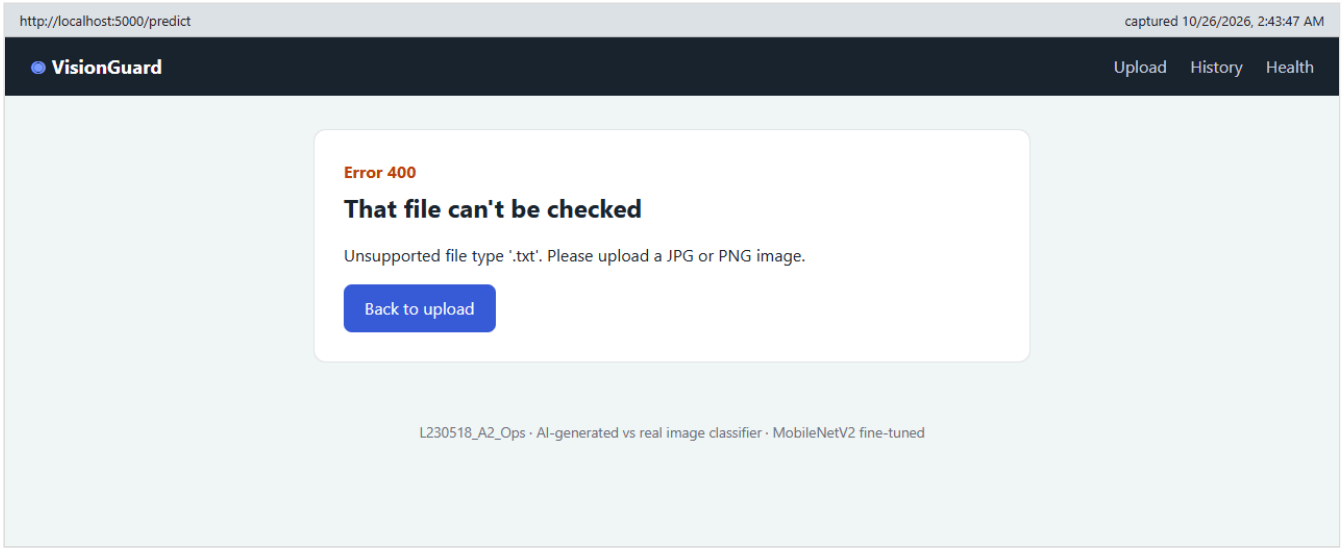


Figure 8.6 – remote mode: a .txt upload is rejected locally

Chapter 9: Summary and what I learned

Task	Status
1 Data and DVC	✓
2 Models, evaluation, tuner	✓ (+ Grad-CAM bonus)
3 MLflow / DagsHub / registry	✓
4 Flask app	✓
5 Database	✓
6 Docker / Compose / CI	✓
7 Cloud API (Vercel, TFLite)	✓
8 Integration	✓

Key lessons: 1. **Measure the threshold, don't assume 0.5.** The business cost of false alarms moved it to 0.771. 2. **Share one preprocessing function** between training and serving. 3. **Load the model once.** 37 s vs 0.3 s. 4. **A small validation set makes "best run" noisy.** That is why the test set is used once, at the very end. 5. **The dataset's "real" class contains paintings and edited images**, and the model learned style as a shortcut. A better dataset would be the most valuable next step.